Kindness

Dane E. Rose

Contents

———

Introduction....4
Prism....6
Chapter One: Ten Dimes....11
Chapter Two: Radios....25
Chapter Three: A Year's Wages....40
Chapter Four: Trays of Sandwiches....51
Chapter Five: The White Chickens....65
Chapter Six: Thirteen....78
Chapter Seven: Mentionable....92
Chapter Eight: The Bullhorn....106
Chapter Nine: Lard....120
Chapter Ten: The Brown Envelope....135
Chapter Eleven: The Missing Page....149
Chapter Twelve: Two Weeks Before Christmas....163
Chapter Thirteen: Sunlight on Clouds....176
Chapter Fourteen: Ninety-Seven Miles....191
Chapter Fifteen: The Mark....205
Chapter Sixteen: Escort....218
Chapter Seventeen: Railway....228
Chapter Eighteen: They Need Praying For....242
Chapter Nineteen: Corn....256
Chapter Twenty: Wooden Feet....267
Chapter Twenty-One: Squeeze My Hands....281
Chapter Twenty-Two: The Kitchen Table....295
Chapter Twenty-Three: A Sad Sweet Feeling....305
Chapter Twenty-Four: A Window....319
Chapter Twenty-Five: Ode....333

Chapter Twenty-Six: Seven Names.....342
Chapter Twenty-Seven: Earthrise.....356
Thirty-Five Kindnesses.....371
Meta.....376
Afterword.....386
Acknowledgments.....392
A Note on Sources.....393
About the Author.....394

Introduction

———

I had lived through a major trauma that had no place to land. When I spoke about it, the people around me moved on to other topics, and I felt outraged and completely disconnected from my culture. So I went to Thailand, a country I knew to be kinder and softer than most in the world.

There I wandered, in pain and in a compulsive state, staying up late until I collapsed in exhaustion. In my wanderings I found a small village shop with a dusty concrete floor, where children came barefoot for their daily supplies. A woman tended the shop with her small dog. I would sit in her chair and play with the dog, and sometimes, without a word of English, she placed her hands on my head and gave me a few minutes of massage between customers.

These were the happiest moments of a life buckling under mind-numbing pain. There was no pretense and no rank. A dog and a woman in a tin hut selling one-dollar snacks to the village children meant everything to me because they were kind: no money, no agenda, no speech. She simply saw my face and offered me small doses of relief. I could not find that in the finest hotels. I stayed for months, because I knew of nowhere else that felt as simple and kind as

that little shop, where no language was exchanged. I felt more at home there than in my own house or my own country.

Later I bought a dog from the place where she had bought hers and gave it to another trauma survivor I had met, to keep her company. The kindness spread.

That shop taught me the priceless power of small acts of kindness, and how rare and valuable they are. Years later, strolling across the UC Berkeley campus, I saw faces like the one I had carried into that shop. I asked GPT about the levels of depression and disconnection among students, and they ran high. I decided to write this book as a small, simple act of kindness.

Dane E. Rose

Prism

———

Every color

"*But the most surprising, and wonderful composition was that of Whiteness.*" — Isaac Newton, letter to the Royal Society on light and colours, 1672

In the summer of 1665 the plague came to Cambridge, and the university sent its young men home.

In London it had been killing for months. Houses where the sickness had been found were shut for forty days with the families inside, a red cross painted on the door and beneath it the words *Lord have mercy upon us.* When it reached Cambridge, the colleges emptied.

One of the students who left was a sizar of Trinity College named Isaac Newton. He was twenty-two, a farmer's son who had never known his father, and he went back to the stone farmhouse at Woolsthorpe in Lincolnshire where he had been born, with his books and his notebooks, to wait out the dying.

Long afterward, an old man by then and famous across Europe, he wrote about those months. *All this was in the two plague years of 1665 and 1666*, he

said, *for in those days I was in the prime of my age for invention.*

◆ ◆ ◆

He had been thinking about light for some time. The room where he did what he described next is not certain; he wrote only that it was *in the beginning of the Year 1666*.

I procured me a Triangular glass-Prisme, to try therewith the celebrated Phaenomena of Colours. And in order thereto having darkened my chamber, and made a small hole in my window-shuts, to let in a convenient quantity of the Suns light, I placed my Prisme at his entrance, that it might be thereby refracted to the opposite wall.

Picture it. A young man in a room with the shutters closed against the day. A single round hole lets in one thread of sunlight, so bright it seems almost solid, with the dust turning slowly inside it. He lifts a wedge of glass into that thread, and on the far wall, where a pale spot of sun had been, there is suddenly a band of colour.

◆ ◆ ◆

After a while applying my self to consider them more circumspectly, he went on, *I became surprised to see them in an oblong form; which, according to the received laws of Refraction, I expected should have been circular.*

The hole was round. The sun was round. Instead the spot was stretched into a long strip, about five times

as long as it was broad. Something in the light itself was being pulled apart.

Since Aristotle, learned people had agreed that sunlight was pure and simple, and that colours were what happened to light when it was spoiled, bent and stained by glass. The prism, in this view, did not reveal colours. It made them.

Newton set a second prism in the path of a single colour. If the glass manufactured colour, it should have spread that beam into a new rainbow. It did not. The red went through and came out red. The blue went through and came out blue, only bent more steeply than the red had been. He called this his *Experimentum Crucis*, the experiment of the crossroads.

The colours were not made by the glass. They had been in the sunlight all along, travelling together so closely that no one had ever seen them apart.

◆ ◆ ◆

Then he ran it backwards.

He gathered the spread of colours with a lens and brought them together again into one place. Where they met, the band of red and orange and yellow and green and blue and violet vanished, and in its place was a spot of plain white light, like the sun on the wall before the prism was ever lifted.

I have often with Admiration beheld, he wrote to the Royal Society, *that all the Colours of the Prisme being made to converge, and thereby to be again mixed as they were in the light before it was*

Incident upon the Prisme, reproduced light, intirely and perfectly white.

White was not the simplest colour. It was the fullest. It was every colour at once.

◆ ◆ ◆

Years later, in *Opticks*, he bent the long straight strip of colours into a circle.

On his circle the red end and the violet end, which on the wall had been as far apart as they could be, came round and touched. The more colours he mixed, and the more evenly, the closer their balance moved toward the middle. At the centre of the circle, where everything balanced, was white.

Where the ends met, he lit a square of white paper with red light and violet light together, and it appeared, he wrote, *all over purple*. That colour is not in the spectrum. No single ray of sunlight carries it. Magenta is what the eye and mind paint where red and violet reach for each other across the gap.

◆ ◆ ◆

Black has its own two lives.

In light, black is what we see when no light reaches the eye at all. It is the room with the shutter closed and the hole stopped up, the darkness Newton sat in before he let the sun in.

In paint it is the opposite. Mix enough pigments together and the colours swallow each other's light until we call it black. White light is every colour given back. Black paint is every colour taken in.

◆ ◆ ◆

Newton lived to be eighty-four. He kept, all his life, the habit of a young man in a shuttered room, testing what everybody already knew to see whether it was so.

Somewhere today, in a classroom with the blinds pulled down, a teacher is setting a glass prism on a desk in the path of a projector beam. The children lean forward. On the wall a band of colour appears, red at one end and violet at the other, and someone laughs out loud. Then the teacher holds up a lens, and the colours run back together, and on the wall there is a single round spot of light, quiet and white, with everything in it.

Chapter One

Ten Dimes

———

Crimson

"I can't do everything, but I can do something to help somebody. And what I can do I will do."
— Oseola McCarty, quoted in the University of Southern Mississippi News

◆◆◆

The first job was a dress, and the price was ten cents.

A schoolteacher in Hattiesburg, Mississippi, asked a small girl what she would charge to wash and iron it, and the girl said a dime. When she brought the dress back, clean and pressed, the teacher paid her a quarter. The girl was Oseola McCarty, and years later she still remembered that extra fifteen cents.

She had been born on March 7, 1908, near Shubuta, in Wayne County, the only child of a woman named Lucy McCarty. Around 1916 the family moved to Hattiesburg, bringing with them a big black cast-iron pot. In the yard of their small frame house they filled the pots with water carried from a hydrant down the street, boiled the clothes, rinsed them, and hung them on the line. The child started on the

small things, socks and handkerchiefs, standing on a wooden box so she could reach.

The coins she earned went somewhere private. Someone had given her an old doll buggy, and under its pink lining she began to tuck her dimes and nickels and quarters.

◆◆◆

She went to the Little Red School House, later called Eureka School, and she liked it. She had a picture of her future. She wanted to be a nurse.

In the sixth grade, her aunt came home from the hospital unable to walk. Someone had to stay with her, and someone had to keep the washing going, because the washing was the family's living. Oseola was the one who stayed. She always hoped to go back and finish, and she never returned to a classroom.

By then the doll buggy was getting heavy. One day she carried the coins to the bank, First Mississippi National, and dumped them on the counter. *I went to the bank and deposited*, she said in her old age. *Didn't know how to do it. Went there myself.* The accounts of that first visit differ a little: in some she went alone and told no one at home, in others a teller suggested she open a savings account rather than keep the money in checking. All the accounts agree on what happened next. She kept going back. Her rule was simple, and she stated it plainly: *I only went to the bank to put my change and dollar bills in, not to get them out.*

She did not think of saving as a sacrifice. She thought of it as a kind of good sense that anyone could have, rich or poor. *It's not the ones that make the big money*, she said, *but the ones who know how to save who get ahead.* For most of the twentieth century, the deposits she made were mostly dollar bills and change, carried in by hand, a few at a time.

◆◆◆

For the next seventy-five years she washed other people's clothes.

She worked in the yard behind the house, bending over a rubboard. In the 1960s she tried an automatic washer and dryer and went back to the pot and the board. *The washing machine didn't rinse enough*, she said, *and the dryer turned the whites yellow.* She charged two dollars and fifty cents for a bundle of laundry, and later, after the war, ten dollars a bundle. The work was heavy and hot and never finished, and she did not complain about it. *I loved to work*, she said, *and when you love to do anything, those things don't bother you.*

The family thinned around her. Her grandmother died in 1944. Her mother died in 1964. Her aunt died in 1967, and from then on, for the last thirty-two years of her life, Oseola McCarty lived alone, in a house that had been passed down to her in the family. The accounts differ on whether it came from an uncle, in 1947, or from her aunt. She never married and had no children. She never owned a car. She walked nearly a mile to the grocery store and pushed the groceries home in a shopping cart.

Her Bible had come apart from use, and she had taped it back together. When a pair of shoes pinched, she cut the toes out and went on wearing them.

Her social life was her church and her Bible. She gave a tenth of what she earned, sending it to Friendship Baptist Church every month, and for decades the only check she ever wrote, by her own telling, was for a cedar chifforobe that cost forty dollars. Bankers advised her over the years to move her savings into certificates of deposit and conservative funds, and she did. The banks merged and changed their names. The dimes grew.

It would be easy to call this a hard life. She did not. *I knew there were people who didn't have to work as hard as I did*, she said, *but it didn't make me feel sad.* And another time, more simply: *My secret was contentment. I was happy with what I had.* She liked to say that work was a blessing, and that as long as she was living she wanted to be working at something.

◆◆◆

In December of 1994, when she was eighty-six, her hand began to swell. Arthritis had found the joints that had wrung out other people's shirts since the First World War. She could no longer do the work, and she put it down.

The people at Trustmark National Bank, which held most of her money by then, knew her well. They knew she had saved far more than anyone would have guessed from the woman with the shopping

cart; when she retired, her savings came to about $280,000. An assistant vice president there named Paul Laughlin sat down with her to talk about what should happen to it after she was gone.

Ebony later reported that an attorney who had once been one of her laundry customers helped her plan the gift as well. But it was the banker's method she remembered. He did not use charts. He took ten dimes and spread them out on the table. Each dime, he told her, stood for ten percent of everything she had. She could move them wherever she wanted.

She moved one dime to her church. She moved one each to three relatives. The other six she pushed to one side for a college.

The college was the University of Southern Mississippi, there in Hattiesburg, a school she had never set foot on. It had admitted its first two Black students only in September 1965, when she was already fifty-seven years old. Her reason for the gift was the one she gave everyone who asked: *I want to help some child go to college.* Or, in her slightly longer version, she wanted *to give some child the opportunity I did not have.* She signed an irrevocable trust. The bank would manage the money and send her a regular check to live on, and at her death the university's share, about $150,000, would go to a scholarship fund for students who could not otherwise afford to come, with preference for Black students from southern Mississippi. *I made the decision on my own to give the school the money*, she said. *Mr. Paul gives me a check, and I can get money anytime I need it.* Asked how she felt

about it, she put it in terms of work, which was the language she trusted most. *I am proud that I worked hard*, she said, *and that my money will help young people who worked hard to deserve it.*

◆◆◆

The gift was announced in July 1995. The next month a reporter for The New York Times, Rick Bragg, came to see her and wrote a sentence that people would quote for decades: *Oseola McCarty spent a lifetime making other people look nice.* The story was among the work for which Bragg won the Pulitzer Prize for feature writing the following year.

By the reckoning of Ebony magazine that year, it was the largest gift a Black donor had ever made to a university in Mississippi. It had been assembled out of bundles of laundry at two dollars and fifty cents, and later ten.

The response began almost at once, and it began close to home. Business leaders in Hattiesburg pledged to match her gift. Letters and checks arrived from strangers, one of them for $10,000 from a man in Houston. Some of the well-off families whose clothes she had washed for decades were reported to be working to match what their washerwoman had given. Over the next four years more than six hundred people from more than thirty states gave to the Oseola McCarty Scholarship. Under the trust, the university would receive nothing until she died. The people running the new fund decided not to wait for that. With the money that strangers were sending in, they could start

awarding scholarships that very fall, and they wanted her to see, with her own eyes, what her money would do.

The first student chosen was an eighteen-year-old Hattiesburg honors graduate named Stephanie Bullock. Her mother, Leedrester Bullock, was a schoolteacher. Stephanie had a twin brother who was starting at Jones County Junior College that same fall, and two tuitions at once had made the family's figures very tight. Stephanie had been praying about it. Then the telephone rang, and a voice told her she would be the first person ever to receive an Oseola McCarty Scholarship: one thousand dollars a year, renewable as long as her grades held, at a university whose yearly tuition was then about $2,400.

At first, I was really surprised and shocked, Stephanie said that year, *but now I am very proud.*

She was not the last. In 1996 a second student, Carletta Barnes, received a thousand-dollar scholarship paid from the fund's interest. Within a couple of years, the gifts of strangers had pushed the fund past $200,000, and the interest alone was paying for four full scholarships of $2,400 each. McCarty began to speak of a new dream. She wanted to live long enough to see Stephanie and Carletta graduate.

That August, Oseola McCarty went onto the campus for the first time in her life. About a thousand people stood and applauded her. A young woman came toward her through the people. *A lovely young girl*

ran up and threw her arms around me, McCarty remembered. It was Stephanie. *She is great*, Stephanie said afterward. *I gave her a big hug and thanked her.* The two of them adopted each other on the spot. *Now I feel like I've got a granddaughter*, said the woman who had no children.

◆◆◆

Then the world arrived, all at once and from every direction.

President Bill Clinton presented her with the Presidential Citizens Medal. Harvard gave her an honorary doctorate. All told, she was given more than a hundred and fifty awards. In December 1996 she pressed the switch that sent the ball down in Times Square on New Year's Eve, the washerwoman from Hattiesburg counting down the year for the crowds below.

On the evening of September 18, 1997, at a dinner of the United Nations Association in New York, Ted Turner, then vice-chairman of Time Warner, announced that he would give one billion dollars to support the work of the United Nations, for refugees, for children, for clearing landmines. In the years since, a sentence has been attributed to him again and again, said to have been printed in The New York Times, about the woman in Hattiesburg: *If that little woman can give away everything she has, then I can give a billion.* The original interview is hard to trace, and he gave other reasons for the gift as well. But the line has followed both their names ever since. Her story had been told in nearly every

newspaper and talk show in the country in the two years before he stood up at that dinner.

◆ ◆ ◆

Fame had a cost, and she paid some of it in miles. In the first year after the gift she traveled to New York five times and to Washington three times, and to five other cities besides. This was a woman who had made one long trip in her life before, to Niagara Falls and Chicago, and who had come home remembering that *the sound of the water was like the sound of the world coming to an end.* Now she was crossing the country and sitting under studio lights in her late eighties, with hands that hurt. In hotel rooms that other people had paid for, she made her bed before she checked out.

Not everyone was pleased. Some Black residents of Hattiesburg asked why her money had gone to a university that had kept Black students out within living memory, rather than to a historically Black college. She had her own view of the place. *They used to not let colored people go out there*, she is reported to have said, *but now they do.* The scholarship would help make sure they did.

Friends worried that the attention would wear her out. She disagreed. *I'm not tired of it, as long as I'm able*, she said. *I used to wouldn't talk*, she told the campus newspaper. Now she felt, in her words, *more braver.* The woman who had spent most of her life in a backyard with a rubboard, whose world had been her work and her church, had found at eighty-seven that she liked being asked what she thought.

In Memphis, Baptist Memorial Hospital gave her a nursing cap and an honorary diploma, more than seventy years after a sixth-grader had put that dream away to look after her aunt.

Wherever she went, people asked her the same question. Why hadn't she spent the money on herself? She gave the same answer every time. *Thanks to the good Lord*, she said, *I am spending it on myself.*

The other question was whether she had any regrets. She had one, and she repeated it so often that it became the line people remember her by. *I don't regret one single penny I gave*, she said. *My only regret is that I didn't have more to give.*

◆◆◆

In 1998 the University of Southern Mississippi gave her the first honorary doctorate in its history. Of all the honors, it may have been the one closest to home. The school she had never visited until she was eighty-seven had now made her a doctor. She still had one wish left, and she said it out loud often enough that the people around her knew it by heart: she wanted to see Stephanie graduate.

Stephanie Bullock graduated in May 1999.

By then Oseola McCarty was ill with cancer. She died at home in Hattiesburg on September 26, 1999, at the age of ninety-one. The next day the President of the United States issued a statement calling her *a true American hero*, and saying that what she stood for, work and education and generosity, would outlast her. In the months after, the trust did what

the dimes had promised. Her share went to the university.

In April 2002 the university dedicated a residence hall in her name, so that every year hundreds of students would sleep under her name. Stephanie spoke at the ceremony. *Miss McCarty wanted to be a nurse and help educate others and impact lives*, she said. *Even though she didn't go to college, that's exactly what she did.*

In 2019 the little house where she had lived alone was moved and opened as a museum. In October 2020 the university unveiled a life-size bronze of her in the middle of the campus she first visited at eighty-seven. By then more than a hundred students from south Mississippi had gone through college with her help.

◆ ◆ ◆

On March 7, 2025, which would have been her 117th birthday, the university announced that the Oseola McCarty scholarship endowment had reached one million dollars. About 1,400 people had given to it over the years, most of them in amounts she would have recognized: a few dollars, a few hundred, a bundle of laundry's worth. By then 133 students had received McCarty Scholarships, and the fund could support twenty McCarty Scholars every year, with mentoring, career planning and lessons in managing money. The washerwoman who had once dumped a doll buggy's worth of coins on a bank counter would have understood the last part.

One of them, a recent nursing graduate named Destiny Johnson, explained what had kept her going. She had learned that Oseola McCarty once wanted to be a nurse and had given that up to care for a sick aunt. Johnson finished her nursing degree with that in mind. She called the gift *a game changer*, because it had given everyone else a reason to give too.

The head of the university's foundation, Stace Mercier, called the million dollars *a testament to the power of collective giving*, which was another way of saying that it had been built the way she built hers, a little at a time, by a great many hands.

Stephanie Bullock, now Stephanie Bullock Ferguson, was asked to speak again. She spoke about small amounts. The philosophy she had learned from her adopted grandmother, she said, was this: *Nothing's too small. Everything counts.*

Somewhere in Mississippi this morning, a young nurse is pulling on her scrubs before a shift. Her uniform was washed in a machine and dried in a dryer, and nobody had to carry the water from a hydrant down the street. She may not know whose dimes paid part of her way, or about the doll buggy with the pink lining, the black pot in the yard, or the banker who spread ten coins across a table. She is checking her watch, picking up her keys, and walking out the door to look after someone who cannot look after themselves, which is the work a girl in the sixth grade once stayed home to do.

> Side note: For more than thirty years, a man named Albert Lexie rode the bus to Children's Hospital of Pittsburgh every Tuesday and

Thursday, leaving home at 5:50 in the morning, to shine shoes in the hallways. He had built his first shoeshine box in shop class. Every tip he ever received went into the hospital's Free Care Fund, which helps families who cannot pay for their children's care. When he died in October 2018, at seventy-six, the tips came to more than $202,000.

Question: Who once gave you more than you asked for, the way a teacher paid a quarter for a ten-cent dress, and how did it change what you did next?

Question: What are three ways that what is happening could be kind?

Action: Spend five to twenty dollars today on someone who cannot repay you: a coffee for the

person behind you, a meal for a coworker, a book for a child. Afterward, write one sentence about how the feeling differs from the last time you spent the same amount on yourself.

Chapter Two

Radios

———

Scarlet

"*Whoever saves a single life is considered to have saved an entire world.*" — Mishnah, Sanhedrin 4:5

◆◆◆

Jan Zwartendijk sold radios.

The shop stood at number 29 on Laisvės alėja, Freedom Avenue, the long linden-lined boulevard that ran through the middle of Kaunas, then the capital of Lithuania. In the window were the latest Philips sets, walnut cabinets with glowing dials that named cities most people in Kaunas would never visit: London, Paris, Hilversum, Berlin. Upstairs, on a wood-panelled mezzanine, was his office, with its telephone. People in town called him Mr. Philips, as though he were the name printed on the dial.

He was forty-three that spring of 1940. He had been born in Rotterdam, one of identical twins, and had sold oil and grease in South America, in Prague, in Hamburg before Philips hired him.

His wife, Erna, whom everyone called Erni, had grown up speaking German in a small Austrian

town. They had three children: Edith, who was thirteen; Jan, who was eleven; and Robert, called Rob, born in Kaunas that previous September. The house stood on a hill above the city, with fruit trees in the garden and a flowering plum by the gate.

There is one detail of that household that matters more than all the rest, though no one could have known it at the time. Baby Rob had been born with a bright red birthmark across his nose, a swelling of blood vessels that his brother and sister teased him about. A Kaunas doctor recommended radiation therapy, which no one in Lithuania could provide. So every month that winter, Erni carried the baby onto a train, rode across Germany to the Netherlands, stayed overnight in a hotel, and took him to a cousin's hospital in Utrecht for treatment. In March 1940 the doctors gave him too much. His small nose was burned, and the treatments stopped.

Had they not stopped, Erni and the baby would have been in Utrecht in May, when Germany invaded the Netherlands, cut off from Jan and the older children by a war. Instead they were home in Kaunas, all five of them, when the telephone rang.

◆◆◆

On the tenth of May, Germany invaded the Netherlands. Four days later, German bombers flattened the center of Rotterdam. The street where Jan had grown up was gone. For days there was no news of his twin.

Nobody in Kaunas was buying radios in May 1940, though everybody was listening to them.

The Netherlands kept an honorary consul in Kaunas, a businessman named Herbert Tillmanns who had been educated in Berlin and who had told Jan, in conversation, that he believed in Hitler. After the invasion, a man who believed in Hitler could not be allowed to represent the country Hitler had just overrun. Tillmanns resigned.

On the evening of the twenty-ninth of May, as Jan was locking up the shop, the telephone rang upstairs. He climbed back up and answered it the way he always did: *Allô, Lietuvos Philips.*

It was the Dutch ambassador to the Baltic states, L. P. J. de Decker, calling from Riga. The Netherlands needed someone to represent it in Lithuania, and de Decker wanted Zwartendijk. The two men had met. The ambassador later explained his choice in a single sentence: *I know people, Zwartendijk. One look was enough.*

The job paid nothing. As far as anyone could tell, it consisted of stamping the occasional Dutch passport. Jan knew so little about it that he had to ask how a visa was issued at all.

He said yes.

Decades later, his daughter Edith, by then nearly ninety, stood in the old shop on Freedom Avenue with the writer Jan Brokken, who was researching her father's life, and pointed to the spot where the telephone had been. Everything, she said, began here, that evening in May.

◆ ◆ ◆

On the fifteenth of June, the Red Army rolled into Lithuania.

Kaunas held perhaps thirty thousand Jews. Yiddish was spoken in the shopping streets, and Jan bought his lunch most days from Jewish bakers and tea rooms. Since the previous autumn, ten thousand or more Jewish refugees from Poland had joined them, people who had fled east when the German army crossed the Polish border and had found, in small, independent Lithuania, a country that would let them in. They slept in schools and prayer houses and in rented rooms. Whole religious academies had arrived together, hundreds of students walking in with their teachers and their books.

Now the Soviets had come, and every refugee in Kaunas understood what that meant. The borders would close. Behind the Soviets, sooner or later, stood the Germans. To leave, a person needed a destination, and a destination required a visa, and in the summer of 1940 almost no country on earth would grant one to a Jew.

◆◆◆

The first person to bring the problem to the radio shop was a woman named Pessla Lewin, whom everyone called Peppy.

She had been born in 1911 and raised in Amsterdam, and she had studied at the University of Berlin, where she watched what the Nazis were doing to German Jews. When she married a Polish Jewish scholar named Isaac Lewin and moved with him to Łódź, she lost her Dutch citizenship. She

made her husband promise that if Germany ever invaded Poland, they would leave at once. In September 1939, they did. They crossed into Lithuania on foot through a forest at night, with their three-year-old son Nathan, who was told that if he made a sound, the wolves would come.

Her father had flown back to Amsterdam to look after the family business. He would later be murdered at Auschwitz.

In Kaunas, Peppy went to the new Dutch consul and asked for a visa to the Dutch East Indies. Zwartendijk told her he could not give her one. So she wrote over his head, to the ambassador in Riga.

De Decker refused her too. Then, in a second letter, he suggested something else. The Dutch islands in the Caribbean, Curaçao and its neighbors, had no visa requirement for entry. Admission was at the discretion of the island's governor, and the governor almost never granted it. But the first half of that sentence was true on its own. *Send me your passport*, he wrote.

On the eleventh of July, in Riga, de Decker wrote into Peppy Lewin's passport, in French, that no entry visa was required for Surinam, Curaçao, and the other Dutch possessions in the Americas. He left out the clause about the governor.

Eleven days later, on the twenty-second of July, her husband Isaac brought his own travel document to the radio shop. Jan Zwartendijk took out his fountain pen and copied the same sentence into it, word for word, and signed it.

That was the first.

◆ ◆ ◆

Within days another visitor came, a young Dutchman named Nathan Gutwirth, who had grown up near The Hague and come to Lithuania five years earlier to study at the famous yeshiva in the town of Telz. Gutwirth was a Dutch citizen and could travel. His friends at the yeshiva could not. Would the consul write the same sentence into their papers too?

A Polish refugee leader named Zorach Warhaftig, a lawyer who would one day serve as a minister in the government of Israel, pressed the idea further: a general notation, for anyone who asked. In his memoir after the war, Warhaftig described what they were doing in a single line. *Where no route existed, it was for us to create one, if only on paper, for the time being.*

Within hours there were dozens of people at the door of the radio shop. By the next morning, there was a line.

Between the twenty-fourth and the twenty-seventh of July, Jan Zwartendijk wrote about thirteen hundred Curaçao notations by hand. The sentence was the same every time, and he signed every one of them. When his hand could no longer keep up, he had a rubber stamp made with the text on it, so that only his signature was needed, and in the following days he issued roughly a thousand more. The highest number among the papers that survive is 2,345.

He signed himself *Consul des Pays-Bas ad interim*, acting consul, a title that would let him plead inexperience if anyone in authority ever asked what he thought he was doing.

He told almost no one. Each week he sent a report to Philips headquarters in Eindhoven, and each report was written so as to reveal nothing. One of them noted only that he was receiving a constant stream of Dutch people who had got themselves, in one way or another, into a mess. Privately, he doubted the whole scheme would work. *It's surely impossible*, he said. *But who knows?*

One afternoon a Soviet officer arrived at the shop, irritated by the long line of people outside what was supposed to be a radio store, and suspicious of what was going on inside. According to the account the family later gave Brokken, Zwartendijk sat the officer down and made him a present of a new Philips electric razor. The officer turned it over in his hands. *What a marvel*, he said, in Russian. The line kept moving.

◆◆◆

A Curaçao notation on its own led nowhere. To reach the Caribbean from Lithuania, a refugee had to cross the entire Soviet Union, and the Soviets would let travelers through only if the country at the far end agreed to let them in. That country was Japan. So each passport with Zwartendijk's sentence in it was carried to the Japanese consulate, a short walk away, where the acting consul, Chiune

Sugihara, would need to stamp it with a Japanese transit visa.

Sugihara cabled Tokyo for permission. According to his wife, Yukiko, he asked three times and was refused three times. The two of them talked it over at home. Then he began to write.

Yukiko remembered the crowd at the gate of the consulate, people standing there from morning until night. When they caught sight of her at an upstairs window, they would press their hands together as if in prayer. *We could not sleep at night*, she said. Each visa took several columns of Japanese brushwork. Her husband wrote until he looked, in her words, like a sick man.

The two consuls lived and worked a few hundred meters apart, and they never met. They spoke on the telephone. At one point, Zwartendijk's son later recalled, Sugihara called to ask him to slow down, because the Japanese consulate could not keep pace with the Dutch one.

Zwartendijk's children knew Mrs. Sugihara by sight. The Japanese consulate was on their route to school, and Edith practised copying the walk of the consul's elegant wife, swaying down the street to make her brother laugh.

On the third of August, the Soviets took over the Philips office, and with it the Dutch consulate. The official work was over. A few days later the ambassador in Riga ordered every consular file destroyed. The family fed the papers into the stove at home, and eleven-year-old Jan helped. The list of

names, the only record of who had come to the door, went up the chimney.

That same month the family's landlord, a Lithuanian history professor, was arrested and deported to Siberia with his wife and their five-year-old daughter.

In early September, the Zwartendijks boarded a train west, home to the occupied Netherlands, and Jan reported for work at Philips in Eindhoven.

◆ ◆ ◆

The people who held both papers, the Dutch sentence and the Japanese stamp, boarded the Trans-Siberian railway and rode east for more than a week, across the whole of the Soviet Union, to Vladivostok. From there they crossed by ship to Japan. Some went on to the United States, Canada, Palestine, or Australia. More than a thousand who had nowhere else to go waited out the war in Japanese-occupied Shanghai.

Among them were the students and teachers of the Mir yeshiva, one of the great centers of Jewish learning in Europe. Some two hundred and fifty of them crossed Siberia together and spent the rest of the war studying in a synagogue in Shanghai, hungry for much of that time. Afterward the Mir yeshiva went on, in Jerusalem and in Brooklyn.

In March 1941, seventy-four refugees arriving at Tsuruga were refused entry because their papers were not in order. Nathan Gutwirth, the young Dutch student from Telz, was in Japan by then. He went to the Dutch consul in Kobe and persuaded

him to write the same Curaçao sentence into their documents. They were let in.

Nobody, as far as is known, ever reached Curaçao.

◆◆◆

In Eindhoven, Jan Zwartendijk went back to selling Philips products. During the occupation, two Gestapo officers came to his house asking about an old friend who had been carrying his name and address. They went away.

He did not speak about Kaunas. His colleagues knew nothing about it. His children heard almost nothing. The rule he had given them was simple, and his son Jan remembered it all his life: *Do what you think is right, and then keep quiet.*

Rob, the baby with the burned nose, was thirty-five before he learned what his father had done that summer, and he learned it from his older brother. When he asked his father about it, the answer was brief. *Ah, that's not very important*, his father said. *Everyone would have done those things if they had been in this position.*

In 1963 a Jewish newspaper in Los Angeles found the story and called him "the Angel of Curaçao." He winced at the name and gave the credit to de Decker. Some time in the 1960s, the Dutch Ministry of Foreign Affairs called him in. According to his family and to Brokken's research, he was reprimanded for having issued the notations without authority. His children said he was deeply offended. He had never cared for medals, a Dutch official later

said, but the reprimand bothered him for the rest of his life.

What bothered him more was not knowing. He had burned his own list. He had no way to trace a single name. He had sent several thousand people east across the Soviet Union with a sentence about an island none of them would ever see, and then the war had closed over them, and for the rest of his life he assumed that most of them had died. His children told the prime minister of the Netherlands, many years later, that he feared they had ended up in the Soviet labor camps. Rob said his father came to believe that perhaps only one person had been saved by what he had done.

Toward the end of his life, his children asked researchers to look for survivors.

Jan Zwartendijk died in Eindhoven on the fourteenth of September, 1976. He was eighty.

The answer came around the day of the funeral. The family's accounts differ by a day or two. The researchers had traced the Curaçao papers. Of the people they could follow, the family was told, roughly ninety-five percent had survived the war. The original list was ash, so the figure is theirs, and no one has been able to do better.

◆ ◆ ◆

In 1997, Yad Vashem in Jerusalem named Jan Zwartendijk one of the Righteous Among the Nations. The medal is inscribed in Hebrew with the line from the Mishnah that opens this chapter.

In June 2018 a monument was unveiled in front of number 29 on Freedom Avenue: a spiral of some two thousand slender lights, one for each life the papers are thought to have saved. It glows all night. That October, the Dutch government apologized to the family for the reprimand.

In September 2023, the Dutch prime minister presented Rob and Edith with the gold Medal for Acts of Humanity. Rob was eighty-three. *We are very happy with this recognition*, he said, *and for us, wrongs have now been righted.* Then he added: *No one would have blamed my father if he had kept the door shut and helped no one.*

Jan, the eleven-year-old who fed the lists into the stove, had died nine years earlier, in Tucson, Arizona. Edith spoke to him by video call as he was dying. Among his last words were these: *I smell the scent of Kaunas again.*

◆◆◆

The three-year-old who walked through the forest at night, told to be quiet or the wolves would come, is Nathan Lewin. He grew up in America and became one of the most respected appellate lawyers in Washington, arguing cases before the United States Supreme Court. He still has the travel document with the Japanese transit visa in it, number seventeen. He practises law with his daughter, Alyza.

Alyza Lewin has written about her grandmother Peppy, the woman who would not accept the first no, and who wrote over the consul's head to the

ambassador. Without her grandmother's stubbornness, Alyza believes, there might never have been a Curaçao sentence at all. *He saved my father's life*, she wrote of the consuls. She estimates there may be a hundred thousand people alive today who descend from those who stood in those lines.

In September 2023, at the ceremony where Rob and Edith received their father's medal, a woman named Arlette Liwer-Stuip was in the audience. Her grandfather, Abraham Liwer, had fled the Polish town of Będzin, made his way to Kaunas, and climbed the stairs to the radio shop. Some twenty-five thousand Jews of Będzin were murdered in the war. Sixty-nine of them were members of her family. Her grandfather was not, because of a sentence in fountain pen, and so she was there in the room, alive, to watch the medal handed to the children of the man who wrote it.

If one of those hundred thousand descendants is a child in a classroom somewhere this morning, she has no idea that her life passed, eighty years ago, through a radio shop on Freedom Avenue, through a baby's burned nose, and through a telephone that rang just as a salesman was locking up.

> Side note: In Vienna in 1938, after Germany annexed Austria, the Chinese consul-general was a man named Ho Feng-Shan. Jews desperate to leave needed proof that some country would take them, and almost none would. Ho began issuing visas to Shanghai, against the orders of his superior, the Chinese ambassador in Berlin, and was given a black

mark in his personnel file for it. He signed the two hundredth visa in June 1938 and the one thousand nine hundred and sixth that October, and kept going until he was recalled in 1940. No one knows how many people he saved. Yad Vashem later honored him as Righteous Among the Nations.

Question: Who is standing in your doorway right now, waiting for a sentence only you can write?

Question: What are three ways that what is happening could be kind?

Action: Find one person, yourself or anyone else in the world, and send a message on your phone that begins "I appreciate you for..." Then finish the sentence.

Chapter Three

A Year's Wages

———

Rose

"*If we take people only as they are, we make them worse; if we treat them as if they were what they should be, we bring them to where they can be brought.*" — Johann Wolfgang von Goethe, *Wilhelm Meister's Apprenticeship*

◆◆◆

In the winter of 1956, a thirty-year-old woman from Alabama spent her days behind an airline counter in New York City, booking other people's journeys.

Her name was Nelle Harper Lee. She had grown up in Monroeville, a small courthouse town in the southwest corner of the state, the youngest child of a lawyer. Next door, for a few summers of her childhood, lived a small, strange, brilliant boy who would later call himself Truman Capote. The two of them had played in a treehouse and banged out stories on an old typewriter.

In 1949 she had moved to New York to write. Seven years later she was still trying. She worked as a reservations clerk for the airlines, and she wrote at night and on weekends in a cold-water flat, the kind

of apartment where the tap ran cold and the heat was a matter of opinion. She was nearly broke. She had a pile of stories, some essays, the beginnings of things. She had not sold any of them.

Her friends in the city were Michael and Joy Brown.

Michael was a Texan who had served in the war and come to New York afterward, where he wrote songs and performed them in nightclubs. It was a living that went up and down. Joy had danced with the Ballet Russe de Monte Carlo. By Christmas of 1956 they had two small sons, one about five years old and one about two.

Michael had met Nelle through Truman. Years earlier, Truman had written to him from Tangier asking him to keep an eye on his old friend in New York. Michael did more than that. The Browns took her in. She came for dinners, sat in their living room, and became, more or less, a member of the family.

The Browns watched her come home from the airline tired and go to her typewriter tired. Joy would later say it plainly: Nelle was not going to spend her life working as an airline clerk while hoping to become something else. Michael put it another way. She was, he said, a writer to the depths of her soul.

◆ ◆ ◆

That Christmas, Nelle could not get enough time off to go home to Alabama.

She would write about it five years later, in an essay for *McCall's* magazine called "Christmas to Me." She wrote of the ache for her family's house at Christmas, full of cousins and noise and food. She was spending the holiday instead with the Browns, in their Manhattan townhouse, which was, she understood, the next best thing to home.

She and the Browns had a long-running game: each Christmas, they tried to give one another the best present for the least money. That year, by one account, she found an old print of an eighteenth-century English clergyman and writer for Michael, and it cost her thirty-five cents. She was pleased with it.

On Christmas morning the presents were opened, and there was nothing for her. She tried to hide her disappointment.

Then the Browns told her to look on the tree.

Hanging in the branches was an envelope with her name on it. Inside was a note. It said:

You have one year off from your job to write whatever you please. Merry Christmas.

◆◆◆

She thought, at first, that it was a joke.

Then she understood that it was not. The Browns had saved some money that year, she later wrote, and had decided it was high time they did something about her. What they had done was give her a year's wages, enough to quit the airline and live, modestly, for twelve months, with nothing to do but write.

She protested. It was too much. *It's such a great risk*, she said.

Michael answered her.

No, honey. It's not a risk. It's a sure thing.

Years later, in the *McCall's* essay, she tried to set down what it had felt like. Whether she ever sold a line, she understood, did not really matter to them. What they had given her was *a full, fair chance for a new life*. She went to the window and looked out at the lights and the snow across the street. Of everything the Browns said to her that morning, she wrote, *Our faith in you* was really all she had heard.

She promised herself that she would do her best not to fail them.

◆◆◆

The money was not surplus. A songwriter with a wife and two small boys, in a trade that went boom and bust, does not have a year of someone else's salary lying around. The Browns had had a good year, and had a little extra put aside, and they chose to spend it on a friend instead of on themselves, at a time when they did not know whether next year would be good or bad.

Nelle insisted it be treated as a loan. The Browns let her call it whatever she liked. They never told anyone how much it was.

She quit her job. She wrote.

The year that followed was not the triumph the story seems to promise. In the spring of 1957 she

delivered a manuscript to her literary agents, and in October it was bought by the publishing house of J. B. Lippincott. The novel was called *Go Set a Watchman*. It was about a grown woman named Jean Louise Finch who comes home from New York to her small Alabama town and finds that her beloved father, a lawyer named Atticus, is not the man she believed him to be.

Her editor at Lippincott was a sharp, warm woman in her late fifties named Therese von Hohoff Torrey, known to everyone as Tay. Hohoff read the manuscript and saw two things. It was, she said later, more a series of anecdotes than a fully conceived novel. And the spark of the true writer flashed in every line.

The best parts were the flashbacks: the girl Jean Louise had been, a tomboy called Scout, running wild through a small town in the 1930s while her father defended a Black man accused of raping a white woman. Hohoff suggested that Nelle set aside the grown woman and write the child.

So the year ran out, and the work began again.

◆ ◆ ◆

It took two more years.

Hohoff guarded her author, as one journalist later put it, like a junkyard dog. She read draft after draft. Nelle rewrote, and rewrote, and lost her way, and found it. The book changed its title to *Atticus*, and then to *To Kill a Mockingbird*.

One winter night, according to her biographer Charles Shields, Nelle reached the end of her rope. She gathered up the pages of her manuscript, opened the window of her apartment, and threw them out into the snow. Then she telephoned Tay Hohoff, in tears.

Hohoff told her to go outside immediately and pick up the pages.

She did.

◆ ◆ ◆

To Kill a Mockingbird was published on the eleventh of July, 1960. The next spring it won the Pulitzer Prize. In 1962 it became a film, with Gregory Peck as Atticus Finch, and in April of that year Nelle's father, the lawyer whose courtroom manner and quiet dignity had gone into Atticus, died in Monroeville.

When Lippincott accepted the manuscript, Nelle paid the Browns back in full.

In the copy of the novel she gave them, she wrote an inscription:

For Mike and Joy: Life is not an empty dream, Life is a fountain ... well it is a fountain, isn't it??

◆ ◆ ◆

The fountain did not run the way anyone expected.

Fame came at her like weather. Reporters, readers, students, pilgrims. Within a few years she had largely stopped giving interviews. When requests came in, she was said to mark them with two words:

Hell, no. She was reported to have said she had said what she wanted to say and would not say it again. She never published another novel in the ordinary way.

She went to Kansas with Truman Capote to help him research the murders that became *In Cold Blood*. When the book came out, he did not give her the credit she felt she had earned for the work itself, and the friendship that had begun in a treehouse in Monroeville was never the same.

Tay Hohoff, the editor who had told her to go and pick up the pages, died in 1974. Nelle was devastated.

The Browns' fortunes went up and down, as they always had. Michael found steadier work writing industrial musicals, song-and-dance shows that corporations staged for their salesmen.

For fifty years, neither Nelle nor the Browns told anyone whose envelope had hung in that Christmas tree. Her essay in *McCall's* described the gift and did not name the givers. The world learned who they were only in 2006, when Charles Shields published his biography.

When the Browns finally spoke on camera, in a documentary in 2011, Michael waved away any credit. *It would have happened with or without us*, he said. *All that we did was hurry it up a little.*

He died in New York in June 2014, at ninety-three.

◆ ◆ ◆

The next year, in the summer of 2015, the publisher HarperCollins released *Go Set a Watchman*, the first novel, the one the Browns' year had produced and Tay Hohoff had turned back. Nelle Harper Lee was eighty-nine, nearly blind and nearly deaf, living in an assisted-living home in Monroeville after a stroke. Whether she truly wished it published became a matter of public argument.

Readers opened the book and found an Atticus Finch they did not recognize: an aging man who attends a meeting of a white segregationist council and argues against the pace of integration. Many of them felt something had been taken from them. Some felt that something true had finally been told.

She died in her sleep the following February, still eighty-nine.

◆◆◆

More than forty million copies of *To Kill a Mockingbird* have been printed. For generations of American students it has been the book they read in eighth or ninth grade, often the first novel that made them think about justice.

A Birmingham defense lawyer named Richard Jaffe, who has represented men on death row and won freedom for some of them, said after her death that if it weren't for *To Kill a Mockingbird*, he was sure he would not be doing what he was doing. Nelle's own pastor in Monroeville, Thomas Lane Butts, said the novel gave him courage when he stood up to the Ku Klux Klan in Montgomery during the bus boycott.

And there is Bryan Stevenson.

Stevenson is the lawyer who founded the Equal Justice Initiative in Montgomery and has spent his life defending people on death row in Alabama. In his book *Just Mercy*, he writes that a generation of future lawyers grew up hoping to become the courageous Atticus. Then he tells the story of a client named Walter McMillian, a Black man from one of the poor settlements outside Monroeville, who in 1988 was sentenced to death in the very county where the novel was set, for a murder he did not commit. While the town was celebrating its famous daughter and turning its old courthouse into a museum for a story about an innocent Black man wrongly accused, Walter McMillian sat on death row. He had never heard of Harper Lee.

Stevenson spent six years fighting for him. In 1993, McMillian walked out of prison a free man.

Think of a young woman somewhere tonight, the first in her family to go to law school, studying for an exam on criminal procedure in a cramped apartment. Twelve years ago, in a ninth-grade classroom, she read about a lawyer who sat all night in front of a jail cell with a newspaper and a reading lamp so that a mob would have to go through him first. She does not know the name Michael Brown. She has never heard of the envelope in the Christmas tree. But some part of the reason she is up at midnight with her casebook goes back to a songwriter with two small boys who looked at his tired friend and decided she should have one year to write whatever she pleased.

Side note: In 1877 a wealthy widow named Nadezhda von Meck began paying the composer Pyotr Tchaikovsky an allowance of six thousand rubles a year, enough for him to leave his professorship at the Moscow Conservatory and compose full time. She made one condition: they were never to meet. For thirteen years they wrote to each other instead, more than twelve hundred letters in all. Once, in August 1879, they came face to face by accident in a forest near her estate, for a few moments, and passed on. He dedicated his Fourth Symphony to her.

Question: Who in your life is a writer to the depths of their soul, or a builder, or a healer, and still working behind a counter?

Question: What are three ways that what is happening could be kind?

Action: Write a letter to someone who believed in you before there was any evidence, and tell them exactly what their belief made possible. If you can, read it to them aloud, in person or on the phone.

Chapter Four

Trays of Sandwiches

———

Tangerine

"*You just have to put yourself in their shoes, and that makes your heart even bigger.*" — Beulah Cooper of Gander, Newfoundland, speaking to the E.W. Scripps Company, 2019

◆◆◆

Gander, Newfoundland, more than a thousand miles from lower Manhattan, was built for airplanes that no longer needed it.

In the years when airliners could not cross the Atlantic on one tank of fuel, they came down in the middle of the island to refuel, and a town grew up beside the runways. By 2001 the big jets flew straight over. Gander had about ten thousand people, a hockey arena, a branch of the Royal Canadian Legion, churches and schools, a small animal shelter, and roughly five hundred hotel rooms.

On the morning of Tuesday, September 11, 2001, after the attacks in New York and Washington, the United States closed its airspace for the first time in its history. More than two hundred airliners were

already over the ocean, flying toward American airports that would not take them. On a US Airways jet from Rome, Captain Guy Gulick received a short message on the cockpit printer: *U.S. airspace is closed. Plan accordingly.* Canada opened its airports to them.

Gary Tuff, the emergency coordinator at Gander International Airport, remembered how fast it happened. *Fifteen minutes after we got the word that the airspace was closing down*, he said, *planes started to drop out of the sky.*

Thirty-eight airliners landed at Gander that day. One account adds four military aircraft. The count of the people aboard has never quite settled: most put it at about 6,600 passengers and crew, and other counts run from 6,500 to nearly 7,000. They came from something like ninety-five countries. In a single afternoon, the population of Gander had nearly doubled.

◆◆◆

On the ground, Constable Oz Fudge was called out to the airport because about a thousand people from town had gathered to watch the planes come in. He guessed there were two or three hundred people on each one. *When we saw what was happening*, he said, *we just said:* "*Well, we've got to help.*"

Nobody got off at first. Before anyone could set foot on Canadian soil, every passenger had to be checked, and customs and immigration officers had to be flown in from across the country. The planes sat on the tarmac with their doors closed for hours;

on some of them people waited as long as twenty-eight hours. Cory Smith, who ran the logistics for the planes, arrived that Tuesday morning and did not go home until Saturday night.

While the passengers waited, the town went to work.

The school bus drivers of the area were on strike that week. They put down their picket signs and drove. The school gyms became dormitories. The churches opened their halls. The Legion opened its doors. Gander's hockey arena, cold by design, became a walk-in freezer for the food that began to pour in from kitchens all over town. Brian Mosher, who ran the local cable channel, by his own account did not sleep for five straight days.

Gander could not hold everyone, so the nearby towns took their share. About seven hundred passengers went by bus to Lewisporte. Others went to Appleton and other towns that most of their guests had never heard of. In Lewisporte, Marlene George of the Salvation Army sat with a frightened woman who was traveling alone. *If you have to be stranded anywhere in the whole wide world*, she told her, *you have just landed in the right place.*

Pharmacists filled more than a thousand prescriptions for the passengers, and they did not charge for them. Shop owners refused to take money.

A Gander woman named Dawn Baker made up the spare room for a seventeen-year-old Israeli girl named Libby. Twenty years later Baker could still

show a reporter the room. *The spare room was spick and span*, she said, *the sheets were, as I've said many times before, dried on the line.*

◆◆◆

Bonnie Harris ran the Gander and Area SPCA, the town's animal shelter, and she had a question nobody else was asking.

She was told there were no animals on any of the planes. She did not believe it, and neither did her husband, Doug, who worked at the airport. Thirty-eight transatlantic jets, she reasoned, were bound to be carrying someone's pets. She telephoned around. She asked to see the cargo manifests. The count went up.

In the end there were nineteen animals (most accounts say twelve dogs and five cats, though one early report counted nine dogs and ten cats) and two bonobos, a rare and endangered kind of ape.

The bonobos were two females named Unga and Kosana, flying from Europe to the Columbus Zoo and Aquarium in Ohio, where Unga would stay; Kosana later moved on to a zoo in Milwaukee. According to the Columbus Zoo, their plane was about an hour outside United States airspace when the towers fell. They had traveled with keepers, and by the zoo's account the apes stayed in the hold with them through the five days on the ground. The others had no one.

Bonnie Harris and two other women went to them. They crawled into the cargo holds over and around the stacked luggage to reach the crates. Some of the

animals had gone about two days without food or water. One of the cats was epileptic. One of the dogs was a cocker spaniel puppy named Ralph. The animals were moved to a hangar at the airport, and for five days Harris and her helpers worked from dawn to dusk, feeding them, giving them water and blankets, walking the dogs, and giving medication to the animals that needed it. Their owners were somewhere among the thousands of strangers in the town's gyms and church halls.

When the planes left, the animals went home with their people. Ralph, the cocker spaniel puppy, grew up to become a champion in American dog shows. Harris's one regret, years later, was a small one. She wished she had left notes in the crates asking the owners to get in touch. *It would have been nice*, she said, *to have a picture of them with their family.*

She never thought of it as anything special. Asked where it came from, she said it was *a family value to me*, *a learned behavior*. *It's just what you do*, she said.

◆◆◆

At the Legion, a retired woman named Beulah Cooper was making sandwiches.

Years later, when people asked her what she did that week, she gave the same answer. *My name is Beulah Cooper*, she would say, *and I made trays of sandwiches.* It began with a phone call asking her to bring sandwiches to the Legion. *I asked what was going on*, she remembered, *and they said there was a planeload of people coming in.* She also did a great

deal else. She was a long-time volunteer at the Gander branch of the Royal Canadian Legion, where some of the passengers were sheltered. She drove people to a hotel so they could use its pay phones to call home. She took them shopping for clothes. She brought some of them back to her own house for a shower and a meal. Three women stayed with her, among them Monica Burke, a police dispatcher flying from Dublin to Seattle, who had spent about twelve hours on the tarmac. About a dozen more passengers came through her house to take showers. *Everybody in the town put their lives on hold so they could take care of us*, Burke said.

Among the passengers at the Legion were Hannah and Dennis O'Rourke of New York, on their way home from a trip to Ireland. Their son Kevin was a firefighter with Rescue Company 2 in Brooklyn. He was forty-four, a husband, and the father of two daughters. He was not on duty that morning, but his mother, Beulah said later, *knew in her heart that he was there.* He had been reported missing. From the Legion, Hannah kept trying to telephone New York. *If you got through, you got through*, she said later. *And if you did, you didn't.* She held on to what she knew about her son. *If there's a way to get out*, she said, *Kevin will find it.*

Beulah understood the fear. The two women were both in their sixties, and her own son was a firefighter too. She gave Hannah O'Rourke her friendship and whatever comfort there was to give, and by the end of the week the two mothers were no longer strangers. The accounts differ about where

the O'Rourkes slept: in some they stayed at the Legion and went to Beulah's house to wash and eat, in one they stayed with her the whole five days. All agree that she did not leave Hannah alone with it.

When the planes were finally allowed to go, Hannah O'Rourke flew home to New York and learned that her son had died in the north tower of the World Trade Center, trying to save the people inside. His body was found under a stairwell.

Then she picked up the telephone and called Newfoundland.

She called me on the phone and said, "Beulah, he's gone," Beulah Cooper remembered. *That was hard. It was hard.*

Hannah spoke of her son's work in the plainest words she had. He had wanted to be a firefighter to help people and save lives. *That was his passion*, she said. And of herself, afterward: *I have to pick up the pieces.*

◆◆◆

Oz Fudge, the constable who had watched the planes come in, spent most of his working life as a Gander policeman, some thirty years on the job.

That week he joined the emergency team and went wherever he was needed. On one of the planes, he learned, was a group of sick children from England who had been on their way to Disney World. They were not going to get there. Fudge and his daughter had a birthday celebration coming, and they postponed it. They bought a birthday cake large

enough to feed three hundred and fifty people. His daughter dressed up as *Commander Gander*, and her friends put on gowns and became fairytale princesses to greet the children. The accounts give the number of princesses as two or three.

Asked about it afterward, Fudge seemed puzzled by the fuss. Visitors, he said, had simply *dropped in for a bucket-o'-tea and a biccy. What's the big deal?* he asked.

The mayor, Claude Elliott, had put it into numbers. *What do we do with 7,000 people?* he had asked that first day. *We've only got 500 hotel rooms.* Years later he gave the answer as a kind of arithmetic. *The first day, we had 7,000 strangers*, he said. *On the third day, we had 7,000 friends.*

A passenger from Austin, Texas, named Kevin Tuerff remembered walking along the road and having cars pull over to offer him a lift, again and again. *Gander invented the first ride-sharing*, he said later. *Problem is they just didn't charge for it.*

◆◆◆

In Lewisporte, the passengers and crew of Delta Air Lines Flight 15, coming home from Europe to Atlanta, were taken in for three days. Shirley Brooks-Jones was one of them. *They essentially shut down their town*, she said later, *came in from these little tiny places and took care of us.* Their hosts would not take a cent for any of it.

Brooks-Jones was a retired university employee from Ohio State who had gone back and finished her own

degree late. She had seen, she said, *how even a tiny little scholarship would help kids get started.*

Once they were back aboard and on their way home, the passengers talked about how to thank their hosts, whom an Ohio State writer later described as *proud people and many of modest means.* The problem, as Brooks-Jones put it, was how to repay people without wounding their pride. *How do you do something for someone who doesn't want you to?* Someone suggested a scholarship for the children of Lewisporte. Brooks-Jones drew up pledge sheets by hand. The captain, Michael Sweeney, let her make her pitch over the plane's public address system, and he made the first pledge himself. The sheets went up and down the aisles. By the time Flight 15 landed in Atlanta, the passengers and crew had pledged fifteen thousand dollars.

She set up the fund in 2002 with The Columbus Foundation in Ohio, and that year the first scholarships went to graduates of Lewisporte Collegiate.

Brooks-Jones went back to Lewisporte for graduations again and again, twenty-seven times in the first sixteen years alone. In 2005 the school made her its first honorary graduate. Her favorite part of every trip, she said, was the chance to *just sit and have a cup of tea with those kind, gentle, fun and funny Newfoundlanders.* Asked why she kept at it, she said: *What little I can do, I want to do.*

◆◆◆

When the planes were finally cleared to leave, people in the towns came out to see them off and sang them farewell songs. There was not a dry eye in town, Beulah said.

Gratitude kept arriving in Gander afterward, sometimes in strange shapes.

Lufthansa named one of its new jets *Gander/Halifax*. Kevin Tuerff, the passenger who had been offered all those rides, started a campaign called Pay It Forward 9/11, asking people to mark each anniversary of the attacks with small kindnesses to strangers.

Years later a Canadian couple, Irene Sankoff and David Hein, who had been living in New York on September 11, came to Gander to listen. Out of the interviews they wrote a musical, *Come From Away*. *There were people who were showing the best of humanity*, Sankoff said, *at the time we were also seeing the worst.* When they told the president of the airport authority, Reg Wright, what they were writing, he asked whether it was a musical about people making sandwiches. It was.

On October 29, 2016, the show was performed in Gander, in the hockey arena that had served as the town's freezer fifteen years before. About five thousand people came, nearly half the town. Oz Fudge remembered the ending. *You should've heard the reaction in the room*, he said, *it was like thunder, everyone rising up.*

In March 2017 the show opened on Broadway. Hannah O'Rourke and Beulah Cooper sat side by

side at the opening, held hands, and wept as actors played their week together. Before the performance, Oz Fudge and Beulah went to the September 11 memorial in lower Manhattan. Fudge took off his hat before he went in. As a policeman, he said, *you go to a scene to try and save.* At the towers, *there was no one to save. No words can describe it*, Beulah said.

◆◆◆

The fame cost something, and so did the remembering. The people of Gander became characters, and characters get recognized. For some of the people who had worked those five days, the memories grew heavier with time, not lighter. *The more time that passes, the more emotional I get about it*, said Cory Smith, who had run the planes. *Those days had an impact on me.*

Bonnie Harris, who called herself *a pretty reserved person*, watched an actress play her on stage. After a friend praised the portrayal, she reconsidered herself a little. *Maybe I am a little more badass than what I think I am*, she allowed. But she kept saying the same thing she had said in 2001. *I've said this so many times to so many people*, she told a reporter, *this really should not be a big deal.* When the show opened in Australia, money from the final preview went to a guide dog charity in her honor. The woman who had crawled over suitcases to reach a cocker spaniel puppy was being thanked, in the end, with help for more dogs.

In Columbus, Unga settled in. In December 2003, two years after the five days in a cargo hold on a

Newfoundland runway, she gave birth to her first baby, a son. The zoo named him Gander, after the people who had taken care of his mother. Bonnie Harris planned a trip to Columbus in the spring of 2020 to meet Unga again, and the pandemic cancelled it. Unga died in March 2021. Later that year she visited the Columbus Zoo anyway, to meet the family Unga had left behind. *I came full circle, I guess*, she said.

◆◆◆

The twentieth anniversary, in September 2021, arrived in the middle of the pandemic. In Appleton, as every year, people gathered at the Derm Flynn Riverfront Peace Park, where another piece of the towers, a thousand pounds of steel, stands by the water. Diane Flynn remembered the passengers who had come to that riverbank in 2001. *That week*, she said, *people came here to get some space, to stare out on the water and think and cry.* At Gander's airport emergency centre, the sticky notes listing the flight numbers of the thirty-eight planes were still on the wall, and there were no plans to take them down.

Hannah O'Rourke, eighty-seven that year, was still talking about her son, and still talking to Beulah. The two stayed friends for the rest of Hannah's life. She died in 2025, at ninety-one.

The fund that began with fifteen thousand dollars of pledges on a Delta jet passed one million dollars, and by 2021, 341 students of Lewisporte Collegiate had earned scholarships from it. One of them that

year, Mackenzie Pope, was starting veterinary school on Prince Edward Island.

On the twenty-fifth anniversary, in September 2026, reporters came back to Gander and found Bonnie Harris still at the SPCA. Her answer about that week had not changed. *It's something we'd do again tomorrow if it came up*, she said.

Somewhere tonight, a student from Lewisporte is studying late on a scholarship that began as a handwritten pledge sheet passed down the aisle of an airplane. And somewhere in a small town, at a shelter that most people drive past without seeing, a volunteer is filling the water bowls one more time before she switches off the lights and locks the door.

> Side note: The last known search dog from Ground Zero was a golden retriever named Bretagne, who worked twelve-hour shifts in the rubble in 2001 with her handler, Denise Corliss, a volunteer firefighter from Texas. She went on to search after Hurricanes Katrina, Rita and Ivan. When she retired, she became a reading dog at an elementary school, listening to children practice out loud. In June 2016, when she was sixteen, firefighters and rescue volunteers lined the path into the animal hospital in Cypress, Texas, and saluted as she walked in for the last time.

Question: When were you the stranger who was taken in, and who was the person, like Beulah Cooper with her trays of sandwiches, who made room for you?

Question: What are three ways that what is happening could be kind?

Action: Go find the nearest animal to hug, adore, feed or compliment.

Chapter Five

The White Chickens

———

Apricot

"*Happiness doesn't come from a bigger car, house, or fancier vacation. It comes from serving others.*" — Gail Halvorsen, speaking at the Hill Aerospace Museum, Utah, 2014

◆◆◆

The gum was Wrigley's Doublemint, and there were two sticks of it.

On a day off in the middle of July 1948, an American transport pilot named Gail Halvorsen walked about twenty minutes from the runways of Tempelhof airfield, in the American sector of Berlin, to the barbed-wire fence at its edge. He had a movie camera with him. He wanted to film the planes coming in. On the other side of the wire stood about thirty German children, somewhere between eight and fourteen years old, watching the same planes.

He was twenty-seven. He had grown up on small farms in Rigby, Idaho, and Garland, Utah, with, as he put it, *my face down in the dirt all the time*, looking up at the airplanes that crossed the sky and wanting to be up there with them. When he earned

his pilot's license, he flew over his parents' farm and rocked the wings to say hello. He spent the war ferrying transport planes across the South Atlantic. Three years earlier, the people on the other side of this fence had been the enemy.

◆◆◆

Berlin sat deep inside the Soviet zone of occupied Germany, divided among the four powers that had won the war. In June 1948 the Americans and British introduced a new currency, the Deutschmark, into their zones and into West Berlin, without the Soviets' agreement. On June 24 the Soviets closed every road, railway and canal into the western half of the city. More than two million people were cut off from food and coal. Two days later the Americans began flying supplies in, and called it Operation Vittles.

Halvorsen got the order with less than an hour's notice. He packed extra handkerchiefs, because he had a cold. Like most of the pilots, he expected the airlift to last a couple of weeks. By early July he was flying a four-engine C-54 out of Rhein-Main, near Frankfurt, three round trips a day into Tempelhof, with about seven hours left over to sleep. His first load was flour.

He did not think of himself as a political man. *I was a throttle jockey and didn't know anything about the politics of it all*, he said years later. He knew one thing. *In trying to control people by starving them, Stalin was getting a black eye in the world press.*

◆◆◆

At the fence, the children did most of the talking. They asked what each plane was carrying. They talked about relatives in the Soviet zone. By the account of the historian Andrei Cherny, Halvorsen wondered at first whether some of them had been in the Hitler Youth.

What they told him was about freedom. They said the Americans should keep flying even when the weather turned bad, because they could get by on little food. As he remembered it, they said that if they lost their freedom, they might never get it back. *They did not beg for chocolate*, he said. *Flour meant freedom. They would not lower themselves to ask for more.*

After about an hour he said goodbye and started back toward the base. Fifty yards away he stopped. Everywhere else in Europe, crowds of children had run after American servicemen asking for gum and candy. These thirty had asked for nothing.

I was astounded, he said. *I wanted to do more.* He reached into his pocket and found the two sticks of Doublemint. He went back to the fence, broke them in half, and passed the four pieces through the wire.

The result was unbelievable, he said. *Those with the gum tore off strips of the wrapper and gave them to the others.* The children who got no gum held the strips of foil to their noses and smelled them.

I was so moved by what I saw and their incredible restraint, he said, *that I promised them I would drop enough gum for each of them the next day.* One of the children asked how they would know which

plane was his. He remembered the farm in Utah. He told them he would wiggle his wings.

◆ ◆ ◆

That night he went to his copilot and his flight engineer and asked for their candy rations. They gave him what they had, and the three of them bought more at the base exchange at Rhein-Main. He tied the candy bars to his spare handkerchiefs with string, so they would float down slowly and not hurt anyone.

On the approach to Tempelhof he rocked the wings of the C-54 over the apartment buildings, and his crewman Herschel Elkins pushed the three little parachutes out through the flare chute. When the plane taxied in, the children were at the fence, waving the three white handkerchiefs back at them.

Dropping anything from an aircraft broke regulations. His friends warned him that it could mean a court-martial. He kept going, once a week, for three weeks, and every week there were more children at the fence. Then he walked into base operations at Tempelhof and found a table covered with letters addressed to *Onkel Wackelflügel*, Uncle Wiggly Wings, and to the Chocolate Flier. *Holy cow, we're in trouble*, he said, and told his crew they had to quit. Then he decided on one more drop. *Once more, and that's all.*

One letter came from a boy named Peter Zimmermann, who sent him a map to his house. Another, as Halvorsen remembered it, scolded him:

You missed me again! How did you guys win the war anyway?

A candy bar on a handkerchief came down near a German reporter, and the story ran in the newspapers with a photograph of the plane and its tail number. An officer met Halvorsen as he landed. The colonel wanted to see him right away.

Whatcha doing, Halvorsen? the colonel asked.

Flying like mad, sir.

The colonel held up the newspaper. *I'm not stupid*, he said. *What else you been doing?* The general had seen the article first and called the colonel about it, and Halvorsen always suspected that this was what upset his commander most. The general was William Tunner, who ran the whole airlift, and his order was short. *Keep doing it!*

◆◆◆

The Air Force saw what a pilot dropping chocolate to the children of a former enemy was worth to its reputation, and on September 22, 1948, the drops became official, under the name Operation Little Vittles. They spread through his squadron, where twenty-five men joined in, and then across the airlift.

In Chicopee, Massachusetts, a college student named Mary Connors wrote to the national association of candy makers. *We'll tie up all the parachutes*, she told them. *Have the candy sent to us.* The children of Chicopee tied parachutes after school and on weekends, and the town prepared more than eighteen tons of candy and gum for

Berlin. Elsewhere, a homebound woman named Dorothy Groeger organized other women to sew handkerchiefs and raise money. In December 1948 alone, about ninety thousand small parachutes fell on the city. The letters from Berlin's children came by the sackful, and a women's club took on the work of answering them. *It just went crazy*, Halvorsen said.

By the time it ended, Operation Little Vittles had dropped more than 250,000 parachutes. Accounts differ on how much candy they carried, from about twenty-one tons to twenty-three.

Halvorsen himself rotated home in January 1949, and a squadron mate kept the drops going. On April 16, 1949, Halvorsen married Alta Jolley.

◆◆◆

One of the letters had come from a seven-year-old girl named Mercedes Simon.

She lived with her mother and grandmother near Tempelhof, in a house where refugees from the east also lived. Her father had been a pilot in the war and had gone missing early in it. She and her mother never learned what happened to him. She had started school in 1947, and some days the school meal was the only one she ate.

When the airlift began, the noise frightened her. Three years earlier, planes over Berlin had meant bombs. *I asked my grandmother if we should go downstairs in the cellar once more*, she said. Her grandmother told her that this time the planes were bringing food and coal. That summer one came

down about two hundred meters from her house, and two pilots were killed. Flour lay over everything nearby. She remembered thinking it might have been their house.

The family kept white chickens in the yard, and eggs during the blockade were worth a great deal. The planes passed over the house day and night, and the hens stopped laying. Mercedes complained, and her grandmother told her, in effect, to stop whining and do something about it. So she wrote to the pilot whose picture she had seen in the newspaper. She addressed the envelope *To my Chocolate Uncle, Tempelhof Airport* and mailed it without a stamp. He flew over her house every day, she told him. He would recognize it by the white chickens. He could drop his candy there. Halvorsen remembered her complaint for the rest of his life. *Their feathers are falling out and they're not laying many eggs anymore*, he would recite, *and that's bad news!*

He and his crew looked for the white chickens and never found them.

On November 4, 1948, he wrote back. The letter, addressed to Miss Mercedes Simon, told her he could not find the chickens in her backyard. Accounts differ on what came with it: in Halvorsen's telling he mailed her a bundle of candy and gum, and in her own a piece of peppermint gum and a flat lollipop. She did not like peppermint. She traded the gum at the children's black market for a glass marble, and she saved the lollipop for Christmas. Decades later she still had the marble.

What she treasured was the letter. *It wasn't the sweets that impressed me*, she said. *Knowing that someone outside of Berlin was thinking of me gave me hope.*

◆◆◆

The winter of 1948 was the hard part. Coal was the largest single cargo on the airlift, and still the apartments were cold and the electricity came on for only a few hours. On September 9, 1948, Berlin's elected mayor, Ernst Reuter, stood in front of the burned-out Reichstag and spoke to a crowd that accounts put between three hundred thousand and three hundred fifty thousand people. *People of the world*, he said, *look at this city.*

The planes kept coming. At the peak, one landed at Tempelhof every minute and a half. On April 16, 1949, the day Halvorsen married in the United States, the airlift carried nearly thirteen thousand tons into Berlin in a single day, about as much as the trains had carried before the blockade.

It cost lives. Accounts of the total vary: at least seventy-eight American, British and German airmen and ground crew died in accidents, and the British National Archives counts 101 deaths in all, among them thirty-nine British.

On May 12, 1949, the Soviets reopened the roads. By the time the airlift ended that September, American and British crews had made more than 277,000 flights and carried more than 2.3 million tons.

Behind the airlift stood a larger decision. In June 1947 the American Secretary of State, George Marshall, had said that American policy was directed *not against any country or doctrine but against hunger, poverty, desperation and chaos.* Part of the plan that carried his name went to West Germany, the country American pilots had been bombing a few years before.

A young Berliner later told Halvorsen what the small parachutes had meant, and he wrote it down in his memoir. It wasn't just chocolate, the Berliner said. *It was hope.*

◆ ◆ ◆

Gail Halvorsen stayed in the Air Force, and he never stopped dropping candy. In February 1970 he went back to Berlin as commander of the air base at Tempelhof, the same field where he had once landed with flour and handkerchiefs. He served there four years, longer than any other American base commander after the war.

In the fall of 1972 he and his family were invited to dinner at 15 Hähnelstraße, an old apartment house near the airport. Accounts differ on how the invitation came: in one, the hostess's husband, a chemistry teacher named Peter Wild, approached Halvorsen with the letter; in another, she wrote to him herself. The hostess was a woman in her thirties. She brought out a letter that she had kept in her china cabinet for twenty-four years. It was dated November 4, 1948.

I am Mercedes, she told him. Then she took him a few steps to the window and showed him where the chickens had been.

She served chicken fricassee. Halvorsen asked whether it came from the hens she had written to him about, and the question broke the ice. The two families have been friends ever since.

The chocolate uncle became a symbol of my father, Mercedes said in 2008. Eleven years later she put it more simply. *He became a father-figure for me.*

On May 14, 1998, at the fiftieth anniversary of the airlift, President Bill Clinton came to Tempelhof and asked the famous *Rosinenbomber*, the raisin bomber, who had dropped tiny parachutes of candy to Berlin's children, to stand. Mercedes Wild was on the stage with Halvorsen and the President, and she thanked the Americans on behalf of the people of Berlin. *Without the help of the Americans*, she said, *I wouldn't be here.*

She kept telling the story, mostly to children. An American author made it into a picture book, *Mercedes and the Chocolate Pilot*. In October 2010, at an American school in Stuttgart, a general read the book aloud in English, and she stood beside him and translated it into German, page by page. A parent there noticed how grateful the sixty-nine-year-old grandmother still was for something as simple as candy. At times her voice broke.

◆◆◆

Over the years he dropped candy over Bosnia and Kosovo, Albania, Guam and Japan, and at events

across the United States, and he gave thousands of talks, most of them at schools. In 2014 he received the Congressional Gold Medal.

In May 2019, at ninety-eight, he flew to Berlin for the seventieth anniversary of the end of the blockade. Tempelhof had closed as an airport in 2008 and become a public park, and a local baseball club named its field there for him. He threw the first pitch. Mercedes Wild, seventy-eight, was there and talked to the reporters. Halvorsen told them that the heroes of the airlift had been the Germans, the parents and children on the ground. *Berlin is my second home*, he said.

Gail Halvorsen died on February 16, 2022, at Utah Valley Hospital in Provo, at the age of 101, with his family around him. In his last days, his foundation said, he wanted to remind everyone to have gratitude. The German Embassy in Washington sent its own message. *Thank you for your kindness, Colonel.* Berlin's mayor, Franziska Giffey, said that his deeply human act had never been forgotten.

In Berlin, a secondary school has carried his name since 2013. Its motto is *Freedom, Responsibility, Friendship.*

◆ ◆ ◆

The old field at Tempelhof has been open to anyone since 2010. People cycle and skate on the two runways, and children run where the C-54s once came in every ninety seconds. The barbed wire is gone. On windy days, kites hang over the field on long strings.

Decades after the blockade, a woman in Berlin still had a glass marble. She got it as a seven-year-old, in trade for a stick of peppermint gum she did not want, which came in an envelope from a pilot who could not find her chickens, who had made a promise at a fence to thirty children who asked him for nothing, with the only two sticks of gum in his pocket.

> Side note: In January 1947, President Truman asked Herbert Hoover, then seventy-two, to go and see how Germany was eating. Hoover had argued for feeding Germans after the First World War too, when Allied leaders wanted to withhold food as punishment. He flew through the frozen country in an unpressurized plane, met with commanders in buildings without heat, caught severe colds, and came home with damaged hearing. Among his recommendations was a daily midday meal for children, run by German women, mostly in schools. Germans called it the *Hoover-Speisung*, the Hoover feeding. That November, the forty-three twelve-year-olds of class 7c at an elementary school in Hamburg-Volksdorf wrote to thank him. *Every day*, they told him, *we think of you when we get our Hooverbreakfast.*

Question: In a hard season of your life, who sent you something small that told you someone outside was thinking of you, and who could use that from you now?

Question: What are three ways that what is happening could be kind?

Action: Write a short note by hand to someone going through a hard stretch, a child, an elderly neighbor, a friend far away. Tell them one specific thing you remember about them, put something small inside the envelope, and mail it today.

Chapter Six

Thirteen

———

Amber

"*The man who is angry at the right things and with the right people, and, further, as he ought, when he ought, and as long as he ought, is praised*." — Aristotle, Nicomachean Ethics, Book IV (trans. W. D. Ross)

◆◆◆

Cari and Serena Lightner were born on the fifth of September, 1966, identical twins, two girls with one face between them. Their mother, Candy, was twenty years old.

Candy had grown up as a military child and married an Air Force officer named Steve Lightner. On Okinawa she helped set up a drug program for heroin-addicted servicemen and a hotline for people thinking of ending their lives. She was, from early on, a person who went toward trouble. Later there was a son, Travis. Later still there was a divorce, and a house in Fair Oaks, a leafy suburb on the eastern side of Sacramento, where Candy sold real estate and raised three children on her own.

The roads had already come for her family twice. When the twins were eighteen months old, a drunk driver rear-ended the station wagon their grandmother was driving, and Serena was cut by flying glass. Six years after that, Travis, four years old, was run over by an unlicensed driver who was impaired by tranquilizers. He was in a coma for four days. He had a collapsed lung, broken ribs and a fractured skull, and the damage to his brain was permanent. The driver did not receive a ticket.

Candy Lightner was not a political woman. She was not, by her own account, even registered to vote.

◆◆◆

On Saturday, the third of May, 1980, Cari was thirteen. She was walking with a friend along a quiet street in Fair Oaks toward a church carnival when a car came up behind her, swerved into the bike lane and struck her from behind.

The force threw her about 125 feet. One account says it knocked her shoes off. She died within the hour. Her injuries were so severe that her organs could not be given to anyone.

The car did not stop.

The man behind the wheel was Clarence William Busch. Accounts give his age as forty-six or forty-seven. His blood alcohol level was later reported at 0.20 percent, twice the legal limit of the day. By the account Candy later gave, he blacked out briefly behind the wheel and then drove home. Police found him four days later.

What they found in his record was the part that would change Candy Lightner's life. Busch had been convicted of drunk driving in 1976, in 1977 and in 1979. Just before he killed Cari, he had been arrested yet again for a drunk-driving hit-and-run and released on bail. The accounts differ on how close together the two crashes were. Candy's own account says the arrest was the night before. A wire report from 1992 says two days. Another history says less than a week. By Candy's count, the crash that killed Cari was his fifth drunk-driving offense in four years. All of the accounts agree on the essential thing: the man who hit Cari had been free to drive because no one had stopped him, and he still held a valid California license. For the earlier convictions, one account says, he had spent at most forty-eight hours in jail.

Then a police officer told Candy what to expect. The driver, he said, would probably never spend a day in jail.

That made me very angry, she said many years later, *so I decided to start MADD.* In another telling she put it more simply. *I was furious.* And in another, the one that sounds most like a mother in the first week: *I felt enraged and helpless.*

◆ ◆ ◆

The anger took a shape almost at once.

On the evening before Cari's funeral, Candy went out to a restaurant with friends. They were waiting for a table in the bar, in a cocktail lounge, of all places, when she said it out loud. She was going to

start an organization, because people needed to know about this. Someone at the table offered a name. In one version it was a friend. In another it was Candy's sister. The name was Mothers Against Drunk Drivers, and the initials spelled what she was. Years later the last word would be changed from *Drivers* to *Driving*, from the person to the act, but in 1980 she was thinking about one person in particular.

Her own records date the beginning to the seventh of May. Within days she was working out of her house in Fair Oaks. She quit her real estate job. She spent her savings. She spent the money from Cari's insurance policy, and between the two she paid for nearly sixty percent of the new group's expenses in its first year. She had no experience running anything of the kind. She learned as she went, in grief.

The door she wanted first belonged to the governor of California, Jerry Brown. At first he would not see her. She did not go away. By the fall of 1980 he had agreed to create a state task force on drunk driving, and Candy Lightner was its first member.

On the seventeenth of August she stood up at a press conference in Sacramento and announced the group to the public. Later that year she joined up with another mother, Cindi Lamb of Maryland. Cindi had been driving with her daughter Laura, five months old, when a repeat drunk driver hit their car head-on. Laura became, by MADD's account, the youngest quadriplegic in the country. She lived to be six. The two women went to Washington together,

and a march planned for about twenty people turned into roughly a hundred on the sidewalk outside the White House.

On the fifth of September, 1980, the papers were filed and Mothers Against Drunk Drivers was incorporated in California. It was the twins' birthday. Serena turned fourteen that day. Cari would have turned fourteen with her.

◆◆◆

The phrase Candy used again and again in those years came from the force of it. She told *People* magazine in 1981 that death caused by drunk drivers was *the only socially acceptable form of homicide*. She meant that everyone had quietly agreed to look away. In her family, she said, they do not call them accidents. They call them crashes, or crimes.

People listened, because she was a mother and because she was angry and because the anger was clean. It was not aimed at drinking itself. *I am for responsible drinking*, she told the *Statesman Journal* in 1980. It was aimed at one specific failure: that a society could know exactly who was dangerous and let him keep the keys.

Clarence Busch was the proof. In November 1980 he pleaded no contest to vehicular manslaughter and was sentenced to two years. How much of it he served depends on who is counting. Candy says sixteen months, in jail, labor camps and halfway houses, and that he was allowed to drive himself to work while he was serving it. A later history says

twenty-one months. A wire report from 1985 says he was paroled after nine months, returned to prison in April 1982 for violating parole, and released again in February 1983. Every version is short.

In 1981 California passed a law setting minimum fines for drunk drivers and mandatory jail for repeat offenders. Other states followed, one after another, and mothers began starting chapters in their kitchens. In 1982 President Ronald Reagan created a national commission on drunk driving, and Candy Lightner was on it. In 1983 NBC made a television movie of her life, *M.A.D.D.: Mothers Against Drunk Drivers*. In it, an actress played Cari, and the same actress played Serena.

◆ ◆ ◆

The anger was doing what anger does. It was getting things done, and it was costing her.

She was honest about it afterward. *I had become a personality and a crusader with a cause*, she said. *The texture of my days changed enormously.* She called herself unstoppable in those years. She also said she had been *so obsessed that, in many ways, I did not permit life to go on outside of MADD.* At home there was still a teenage daughter who had lost her twin and a son whose brain had been injured on a road years before. The record does not say what those years were like for Serena and Travis.

What the record does show is a woman who would not make a show of her pain. *I never attempted to go public with my pain*, she said. She went public

with the facts instead: the convictions, the valid license, the bail, the short sentences and the numbers of the dead. Grief she kept for herself. Anger she gave away, to anyone who could use it.

◆ ◆ ◆

The biggest law came in the summer of 1984.

Teenagers had been driving across state lines to wherever the drinking age was eighteen, drinking, and driving home. Congress passed a bill that would withhold a share of federal highway money from any state that did not raise its minimum drinking age to twenty-one.

On the seventeenth of July, 1984, Reagan signed it in the Rose Garden at the White House. He called raising the age *one simple measure that will save thousands of young lives*. Then he named the woman beside him. *Candy Lightner*, he said, *all of you who've been fighting this good fight.* The point of the bill, he said, was *to save our children's lives*.

She was thirty-eight years old. It had been four years and two months.

A real estate agent from Fair Oaks who had not been registered to vote was now a person presidents named from podiums.

She had a way of describing how it happened. *You kick a few pebbles*, she said, *you turn a few stones, and eventually you have an avalanche.* By 1985 every state in the country had tightened its drunk-driving laws. The counts of what she had built differ: one history gives about 320 chapters and 600,000

volunteers and donors by the time she left, and her own biography gives more than four hundred chapters and about two million members. In high schools, students formed groups of their own, and biographies of Candy credit Serena with starting one, though the national student organization most schools came to know was begun in 1981 by Robert Anastas, a hockey coach at Wayland High School in Massachusetts.

In April 1985, Clarence Busch was arrested again after a crash that left another driver with minor injuries. His license had expired in 1982. His parole had ended that February. *When he's discharged from parole*, a state corrections spokesman said, *we lose any jurisdiction whatsoever.* Busch was convicted for the sixth time and sentenced to four years.

◆◆◆

That same year, the movement she had started let her go.

How it happened depends again on who tells it. In October 1985, amid public questions about the organization's finances and an internal fight, the six members of MADD's executive committee asked her to step down. Newspapers reported that the board had balked when she asked for a $10,000 bonus on top of a salary of about $76,000, and that critics accused the organization of spending too much on raising money and too little on its programs. A newspaper account years later described it simply as a firing. In Candy's own account she was removed

from the board in the middle of contract negotiations, stayed on briefly as president, and then chose not to renew. She had done what she came to do, she said. She was burned out. She was spending more of her days on board politics than on saving lives, and she was afraid the grassroots group was turning into a bureaucracy.

Both versions can be true at once. A woman who ran on fury had built something that now needed accountants, audits and a board, and the organization went on without her.

She stayed on as a consultant for a time. Then she did the thing she had not done.

For five and a half years, she wrote later, *instead of focusing on my grieving, I concentrated on the manner in which she died.* The anger had held her up. It had also kept her from the plain fact underneath it, which was that Cari was gone. In 1990, with Nancy Hathaway, she published a book about grief called *Giving Sorrow Words*. The title echoes *Macbeth*, the scene in which Macduff learns that his wife and children have been killed and stands speechless, and Malcolm tells him not to pull his hat down over his brows: *Give sorrow words; the grief that does not speak / Whispers the o'er-fraught heart and bids it break.* Candy's book was not about laws. It was about how a person gets up in the morning after the worst thing has happened and the crusade is over.

She said something else about that time that is worth hearing whole. *I did not want Clarence William Busch to make me a perpetual victim.*

◆◆◆

The next part of her life cost her much of the goodwill the first part had earned.

In January 1994, Candy Lightner went to work in Washington as a lobbyist for the American Beverage Institute, a trade group whose members included breweries and restaurants that served alcohol. Her assignment was to persuade state legislatures not to lower the legal blood alcohol limit from 0.10 to 0.08, which MADD now supported.

The reaction was swift and it was furious. Andrew McGuire, a former MADD board member, said that anyone serious about preventing drunk driving *should not ever get in bed with the alcohol industry.* The president of MADD at the time, Beckie Brown, was more measured. *We believe 0.08 needs to be passed, and Candy doesn't*, she said, and called it a difference in philosophy.

Candy did not see a betrayal. *I don't see it as the other side*, she told a reporter. *They're just as affected by drunk driving as anyone else.* She declined to say what she was being paid. Her argument was the one she had made from the start: the deaths came mostly from a small number of people driving very drunk, again and again. Drivers above 0.10, she said, caused more than eighty percent of the deaths. Go after them. Take their cars. *The man who killed my daughter kept on*

driving drunk, she said. She found it strange that he was barred from ever owning a handgun but could own a car.

The country did not take her side on 0.08. In 2000 Congress tied federal highway money to the lower limit, and within a few years every state had adopted it. In 2002 she told *The Washington Times* that MADD had *become far more neo-prohibitionist than I had ever wanted or envisioned*, and added, *I didn't start MADD to deal with alcohol. I started MADD to deal with the issue of drunk driving.*

There is no tidy way to settle it, and the record does not try. She was hired by an industry with an interest in the outcome. She also never stopped saying what she had said in 1980, that the man who keeps driving drunk is the one who has to be stopped.

In 1992, Clarence Busch, by then fifty-nine and living in Kenosha, Wisconsin, with a Wisconsin license, was convicted of drunk driving for the seventh time. Because more than five years had passed since his last offense, Wisconsin law counted it as a first offense. He was fined $583 and lost his license for nine months. A reporter called Candy Lightner. *I hardly think a $583 fine is holding someone accountable for drinking and driving*, she said.

She was still angry. It was still the right thing to be angry about.

◆ ◆ ◆

The numbers moved slowly, and they moved a long way.

In 1982, the first year federal researchers counted them on the modern scale, 21,113 people died in crashes involving a driver with a blood alcohol level at or above 0.08. In 2023, the count was 12,429, in a country with tens of millions more drivers covering far more miles. It is still far too many people. It is also thousands of people every single year who did not die.

The government also tries to count the young ones directly, the people alive because of the drinking age alone. The running total from 1975 through 2014 came to 30,313. Each of those numbers is a person who turned twenty-one, then thirty, and went on, and never heard the name of a girl from Fair Oaks.

The last holdout states raised their drinking age within a few years of the signing in the Rose Garden. No teenager alive today has grown up in an America where it was otherwise.

Candy Lightner kept working. She ran a consulting firm that advised organizations on legislation, fundraising and grassroots advocacy. In the 2010s she founded a new nonprofit called We Save Lives, aimed at the three ways people now die on roads that she had lived long enough to see: drunk, drugged and distracted driving. The phone in a driver's hand was on the list now, beside the bottle.

Asked years later whether she regretted any of it, she answered that there was nothing to regret. She

credits the organization she left with saving hundreds of thousands of lives. When people asked about the founding, she kept the story plain. A man who had killed her daughter was probably not going to spend time in jail, and the crime was not considered serious.

Cari would have turned sixty this September, on the same day as Serena. Her grave is in the Fair Oaks Cemetery, in the town where she was walking that Saturday. The stone says CARI.

Somewhere this evening, in a suburb with a church carnival and a bike lane, a thirteen-year-old girl is walking with her best friend toward the lights and the music, arguing about which ride to go on first. A car slows down behind them, as cars are supposed to, and swings wide, and passes. The driver is sober, and tired, and thinking about dinner. She goes home. Later, after the last ride, so do the girls, and one of them texts the other goodnight from across the street.

> Side note: When Aristotle sat down to write about anger, more than two thousand years ago, he ran into a gap in his own language. Greek had no proper name for the person who gets angry the right amount. The middle state, he wrote, was *unnamed*, and even the extremes were almost without names, so he borrowed the word for good temper to cover it, and noticed that it leans, if anything, toward too little anger rather than too much. We still have no single word for anger that is aimed well, held for as long as the work needs it, and

then set down. We only have people who have done it.

Question: When has your own anger pointed straight at something that truly needed to change?

Question: What are three ways that what is happening could be kind?

Action: Give one hour this week to the cause that makes you angriest. Volunteer, write the letter, make the call, or show up where the work is being done. Let your anger do some good.

Chapter Seven

Mentionable

———

Marigold

"*All of us have special ones who have loved us into being*." — Fred Rogers, Daytime Emmy Lifetime Achievement Award acceptance, 21 May 1997

◆◆◆

Fred Rogers was born on the twentieth of March, 1928, in Latrobe, Pennsylvania, a small town east of Pittsburgh. His mother, Nancy, knitted sweaters for soldiers.

He was not a strong child. He had bouts of asthma that kept him inside for long stretches, and he said later that he had come down with *every imaginable childhood disease*. On the days he could not go out, he played alone, with puppets.

He was also heavy, and shy, and the other boys noticed. Years later, speaking at Saint Vincent College in his hometown, he remembered them following him home, calling him by the name they had for him, Fat Freddy, and promising they were going to get him. He said he felt he had no friends. He said that he cried to himself when he was alone.

What it left in him, he said, was a habit of looking for the stories of other people who were poor in spirit, and feeling for them.

David Newell, the actor who played Mr. McFeely on his program and worked beside him for decades, said it plainly in a documentary many years later. *I've often wondered*, he said, *if there hadn't been a 'fat Freddy,' would there have been a Mr. Rogers?*

◆◆◆

At Rollins College in Florida he met a pianist named Sara Joanne Byrd. They married in 1952 and stayed married for the rest of his life.

Television was new, and by his own account he did not like much of what he saw on it. He went into it anyway, and at WQED in Pittsburgh he made his first children's program on a budget of thirty dollars. At the same time he studied for the ministry. He graduated from Pittsburgh Theological Seminary in 1962 and was ordained a Presbyterian minister in 1963, though he never led a congregation in a church. His congregation was on the other side of a camera lens, and it was mostly very young.

The program that became *Mister Rogers' Neighborhood* was slow on purpose. He came in the door, sang, changed into sneakers and a zippered cardigan, and talked to the camera as though it were one child. He spoke about things that children worried about and adults forgot they had worried about: a haircut, a trip to the doctor, a new baby in the house, the drain in the bathtub. He believed that children could spot a phony a mile away, and he did

not pretend. *One of the greatest gifts you can give anybody*, he said, *is the gift of your honest self.*

On the twenty-third of March, 1970, viewers watched him find one of his goldfish lying still at the bottom of the tank. He lifted it out and tried to revive it in salt water, and it did not move. He wrapped it in a paper towel, carried it outside and buried it in the yard. Then he sat down and told the children watching about the dog he had loved as a boy, and how sad he had been when she died, and how hard it had been to say goodbye. He showed them her picture. He told them the good things he remembered about her. He did not tell them not to be sad.

The cardigans came from his mother. Every Christmas Nancy Rogers, who had once knitted sweaters for soldiers, knitted a sweater for each person she loved, and her son was on the list every year. *And so until she died*, he said, *those zippered sweaters I wear on the Neighborhood were all made by my mother.* They came in many colors. On the set they hung in a closet by the door, a row of his mother's hands.

◆ ◆ ◆

In the spring of 1969 the money that kept programs like his on the air was in danger.

Before leaving office, President Lyndon Johnson had proposed twenty million dollars for the new Corporation for Public Broadcasting, which Congress had created two years earlier. His successor, Richard Nixon, wanted to cut that figure

in half. The country was paying for a war in Vietnam.

The bill went before the Senate Subcommittee on Communications. Its chairman was John Pastore of Rhode Island, sixty-two years old, the son of Italian immigrants. He had a reputation for being gruff and impatient, and by his own later remark he had been listening to testimony for two days. He began that morning skeptical.

On the first of May, 1969, Fred Rogers was called. He was forty-one, and outside Pittsburgh he was relatively unknown.

Alright Rogers, Pastore said, *you've got the floor.*

◆◆◆

Rogers had a written statement. *Senator Pastore*, he said, *this is a philosophical statement and would take about ten minutes to read, so I'll not do that.* Pastore asked, a little drily, *Will it make you happy if you read it?* Rogers said he would rather just talk, and that he trusted what the senator had said about reading the statement himself.

Then he started talking about trust.

One of the first things that a child learns in a healthy family is trust, he said. He spoke in the same voice he used on the program, slow and level, with no hurry in it at all. *I care deeply about children*, he said. He talked about his own work. Fifteen years earlier, he said, his first children's program at WQED had a budget of thirty dollars. Now his program had a budget of six thousand dollars,

which, he pointed out, paid for less than two minutes of cartoons. Pastore began to ask questions: how long was the program, when did it air? He said he would like to see it. Rogers said he would like that too.

He said his program dealt with *the inner drama of childhood*. He said, *We deal with such things as getting a haircut, or the feelings about brothers and sisters*, and the kind of anger that comes up in simple family situations. He said the program did not need violence to hold a child. Two men working out their feelings of anger, he said, was *much more dramatic than showing something of gunfire*.

He told the senator how he ended every program. *I give an expression of care every day to each child*, he said, *to help him realize that he is unique.* And then, in a Senate hearing room, he simply said it, the way he said it at the end of each show, to the senator and the cameras: *You've made this day a special day, by just your being you.* He finished the closing words of that sign-off, the part about liking someone just the way they are.

◆◆◆

Then he said the sentence people would remember.

If we in public television can only make it clear that feelings are mentionable and manageable, he said, *we will have done a great service for mental health.*

Mentionable. Manageable. It had taken him forty years, and a childhood of crying where no one could see, to put it into two words.

He asked whether he could recite the words of one of his songs. Pastore let him.

The song was *What Do You Do with the Mad That You Feel?* He had written it the year before, and over the life of the program he would sing it in thirty-eight episodes. Its title is a question, and Rogers explained that its first line came straight from a child. The rest of it, which he spoke rather than sang, is about the moment of choosing what to do with anger that is very big, and about a kind of control inside that children need to know is there. Rogers said the words quietly, without performing them, sitting at a table in a room built for arguments about money.

I'm supposed to be a pretty tough guy, the senator said, *and this is the first time I've had goose bumps for the last two days.*

And then: *I think it's wonderful. I think it's wonderful. Looks like you just earned the 20 million dollars.*

The whole thing had taken about six minutes.

The accounts of what came next differ in their arithmetic. One says the subcommittee granted the full twenty million. Another says that funding for public television rose soon afterward from nine million dollars to twenty-two million. All of them agree that the money was not cut in half.

◆◆◆

The letters kept coming. Children wrote to him, and so did their parents. He answered all of them, by

hand in the early years. When the volume grew to fifty to a hundred letters on an ordinary day, a colleague helped draft the answers, and he still read, edited and signed every one. One of his assistants, Heather Arnet, told a Pittsburgh newspaper that he would not throw away a single drawing or letter. *They were sacred*, she said.

He kept himself in careful order. He woke at five, prayed, read, wrote, answered mail and swam. He weighed himself every day and kept his weight at 143 pounds. He liked the number, he explained, because it takes one letter to say *I*, four letters to say *love*, and three letters to say *you*.

In 1981, Nancy Rogers died. The sweaters stopped coming. In 1984 her son gave one of them, a red one, to the Smithsonian's National Museum of American History in Washington. By the early 1990s the cardigans on the set were wearing thin. The program's art director, Kathy Borland, unable to find zippered men's cardigans anywhere, bought plain white ones and dyed them in a seventy-dollar soup pot, filling in the zipper strips, which would not take the dye, with permanent marker.

◆ ◆ ◆

In 1981, the year his mother died, viewers met a ten-year-old boy in an electric wheelchair.

Jeff Erlanger had been born in Madison, Wisconsin, in 1970. At seven months old he was diagnosed with a tumor on his spine. Surgery removed it and left him quadriplegic. Before another operation on his spine, at five, he said that he wanted to meet Mister

Rogers. His sister wrote to him. Rogers was traveling to Milwaukee, and the family met him there for breakfast.

Years later, Rogers invited Jeff onto the program. The episode aired on the eighteenth of February, 1981. It was part of a week of shows about divorce. In the middle of that week, in the real neighborhood, Jeff drove his chair up beside Rogers and showed him exactly how it worked. They talked about his surgeries, his doctors and his parents. They talked about what to do when you feel sad. Jeff explained it all plainly, and Rogers listened. Nothing about it was scripted. By one account it was filmed in a single take of about ten minutes. Then the two of them sang a song together, *It's You I Like*, a song about liking someone for himself, and Rogers changed a few of the words as they went, so that the song said plainly that Jeff's fancy chair was not the point.

In 1999, Fred Rogers was inducted into the Television Academy Hall of Fame. Jeff Erlanger was the surprise guest who came out to introduce him. When Rogers saw who it was, he jumped up from his seat and went straight onto the stage, and put his arms around the grown man in the wheelchair the way you greet an old friend.

Jeff grew up to work in Madison politics. He chaired the city's Commission on People with Disabilities and helped bring accessible taxis to the city. A line he used in a public television spot in 2002 was the way he lived. *It doesn't matter what I can't do*, he said. *What matters is what I can do.* A former mayor

of Madison, Dave Cieslewicz, summed him up in one line. *He had a minimum investment in ego.*

In February 2000, in an online chat room, he came across a woman in Boston who said she was suicidal and had cut her wrists. Jeff did not log off. From his home in Madison he alerted the police there, the police in Boston and the company that ran the chat room, and Boston police found her and got her to medical care. Senator Russ Feingold later honored him in the United States Senate, the same body before which Fred Rogers had once talked about feelings for six minutes.

◆ ◆ ◆

On the twenty-first of May, 1997, Fred Rogers walked onto the stage of Radio City Music Hall in New York to accept a lifetime achievement award at the twenty-fourth Daytime Emmy Awards. The hall was full of soap opera stars and television executives in evening clothes, people who had spent their careers learning to hold an audience.

So many people have helped me to come to this night, he said. Then he asked the room for something. *Would you just take along with me 10 seconds to think of the people who have helped you become who you are.* He added, mildly, as though it were a practical matter, *I'll watch the time.*

He looked at his wristwatch. The hall went quiet. For ten seconds the audience sat in silence, thinking, perhaps, of a grandmother, a teacher, a coach, a mother. When the cameras turned to the audience, people were crying.

When the ten seconds were up he spoke again. *Whomever you've been thinking about*, he said, *how pleased they must be to know the difference you feel they've made.*

He did this again and again, in other speeches and ceremonies, for the rest of his life, asking rooms full of strangers to be quiet together and remember who had loved them.

He went on making the program, too, and went on bringing hard things into it. In November 1983 he gave a whole week to war, to bombs and to an arms race, because children were hearing about them. He taped the last episode on the first of December, 2000. The last one aired on the thirty-first of August, 2001.

◆◆◆

Not everyone thought it was good for children.

He was parodied for years, most famously by Eddie Murphy on *Saturday Night Live*, and he said he believed the people who did it did so with kindness in their hearts. The harder criticism came after he was gone.

In July 2007, a finance professor at Louisiana State University, Don Chance, made a passing remark, reported in the press, that his students had begun asking for extra points simply because they felt they deserved them, and that *We can blame Mr. Rogers*, whom he called *representative of a culture of excessive doting*. The morning program *Fox & Friends* picked it up. Under banners that read *Blame Mr. Rogers*, *Was Mr. Rogers Wrong?* and *Is Mr.*

Rogers Ruining Kids?, its hosts called him an *evil, evil man* who had told a generation of children they were special just because they were themselves. They cited unnamed experts and the professor. They did not name a study.

Chance later conceded that *no such study was ever done*. The reference, he said, was *just a metaphor*. People who had studied the program pointed out that it had spent decades teaching self-control, patience, persistence and cooperation, that it told children to go to school and respect their teachers, and that Rogers had said plainly that other children would be better at some things than they were. The scholar Mark J. P. Wolf wrote that Rogers' emphasis on a child's worth *should not be conflated with the failed self-esteem movement* that came later.

The criticism did not change the record, which shows a man who asked children to name their anger so that they could choose what to do with it.

In October 2002 he was diagnosed with stomach cancer. He died at home in Pittsburgh on the twenty-seventh of February, 2003, a few weeks before his seventy-fifth birthday. He and Joanne had been married for fifty years.

In May 2003, Jeff Erlanger traveled to Pittsburgh for the memorial service. He died himself four years later, on the tenth of June, 2007, at thirty-six, after choking on food and lying for weeks in a coma. He was an organ donor. When PBS made a special about Rogers in 2018, it took its title from the song the two of them had sung together in 1981.

◆ ◆ ◆

Public television has been in danger more than once since that May morning in 1969, and each time the six minutes of black-and-white film have gone around again. In the summer of 2025 Congress voted, by 216 to 213 in the House and 51 to 48 in the Senate, to take back the federal money that had been set aside for public broadcasting, and on the twenty-fourth of July the bill became law. A week later the corporation that Johnson proposed and Rogers defended announced that it would close. Stations across the country were left to find their own ways forward. The footage of a soft-spoken man in a Senate hearing room was shared again by people who had not been born when it was filmed.

On *Daniel Tiger's Neighborhood*, a program from the company Fred Rogers founded, an animated little tiger, the son of the shy puppet tiger who lived in a clock in the Neighborhood of Make-Believe, sings short songs about what to do when he is mad or scared or sad. One of them is a version of the song Rogers recited for a senator in 1969. Children who will never see the black-and-white footage of the hearing are learning it now, in a new form, before they can read. On another program from the same company there is a little mouse who uses a wheelchair. His name is Jeff.

In Madison, the city council gives an award every year, named for Jeff Erlanger, for civility in public discourse. A playground in Rennebohm Park, built so that children in wheelchairs can play on it beside everyone else, carries his name. And in August 2026

the Madison school board voted to rename Charles Lindbergh Elementary School. It is called Jeffrey Clay Erlanger Elementary School now.

This fall, on the first cold mornings, children are coming through its doors, some of them walking and some of them rolling, some of them furious about a lost mitten and some of them sad about a parent who moved out, and a teacher at the door is bending down to ask one of them, quietly, what is wrong, and then waiting to hear it.

> Side note: Whenever Fred Rogers fed the fish in the tank on his set, he said so out loud, every time, which can seem an odd habit for a man on television. The reason was a letter. A young viewer who was blind had written to ask him to tell her when he was feeding them, because she could not see it and wanted to know that the fish were all right. From then on, he told her.

Question: What feeling in your life has been the hardest to mention, and who could you mention it to this week?

Question: What are three ways that what is happening could be kind?

Action: Visit https://10xliving.org/media and notice whether a comedy, or something else there, brings more meaning to your day.

Chapter Eight

The Bullhorn

———

Yellow

"*When I was a boy and I would see scary things in the news, my mother would say to me, 'Look for the helpers. You will always find people who are helping.*'" — Fred Rogers, The Mister Rogers Parenting Book

◆◆◆

In 1943 the American soldiers came to Hayle.

Hayle was a small harbour town on the north coast of Cornwall, near St Ives, a place of sand dunes and estuary mud and grey stone terraces, where the tide went out so far that boats lay on their sides in the channel. The soldiers belonged to the United States 29th Infantry Division, and they were in Cornwall to train for an invasion nobody was allowed to name. A small boy named Cyril Rescorla, born in Hayle on 27 May 1939, watched them march and drill and laugh, and decided that this was what he wanted to be.

He grew big and strong, and he boxed. After he backed a British boxer who lost to the American Tami Mauriello, Hayle called him *Tammy*.

At sixteen he left and joined the army as a paratrooper. Serving with the Northern Rhodesia Police, he met an American soldier named Daniel Hill. The two of them became the kind of friends who measure the rest of life against each other. Years later Hill said simply, *Rick counted as the world to me.*

Rescorla wanted, in Hill's cheerful phrase, some *bang-bang shoot-'em-up*, and Hill told him the place to find it was the American army. In June 1963 Rescorla arrived in New York, slept at a YMCA in Brooklyn, and enlisted in the United States Army under the name he would use from then on: Rick.

◆◆◆

In November 1965 he was a second lieutenant leading a platoon of the 2nd Battalion, 7th Cavalry, in the Ia Drang Valley of the Central Highlands of Vietnam. The battles there were among the first large clashes between American troops and the North Vietnamese army, and they were fought at close range, in tall grass and scrub, through days and nights of shelling and assault.

His men called him *Hard Core*. Larry Gwin, another young officer in the valley, later wrote a memoir in which Rescorla appears as the *Cornish Hawk*, in a chapter called "Rescorla's Game." What they remembered most was not his bravery, though there was plenty of it, but his voice. To steady them, Rescorla sang. He sang "The Wild Colonial Boy," an old ballad about an Irish outlaw in Australia. He sang the Cornish songs he had learned as a boy in

Hayle. For a frightened man in a foxhole, a big Englishman singing about home said something orders could not: someone here was calm.

Lieutenant Colonel Hal Moore, who commanded the 1st Battalion at Landing Zone X-Ray, where Rescorla's company was sent in as reinforcements, called him *the best platoon leader I ever saw*. In 1992, when Moore and the war correspondent Joseph Galloway published *We Were Soldiers Once… and Young*, the book about those battles, a combat photograph of Rescorla in the Ia Drang was on the cover. When he saw the cover, he chose not to read the book. Later, when a film was made of it, he said he had no intention of seeing it. *The real heroes are dead*, he said.

He left active duty in 1967 with the Silver Star, the Bronze Star and the Purple Heart, and he became an American citizen. On the GI Bill he earned a master's degree in English and then a law degree. In 1972 he married Betsy Nathan, and Dan Hill stood beside him as best man. They had two children.

In 1985 he took a job running security for the brokerage firm Dean Witter Reynolds, whose offices were in the World Trade Center in lower Manhattan. He moved to Morristown, New Jersey, and commuted to a pair of towers that stood a quarter of a mile into the sky.

◆◆◆

Rescorla worried. It was his job to worry, but he did it with unusual imagination. After Pan Am Flight 103 was blown up over Lockerbie, Scotland, in

December 1988, he began to look at the towers the way an attacker might.

In 1990 he invited Dan Hill to come and look with him. Hill had trained in counterterrorism. The two old friends walked down into the public parking garage beneath the towers, where anyone could drive in, and Hill stopped beside a load-bearing column that was easy to reach. *This is a soft touch*, Hill said. *I'd drive a truck full of explosives in here, walk out, and light it off.*

They wrote it up. Rescorla and Hill took their report to the Port Authority of New York and New Jersey, which owned the buildings, and urged tighter security in the garage. According to James B. Stewart, who later wrote a biography of Rescorla, their recommendations were expensive and were not adopted.

Shortly after noon on 26 February 1993, a rented van packed with explosives blew up in that garage. It had been parked, by Stewart's account, about thirty feet from the spot Hill had pointed to. Six people were killed and more than a thousand injured. Smoke filled the stairwells of both towers. In the Dean Witter offices, by one account, Rescorla climbed on top of a desk, took command, and directed the evacuation. Others saw him on a tenth-floor landing with a bullhorn, sending people down, singing a Cornish song, and then going back inside to make sure no one from his firm had been left.

◆ ◆ ◆

After 1993 he was no longer a man who might be right. He had been right, and he could not stop seeing what came next.

He hired Hill as a consultant. Together they kept turning the problem over. The towers had been attacked from below, and they had stood. The two men came to believe, as Stewart tells it, that the next attack would come from the air, perhaps a plane flown into the towers, perhaps a cargo plane loaded with explosives. Accounts of exactly what they pictured differ. What does not differ is that Rescorla told his employers the firm should leave the World Trade Center and move to New Jersey. The lease ran until 2006. The firm stayed.

So he did the only other thing he could. He made people practise leaving.

The 1993 bombing had taught hard lessons. The backup lights in the stairwells had failed, and so had communications; people had felt their way down through smoke and darkness. Rescorla and the firm's managers worked with the Port Authority on fixes. Employees were given a small card, the size of a business card, to keep in their wallets. It carried a toll-free number and one instruction: *Call this number in the event of evacuation or closing of the World Trade Center buildings.*

After Dean Witter merged with Morgan Stanley in 1997, the combined firm became the largest tenant in the World Trade Center, with more than twenty floors of the South Tower and offices in a building nearby. Rescorla's office was on the 44th floor.

Every few months, every employee had to walk out. The firm's later accounts say the drills ran every quarter; others who knew him recalled them as more frequent still. Senior executives were not excused. Visitors were expected to join in. Rescorla stood with a stopwatch and timed the slow ones. He taught them to go down the stairwells two by two, so that the stairs would not jam, and he appointed floor marshals to sweep each floor.

People hated it. They were bankers and traders and assistants with calls to return and markets moving, and here was this big Cornishman with a bullhorn making them walk down dozens of flights of stairs in their good shoes for no reason. Phil Purcell, the firm's chief executive, put it plainly years afterward: *We made everybody walk eight floors. Every quarter. They hated me for that.*

Rescorla kept running them. A friend, Fred McBee, remembered how he explained it: in times of crisis, Rescorla used to say, men don't rise to the occasion, they default to their training. He wanted the way down to live in their legs, so that on the worst morning of their lives their bodies would know where to go before their minds had caught up.

◆ ◆ ◆

By then he was living with something else. In 1994 he had been diagnosed with prostate cancer. He had surgery. By 1998 it had spread to his bone marrow. His first marriage had ended. He was nearly sixty, and he went running in the mornings near Morristown without shoes.

That was how he met Susan Greer, in July 1998. He was jogging barefoot past her house. On their first date, as she remembered it, he asked her a question nobody had asked her quite that way before. *What are you about?*

They married on 20 February 1999 in St Augustine, Florida. Dan Hill was best man, for the second time in his friend's life. In May 2000 they went to Hayle together, so she could see the harbour and the dunes and the town where the American soldiers had marched. In August he told colleagues the cancer was in remission. He was making plans. They had been married for two and a half years.

◆◆◆

On 11 September 2001 he was at work before half past seven.

At 8:46 a.m. American Airlines Flight 11 struck the North Tower. From the 44th floor of the South Tower, Rescorla heard the explosion and saw the fire across the plaza. Over the public address system in the South Tower, a Port Authority announcement told people that their building was secure and they should stay at their desks.

Rescorla called Dan Hill. Officials had told him not to evacuate, he said. He was getting his people out anyway, and he said so in language a soldier uses. He told Hill he thought everything above the point of impact in the North Tower would come down, and that the South Tower might be next.

Then he picked up his bullhorn, a walkie-talkie and his mobile phone, and he ordered the evacuation of

every Morgan Stanley employee in the building. About a thousand more of the firm's people worked in 5 World Trade Center, a low building on the plaza, and they went too. By one account, he ran up and down more than twenty floors that morning, floor after floor, telling people to go. In one account, his order was as plain as a drill: *Get out and start marching.*

The firm's people had walked those stairs so many times that they did not have to think. *I knew where to go, just by rote,* one of them, Patti Monachino, said afterward. *I went straight to the exit.* They went down two by two, the way he had made them practise and complain about it. The floor marshals swept their floors. On the 44th floor, where the stairwells bottlenecked, Rescorla kept the crowd moving and away from the elevators, and told them to stay calm.

At 9:03 a.m., while thousands of them were already in the stairwells, United Airlines Flight 175 struck the South Tower between the 77th and 85th floors. The lights went out. One employee, Kathy Comerford, was knocked out of her shoes and thrown against a marble wall. *I was within inches of Rick,* she said later. *He was on that bullhorn, in the pitch black, reassuring people.*

He sang. Survivors remembered it in different ways, which is how memory works in a smoky stairwell. Some remembered the Cornish songs of his boyhood, among them one set to the old Welsh tune "Men of Harlech." Some remembered him singing "God Bless America" through the bullhorn. His wife

said that he sang Cornish songs and whispered encouragement to people as he guided them down. Camille Prelli remembered his words in between: *We're good Americans, walk down slowly, be good Americans.*

◆◆◆

Sometime in those minutes he called Susan.

She was at home in New Jersey, watching the towers burn on television, and she was crying. She told the story many times afterward, and the words shift a little from one telling to another, the way the words of a last call do. In one telling he said, *Stop crying. I have to get these people out safely.* In another, *You have to stop crying. I have to get everyone out.* Then he said the thing she kept. *If something happens to me, I want you to know that you made my life.* In some tellings he added that he had never been happier.

You made my life, too, she said.

The line went dead. She kept watching the television, and she saw the building come down.

◆◆◆

By the time the people from Morgan Stanley were reaching the lobby and the street, nearly all of them were out. A colleague found Rescorla in the stairwell and told him he had to leave too. *As soon as I make sure everyone else is out,* he said.

He went back up. With him went three men from his security team. Wesley Mercer was his deputy, a war veteran who lived in Harlem with his partner, Bill

Randolph; he dressed formally even to walk the dog. Jorge Velazquez worked security for the firm. Godwin Forde, thirty-eight, had been born in London and had come to Brooklyn in 1991 to visit his sister and stayed.

Rescorla was last seen on the 10th floor of the South Tower, heading up the stairs. One record places Godwin Forde on the 42nd floor when the tower fell. At 9:59 a.m., fifty-six minutes after it was struck, the South Tower collapsed.

Of the roughly 2,700 Morgan Stanley employees in the South Tower that morning, all but a handful came home. The firm lost thirteen people that day, eight employees and five contractors, and the four security men who went back up were among them. The figure most often given for those Rescorla's evacuation saved is 2,687. On the first night, the firm's list of missing stood at 750. The next night it was 250. Then it was thirteen.

In the weeks that followed, the people who had walked out tried to explain to reporters and to each other why they were alive. Mandell Crawley, a Morgan Stanley executive, said Rescorla's decision to ignore the order to stay *made all the difference in the world. Rick Rescorla,* he said, *he instinctively knew that we were under attack.* What had looked, on a hundred ordinary afternoons, like an old soldier's obsession had been rehearsed into the legs of people who mostly wished he would leave them alone.

It put a hole in my stomach, Bill Randolph said of Wesley Mercer's death. *But I knew that's what he would have done.*

Dan Hill said Rescorla could not have lived with himself unless he was the last man out of that building. *I lost the world,* Hill said, *when Rick died.*

◆◆◆

His remains were never identified. He had asked to be cremated and to have his ashes scattered in Hayle. There was nothing to scatter.

Susan Rescorla asked herself, in the first weeks, the question that people who are left behind ask. *Why was I left?* On 27 October 2001 the family held a small memorial, and a hawk was released into the sky. Near their home there is a bird sanctuary called the Raptor Trust, and a plaque for him there; it was the only memorial he had ever asked for.

Then she gave herself a task. She said she had a new mission: *to not let people forget not only what happened to Rick, but what happened to America.* She travelled the country telling his story. In Hayle the town held a memorial service for the boy it had called Tammy. His life became a statue and an opera, *Heart of a Soldier*, in which a baritone sang the part of a man who had sung to frightened people in the dark.

On 7 November 2019, at the White House, Susan accepted the Presidential Citizens Medal on his behalf. Some sixty Vietnam veterans were in the room, among them men who had fought in the Ia Drang. When she spoke, she remembered how he

had sung Cornish songs and whispered encouragement on the stairs. She remembered his *three men*, who had followed the firefighters up the South Tower with him. She remembered the question on their first date. That day the citation was read aloud, and the words of his old commander were quoted again, in their fuller form: *quite simply the best platoon leader of infantry I have ever known in two wars.* The men in the room who had heard Rescorla sing in the Ia Drang had been young men then. They were in their seventies now, and they had come to stand up for him.

◆ ◆ ◆

Today the stairwells he drilled no longer exist. The towers' footprints are two square pools of falling water, and his name is cut in bronze on panel S-46 at the South Pool. The names of Wesley Mercer, Jorge Velazquez and Godwin Forde are cut into the bronze around the same pool.

The habits he insisted on have spread far past those stairs. Office buildings and schools and hospitals run evacuation drills that people still roll their eyes at, still walk through in their good shoes with their coffee going cold. In 2021 the New Jersey Senate voted to make 27 May, his birthday, Richard Rescorla Day. On that date, in the harbour town where he was born, the tide still goes out twice a day and comes back in.

More than two thousand six hundred people walked down from the South Tower that morning because someone had made them do it before. Some of them

were young. They went on to marry, to change jobs, to have children who have never known a world with the towers in it. Those children are in college now, or starting work, or learning to drive.

Somewhere this morning, a man in his fifties is walking down a staircase in an office building in New Jersey, one hand on the rail, not thinking about it at all. His legs know the way. A long time ago, a big Cornishman with a stopwatch made him practise.

> Side note: In the hills above the fishing village of Aneyoshi, on Japan's northeast coast, stands an old stone tablet carved after deadly tsunamis struck that coast generations ago. Its words read, in translation: *High dwellings are the peace and harmony of our descendants. Remember the calamity of the great tsunamis. Do not build any homes below this point.* For generations the families of Aneyoshi listened to it and kept their houses above the stone. When the great tsunami came in March 2011, the village climbed to higher ground. Someone's fear, carved into rock long before, had been looking after children its carvers would never meet.

Question: Who in your life has made you practise for something you hoped would never happen, and what might you say to them now?

Question: What are three ways that what is happening could be kind?

Action: The next time fear rises, breathe in gently through your nose, take a second small sip of air on top, and let it all out long and slow through your mouth. Repeat at a comfortable pace for up to five minutes, and notice whether your body settles.

Chapter Nine

Lard

———

Honey

"*No one is useless in this world who lightens the burden of it for any one else.*" — Charles Dickens, *Our Mutual Friend* (1864–65), Book the Third, Chapter 9

◆ ◆ ◆

The town cooked with lard.

The families of Roseto, Pennsylvania, fried in pork fat more often than in olive oil, and fatty meats were common on their tables. When doctors measured what the town ate, fat made up about thirty-eight percent of the calories the men took in and about forty-three percent for the women, close to the American average of the day. Their cholesterol looked like the cholesterol of Framingham, Massachusetts, where the country's best-known heart study was under way. Many of the adults were overweight. About a third of the men smoked. By the doctors' account, smoking, lack of exercise and rich food were as common in Roseto as in the towns around it.

And the people of Roseto were not dying of heart attacks.

◆ ◆ ◆

The man who first noticed was a local physician named Benjamin Falcone, who had practiced in the area for seventeen years. In 1961, by most accounts, he mentioned it to Stewart Wolf, the head of the department of medicine at the University of Oklahoma. Falcone told him that he rarely saw heart disease among Rosetans below a certain age. The accounts differ on the age: in some it was fifty, in others sixty-five. Either way, it made no sense. Heart disease was the leading cause of death in the United States, and Roseto was in the United States.

Wolf had spent his career on how feelings act on the body, and he did not trust a hunch. He went looking for numbers.

Roseto was small, about 1,600 people, and about ninety-five percent of them traced their families to a single hill town in southern Italy, Roseto Valfortore, in the province of Foggia. The first of them had come in 1882 to work in the slate quarries.

Wolf and his colleagues gathered the death certificates for Roseto and four neighboring towns for the years 1955 through 1961. They examined residents and measured their diets and their blood. The result held. Roseto's death rate from heart attack was less than half that of the towns around it. Among men, adjusted for age, it came to about one death per thousand a year, against a national figure

of three and a half. Among women it was six-tenths of one per thousand, against a little over two.

In June 1964 Wolf and three colleagues published the findings in the *Journal of the American Medical Association* under a plain, almost puzzled title: *Unusually Low Incidence of Death From Myocardial Infarction*. They did not claim to know the cause. It was, they wrote, *not clear at the present moment.* But they had a suspicion, and it was not about food.

◆◆◆

To follow it, Wolf brought in a sociologist, John Bruhn, whose job was to learn how the town lived. Bruhn and his team interviewed Roseto's adults.

What they found was a town organized around the family, and a family that did not stop at its own front door. Many households held three generations under one roof. When trouble came, it was faced jointly, with relatives and friends behind the family. After a death, old quarrels between families were set aside, and the mourners were brought food and money. When a household fell into money trouble, relatives and friends came to its aid. The families who had done well did not show it. The researchers noted an *absence of ostentation even among the wealthy*, and Wolf later put it more simply to a reporter: *There was no keeping up with the Joneses.*

Decades afterward, Bruhn described the town to the writer Malcolm Gladwell. *There was no suicide*, he said, *no alcoholism, no drug addiction, and very little crime.* The people of Roseto, as he saw it, were

dying of old age. That's it. It was a recollection, not a count; the published papers make no such claim.

The team's working idea was that this way of living took something off people. No one in Roseto carried a crisis alone. In the careful language of the journal, a *sensible way of life, with social support and close family ties* might buffer the effects of stress on the heart.

An idea like that could be tested, and in 1963 Bruhn and Wolf made a prediction that would test it. They had noticed that the young people of Roseto, the teenagers and the adults between twenty-five and thirty-five, respected the old ways and were ready to leave most of them behind. If the town's close-knit social structure began to come apart, they wrote, its protection from heart-attack death would fade.

◆◆◆

It did.

Through the 1960s Roseto became, in the researchers' words, *a less cohesive, materialistic, more 'Americanized' community.* Three-generation households became uncommon. Marrying outside the Italian community became the norm. Bit by bit, the way Rosetans lived came to look like the way people lived in Bangor.

Wolf kept watching for twenty-five years. In 1992 he and three colleagues published the long view in the *American Journal of Public Health*, drawn from 3,859 death certificates from Roseto and Bangor covering fifty years, from 1935 to 1985. For the first thirty years, Roseto's death rate from heart attack

was lower than Bangor's, for men and for women. After 1965 the difference disappeared. In the decade that followed, heart-attack deaths in Roseto rose sharply, most dramatically in men under sixty-five, the fathers and wage-earners who had once been the town's great statistical surprise. By 1975, Wolf and Bruhn later wrote, Roseto's rates had reached those of the neighboring towns.

The authors chose their words with care. Social cohesion, they wrote, *may have been protective.*

◆ ◆ ◆

The town paid for the lesson, and the lesson had its own costs.

Roseto's advantage rested on small numbers. The town had about 1,600 people and Bangor more than five thousand, and in a place that size a few deaths either way move a rate a great deal. The authors knew it and tested for it, and the difference held. But the doubts came early. Ancel Keys, the leading diet researcher of the time, argued that the Oklahoma team had not ruled out food and pressed them for data on saturated fat that they did not have. Wolf replied that no one had claimed diet was unimportant. The original study had counted heart attacks that were *proven anatomically, established clinically, and presumed*, which left room for argument. Other researchers pointed out that the old diet changed as the town changed: by the French scientist Serge Renaud's account, by 1985 the use of olive oil in Roseto had fallen by half, and the share of Rosetans who made their own wine had

dropped from half to a tenth. In 2024 two researchers writing in a wine-science journal proposed that moderate wine drinking explained the old advantage. Later reviewers have argued that the social explanation was never proven and have pointed to flaws in the early methods.

So the idea could not stand on Roseto alone. It needed a far larger test, and a sharper question. Was it being cared for that protected the people of Roseto, or was it the caring?

◆ ◆ ◆

In 2010 a psychologist at Brigham Young University named Julianne Holt-Lunstad and two colleagues gathered the studies that had followed people over time and measured both their relationships and whether they lived. There were 148 of them, covering 308,849 people, followed for an average of seven and a half years. Across all of them, stronger social relationships were associated with about fifty percent greater odds of surviving the follow-up, which is not the same as living half as long again. For the fullest measures of how woven a person was into other lives, the figure rose to about ninety percent. The authors set the effect beside the known killers and found it comparable to quitting smoking, and larger than the effects of obesity and physical inactivity.

They were plain about the limit. No one can randomly assign people to be lonely for a decade, and so, as they wrote, *causality is not easily*

established. What they could say was that the pattern seen in Roseto was not peculiar to Roseto.

Connection runs both ways, though, and seven years earlier, in Michigan, another psychologist had already pulled the two directions apart.

Stephanie Brown, at the University of Michigan, had five years of records on 423 older married couples. In those five years, 134 of the people had died. Brown looked at what each had said at the start about the help they gave and the help they got. The giving was ordinary: transportation, errands, shopping, housework, minding a child, or, for a spouse, being willing to listen when the other needed to talk.

The people who gave no help at all were more than twice as likely to die in those five years as the people who gave some. Receiving help showed no link to living longer. Brown worried that the result might be an illusion, that sick people simply give less and die sooner, so she controlled for age, health, mood, income and education. The pattern held. *It isn't what we get from relationships that makes contact with others so beneficial*, she said of the findings. *It's what we give.* She was careful to call it an association. Giving had been observed, not assigned. The study appeared in *Psychological Science* in 2003.

Ten years later Brown and a psychologist at the University at Buffalo, Michael Poulin, came at the question through hard times. They followed 846 people in the Detroit area for five years and asked

what had gone wrong in their lives in the past year: a serious illness, a burglary, a lost job, money trouble, the death of someone in the family. Among people who had not helped anyone, stressful events were tied to about a thirty percent higher risk of dying. Among people who had spent time helping friends, neighbors or relatives, the stressful events showed no link to dying at all. *Helping others*, Poulin said, *reduced mortality specifically by buffering the association between stress and mortality.* It was the old Roseto idea, phrased the way a statistician would phrase it.

That same year, Morris Okun and his colleagues pooled the studies of older adults who volunteer. Volunteers had a forty-seven percent lower risk of dying over the study periods. When the researchers accounted for the fact that healthier, better-off people volunteer more, the figure fell by half, to twenty-four percent. Half was what remained after the honest adjustment, and it was still there.

◆◆◆

Correlations, however many, cannot settle cause. For that, someone had to assign the kindness by chance and see what happened.

At a high school in an inner-city neighborhood of Vancouver, a doctoral student named Hannah Schreier, working with Kimberly Schonert-Reichl and Edith Chen at the University of British Columbia, divided 106 tenth-graders into two groups at random. One group spent an hour a week through the autumn term, ten weeks in all, helping younger

children in after-school programs in their own neighborhood. The other group waited its turn. At the end, the teenagers who had been helping had lower levels of interleukin 6, a marker of inflammation, lower cholesterol and a lower body-mass index than those on the waiting list. The volunteers whose empathy and altruism grew the most showed the largest gains in cardiovascular health. The trial was published in 2013.

A few years later another doctoral student at the same university, Ashley Whillans, gave older adults money. There were 128 of them, aged sixty-five to eighty-five. For three weeks each received forty dollars a week, with instructions to spend it in a single day and keep the receipts. Some were assigned to spend it on themselves, some on other people. Among the seventy-three who already had high blood pressure, those who spent on others saw their blood pressure come down over the course of the study, by an amount the researchers compared to the effect of blood-pressure medication or exercise. Those who spent on themselves saw no change. The benefit looked strongest when the money went to people they felt close to, though Whillans called that part tentative.

◆ ◆ ◆

The body was one place to look. The mind gave quicker answers.

Elizabeth Dunn, a psychologist at the University of British Columbia, her student Lara Aknin, and Michael Norton of Harvard Business School asked

forty-six people one morning how happy they were. Then they handed each one an envelope. Inside was five dollars or twenty, with an instruction to spend it by five o'clock that afternoon, either on themselves, a bill or a treat, or on someone else, a gift or a donation. After five the researchers called. Those who had spent on others were happier than those who had spent on themselves, and it made no difference whether the envelope had held five dollars or twenty. When the team asked 109 students to predict the outcome, most guessed wrong on both counts. They expected the larger sum and the purchase for themselves to win. The authors called them *doubly wrong*. The paper ran in *Science* in 2008. A larger, preregistered replication by Aknin, Dunn and colleagues in 2020 found the effect again, and found that its size depended on how a study was run.

By then Aknin had taken the question around the world. Using a Gallup survey of 234,917 people in 136 countries, she and her colleagues found a positive link between giving and well-being in 120 of them, rich and poor alike. In their model, giving to charity went with a rise in well-being about as large as a doubling of household income. In Vancouver and Cape Town, students given a small voucher could buy a bag of chocolate and juice for themselves, or the same bag for a sick child at a nearby hospital whom they would never meet. Those who bought for the child felt better. *The psychological reward experienced from helping*

others, Aknin said, *may be deeply ingrained in human nature.*

In Eugene, Oregon, the economist William Harbaugh and his colleagues had already gone looking for that reward. They placed nineteen women in a brain scanner and watched as some of their money went to a food bank, sometimes taken like a tax, sometimes given by choice. Either way, reward areas deep in the brain that respond to food and other basic pleasures became active. They were more active when the gift was voluntary. *We actually see people getting rewards as they give up money*, Harbaugh said. The study ran in *Science* in 2007.

In California, the psychologist Sonja Lyubomirsky asked students to do five acts of kindness a week for six weeks. The students who did all five on a single day grew happier. The students who spread them across the week showed no measurable change; the kindnesses, she suggested, blended into ordinary life. Kindness, she said, could *jump-start a whole cascade of positive social consequences.* Other claims have fared less well. A widely cited 2013 study by Bethany Kok and Barbara Fredrickson reported that loving-kindness meditation strengthened the heart's vagal tone, and a reanalysis by other researchers in 2015 challenged the finding. It remains in dispute.

◆ ◆ ◆

The kindness of a doctor can be measured too, and it turns out to be short.

In 1999 the psychologist Linda Fogarty and her colleagues showed 210 women a videotape of an oncologist explaining treatment choices for metastatic breast cancer. Half saw the standard tape. The other half saw the same consultation with two short additions, about forty seconds in all, in which the doctor acknowledged the patient's worry, offered partnership and support, told her that her feelings and the difficulty of the decision made sense, and touched her hand. The medical facts were identical. Anxiety rose in everyone who watched; this was hard news. It rose less in the women who saw the forty seconds, and they rated the doctor as warmer, more sensitive and more caring. The study's title asked a question, *Can 40 seconds of compassion reduce patient anxiety?*, and the answer was yes.

◆ ◆ ◆

The last question was money, and here the evidence is thinnest.

In 2007 the economist Arthur Brooks, then at Syracuse University, used a survey of about thirty thousand people in more than forty American communities to argue that giving and earning feed each other. Brooks's model suggested the arrow also ran the other way: a family that gave a hundred dollars more to charity than an otherwise similar family earned, on average, about three hundred and seventy-five dollars more. The figure comes from his own statistical modeling of one survey. No one has run the experiment.

Adam Grant, an organizational psychologist at the Wharton School, looked at work. In his 2013 book *Give and Take* he gathered studies of people who help others without keeping score, whom he called givers. Givers crowded the bottom of the ladder. Among Belgian medical students and among engineers, the lowest performers were often givers. But givers also filled the top: the best medical students, and salespeople who brought in half again as much revenue as their colleagues. What separated the two groups, as Grant read it, was whether the givers also looked after their own needs. These are correlations, built largely on people's own reports. They describe who rises. They do not prove why.

◆ ◆ ◆

In May 2023 the Surgeon General of the United States, Vivek Murthy, issued an eighty-one-page advisory on what he called an epidemic of loneliness and isolation. It compared the health risk of prolonged loneliness to smoking up to fifteen cigarettes a day, and it asked Americans to build a culture of connection grounded in kindness, respect, service and commitment to one another. Its lead scientific author was Julianne Holt-Lunstad, who had counted the 308,849.

Roseto is still there, a borough of 1,581 people at the 2020 census, close to the number it held when the doctors from Oklahoma came. Its name is attached now to an effect in medicine, in honor of a town that lost the thing it had and, in losing it, showed everyone else what it was.

Somewhere this afternoon, a man in his seventies is backing his car out of the driveway to take a neighbor to a doctor's appointment. He will wait in the lobby with an old magazine, drive her home, and carry her bag to the door. He does not think of it as medicine. On a questionnaire in Michigan, all of it would have fit into a single word: *transportation.* Stephanie Brown counted that word, and the people who could write it down were less likely to die in the five years that followed.

> Side note: In 1938 Harvard researchers began following 268 sophomores, and later added 456 men from Boston's inner city, to learn what makes a good life. The study is still running more than eighty years later. The psychiatrist George Vaillant, who led it from 1972 to 2004, summed up what it taught him: *the key to healthy aging is relationships, relationships, relationships.* His successor, the psychiatrist Robert Waldinger, found that the people most satisfied in their relationships at fifty were the healthiest at eighty. *Taking care of your body is important*, Waldinger said, *but tending to your relationships is a form of self-care too.*

Question: Who would you call at two in the morning, who would call you, and when did you last do something for one of them without being asked?

Question: What are three ways that what is happening could be kind?

Action: Today, offer one specific, practical help to someone nearby: a ride, an errand, a meal, an hour of minding a child, or simply listening while they talk. Name the day and the time when you offer it, so it is easy to say yes.

Chapter Ten

The Brown Envelope

———

Gold

"*Faithful are the wounds of a friend.*" —
Proverbs 27:6, King James Version

◆◆◆

In 1965 a young man named Peter Buxtun saw a flier for a job in San Francisco. The city's venereal disease programme, run with the United States Public Health Service, needed interviewers. He was twenty-eight, with an army hitch and a degree from the University of Oregon behind him. *San Francisco, working in VD control?* he remembered thinking. *What a stitch!*

He was hired in December. The work was plainer than it sounds and more intimate. When a patient came into a clinic with syphilis or gonorrhoea, an interviewer like Buxtun sat down and asked who else might be infected. Then he went out into the city, to neighbourhoods like the Castro, and found those people and persuaded them to come in. The purpose of every conversation was the same. Find the people who were sick, and get penicillin into them.

◆◆◆

He had been born Peter Jan Buxbaum, in Prague, in 1937, to a Jewish father and an Austrian Catholic mother. Early in 1939, as Hitler's shadow fell across Czechoslovakia, the family slipped out, and in time they settled on a ranch in Oregon's Willamette Valley, a long way from Prague. Somewhere along the way the family name became Buxtun. Of Prague he kept one memory above the others. *I clearly remember my father telling people to get out,* he said.

◆◆◆

One day in the office coffee room, Buxtun heard colleagues talking about a case in Alabama. Accounts differ on the details; he told it more than once over the years. A man near Tuskegee had syphilis. His family had taken him to a local doctor, and the doctor had done the obvious thing and given him penicillin. Public Health Service officials were angry. The man, it turned out, was a subject in a government study, and he was not supposed to be treated. The doctor, in the phrases Buxtun remembered, had *ruined their study* and *jogged their statistics*.

Buxtun could not make the story fit. *I was aghast,* he said. His whole job was to find infected people and get them treated. *I didn't want to believe it,* he said later. *This was the Public Health Service. We didn't do things like that.*

So he picked up the telephone and called the Communicable Disease Center in Atlanta and asked

about the study. *I said,* '*Send me everything.*' What came back was a brown manila envelope with about ten reports inside. Decades later he still had it.

The reports described a study that had begun in 1932 in Macon County, Alabama, a poor cotton county around the town of Tuskegee. The Public Health Service, working with the Tuskegee Institute, had enrolled some six hundred Black men, most of them sharecroppers. About four hundred had syphilis. About two hundred did not, and served as controls. None of them were told that the study was about syphilis. The men were told they were being treated for *bad blood*, a local phrase that could mean anything from anaemia to fatigue to syphilis. In return for taking part they were given free medical examinations, hot meals on examination days, rides to the clinic, and the promise that their funeral expenses would be paid. They also agreed, though few could have understood it, to an autopsy after death.

What the study was really watching was what untreated syphilis does to a man's body over the rest of his life. By the mid-1940s penicillin had become the standard cure. The men were not given it. Over the years, the reports in the envelope recorded, the study kept going, round after round, the men getting older, some of them dying.

The reports did not record what the study looked like from the inside, but the men themselves later did. Charlie Pollard, interviewed in 1972, remembered government doctors examining him, and a nurse, Eunice Rivers, giving out pain pills and

a tonic for his *bad blood*. He remembered that after twenty-five years in the programme, the men were given a certificate. Eunice Rivers, a Black public health nurse who worked with the men for decades, said years later, *I was not the doctor. I was the nurse. And nurses don't prescribe.* Heller came to think of her as naive, and used.

Some local doctors tried to treat the men anyway. One, Dr. Reginald James, recalled being told plainly: *don't treat that patient.* When one man learned he had syphilis and went to a clinic in Montgomery for help, by one account the clinic was warned it could lose its federal funding if it treated another of the study's subjects.

Buxtun took the reports to the public library downtown. He had been reading there about the war crimes trials in Germany, about what doctors had done to prisoners in the camps. *It was toward the end of the evening in that library downtown,* he said, *and I thought: I've got to do something.*

◆◆◆

His boss, a man with a wife and children and a job to keep, asked him to keep his name out of whatever he was going to do. Some colleagues asked the same. By Buxtun's account one warning was more direct: if he made a big fuss, he would be fired.

In November 1966, twenty-nine years old and less than a year into the job, he wrote anyway, to Dr. William J. Brown, the director of the Division of Venereal Diseases. He asked whether the men had ever been told what the study was. He asked

whether men with untreated syphilis were still being followed until they died, for the autopsy. He compared the study, plainly, to what the Nazi doctors had done.

The answer was a summons. In March 1967 he was called to Atlanta. He thought, he said later, that they might have decided he was an alcoholic, or a lunatic of some sort. He was taken downstairs to a conference room and seated at the far end of a long table, facing senior men of the agency. Brown was there. So was Dr. John Cutler, a veteran of the venereal disease programme, who did most of the talking. Buxtun later described Brown as *a mousy little bureaucrat* and Cutler as *bursting with rage*. Buxtun's own memories of Cutler's words vary a little across interviews. In one he recalled Cutler saying, *This is serious work we are doing.* In another, *Now see here young man, we're getting a lot of good information from this study.*

Buxtun had come prepared. He opened one of the reports from the envelope, a report Cutler's name was on, and read aloud a passage observing that the men would not have joined the study without the *suasion* of the burial money. Cutler said he hadn't written that. The room went quiet and uneasy.

Make no mistake, Buxtun said many years later, *my confrontation with the CDC aristocracy was intended to get rid of me.*

He went back to San Francisco and kept his job, for the moment, and kept the envelope.

◆◆◆

The study went on. In April 1968 Martin Luther King Jr. was shot in Memphis, and American cities burned. In November, seven months later, Buxtun wrote to Brown again. This time he added an argument aimed at the agency's own interest. He wrote of his *grave moral doubts about the propriety of this study.* He wrote: *The group is 100% negro. This in itself is political dynamite.* He wrote that it would be *morally unethical* to begin such a study today. And he ended with a plain request: *I earnestly hope that you will inform me that the study group has been, or soon will be, treated.*

This time there was a response of a kind. Early in 1969 the agency convened a panel of physicians, which Brown described as a committee of professionals from outside the Communicable Disease Center, to consider whether the remaining men should be treated. The panel decided the study should go on. Brown wrote to Buxtun that the committee *did not agree nor recommend that the study group be treated.*

Buxtun was appalled. He had no movement behind him, no newspaper, no allies inside the agency. He had left the Public Health Service by then and was studying law, with an envelope of reports and a conviction. *I didn't dedicate my life to catch the bad guys,* he said much later, *but it just irked me what was going on down there.*

He graduated from law school in San Francisco in 1971. He could have let it go. He did not. He tried to interest journalists, and some of them listened politely over pizza and told him, more or less, that

they heard stories like his all the time. He kept raising it, for years, with anyone he thought might act. In the end one person did.

◆◆◆

Her name was Edith Lederer, and she was a reporter for the Associated Press in San Francisco. They met through friends; by his account, he raised the subject at a dinner party. *What? Black people? All of them black?* she asked. He drove her to his apartment and she sat on his couch and read the reports from the envelope. When she asked if she could borrow them to make copies, he said, *I wish you would!*

Lederer passed them on within the AP, and the story was given to Jean Heller, the only woman on the agency's small special assignment team. *I think there might be something here,* Lederer told her.

Heller was covering the Democratic National Convention that July. When she began digging, she could at first find no hard evidence, and nobody wanted to talk. Then she found something no one had thought to hide: an obscure medical journal in which the study's own researchers had been publishing their results for years, in plain sight. When she went back to the government with the articles in her hand, officials confirmed it. *It just made me furious,* she said fifty years later. *I could not believe that an agency of the federal government... could let this continue for 40 years.*

Her story moved on the AP wire and ran first in the *Washington Star* on 25 July 1972. The next morning

it was on the front page of *The New York Times*, and of newspapers across the country.

It just blew the story wide open, Buxtun said.

◆ ◆ ◆

In Macon County, Charles Pollard read the story. He was a farmer and a leader in his community, sixty-six years old that summer, and one of the men in the study. The next morning he walked into the Tuskegee law office of Fred Gray, the civil rights lawyer who had represented Rosa Parks and Martin Luther King Jr. Gray later remembered that Pollard *asked me if I had been reading in the newspaper about the men.*

The truth did not land softly on the men it was meant to free. Heller went to Tuskegee right away, and Pollard told her that *people cross the street to avoid shaking my hand.* Heller remembered thinking, *I've ruined their lives*. Years later Pollard's daughter, Ralphine Pollard Harper, said her father never liked talking about the study. He was angry about it. He said the men had been made into *guinea pigs*.

Fred Gray was a Montgomery native who kept a law office in Tuskegee. Asked that year what the men had been told, he answered carefully: *I think they were told all that the people who were in charge of the program wanted to tell them.*

Then things began to move. Inside the Department of Health, Education, and Welfare, staff members staged a sit-in in the office of the secretary, Caspar Weinberger. An advisory panel from outside the

agency concluded that the study was *ethically unjustified* and advised that it be stopped. On 16 November 1972, forty years after it began, Weinberger's department ended the study. For the first time in four decades, the men of the study were offered treatment by the government that had been watching them. On 24 July 1973, almost a year to the day after Heller's story, Fred Gray filed suit on behalf of the men and their families, and the case bore Charlie Pollard's name. In 1974 the government agreed to settle for ten million dollars. Each living man who had syphilis received thirty-seven thousand five hundred dollars. The government paid for the survivors' medical care, and in 1975 their wives, widows and children were added.

The cost of the forty years has been counted more than once, and the counts differ. In the first days after the story broke, the government said seven men had died directly of syphilis. Later reckonings put it at twenty-eight dead of the disease itself and about a hundred of related complications, with forty wives infected and nineteen children born with congenital syphilis.

◆ ◆ ◆

The law changed. On 12 July 1974 the National Research Act became law. It created a national commission to work out what the country owed to people who take part in medical research. In 1978 it released a short report that named three principles: respect for persons, beneficence, and justice. Out of those three principles grew the rules that now

govern research on human beings in the United States: that people must be told the truth about what is being done to them, in words they can understand; that they must agree freely; that they may stop at any time; that a board of people outside the study must review it before anyone is enrolled.

On 16 May 1997, at the White House, President Bill Clinton apologised. Five of the eight men still living had come. Herman Shaw was about to turn ninety-five. Charlie Pollard was there.

Herman Shaw went to the podium first, and the room applauded him. He spoke of the men who had not survived, and of the families who would live with what had been done. When he stepped down, the president took his hand.

The United States government did something that was wrong, Clinton said. *What was done cannot be undone. But we can end the silence.* He spoke directly to the men in the room: *what the United States government did was shameful, and I am sorry.* He spoke, too, to the children and the grandchildren. The men, Gray said, had wanted three things: their lawsuit, an apology, and a permanent memorial in Tuskegee. By that afternoon the first two were done.

Two years later, when a memorial centre was launched in Tuskegee, Peter Buxtun came.

◆ ◆ ◆

He did not fit the shape people expected of him. Reporters who came to his apartment, high on Telegraph Hill in San Francisco, where he lived for

more than fifty years, found a man with an easy laugh, a lifelong Republican and a member of the National Rifle Association, who owned dozens of guns and collected old weapons, medieval swords, Gold Rush gambling gear. Asked if he ever visited the famous radical bookshop City Lights, he said he sometimes liked to go in and ask to see their military history section.

He was not gentle about the doctors. He called Cutler his villain, and a lying bastard, and said in old age that his opinion of the man had never changed. He said he could picture Dr. Mengele saluting Cutler. And yet he said he carried little rancour. *I've moved on,* he said. *A lot of good things have happened.*

He was uneasy with praise. *I don't want to be embarrassed by an oversupply of compliments,* he said. *I am who I am. There's nothing to try to change, up or down. It's tough being a whistleblower,* he said, *when you don't even know you're a whistleblower.* In 2018, at a forum at Johns Hopkins, someone asked where he had found the moral strength to speak. *It wasn't strength,* he said. *It was stupidity.*

His friends saw something else. One, Angie Bailie, said that Peter never ended a single talk without fighting back tears. At the Centers for Disease Control, the agency whose men had once summoned him to Atlanta to be dressed down, an official named Ted Pestorius said that *Peter's life experiences led him to immediately identify the study as morally indefensible.*

He died of Alzheimer's disease in Rocklin, California, on 18 May 2024. He was eighty-six. Lillie Tyson Head, whose father had been one of the men in the study, spoke for many of the families. *We are thankful for his honesty and his courage.*

◆ ◆ ◆

The last of the men died in January 2004. The last widow receiving benefits died in January 2009. As of 2024, ten of the men's children were still receiving medical and health benefits from the programme Fred Gray's lawsuit began. Some of the descendants have come together to make sure their fathers and grandfathers are remembered by name.

Every day in the United States, in hospitals and university clinics and drug trials, people are handed a few pages to read before anyone touches them. Most people who sign them have never wondered why the pages exist. The pages say what the study is. They say what might go wrong. They say that you may refuse, and that refusing will not cost you your care. They say you may stop whenever you like.

Somewhere this afternoon, in a clinic waiting room, a woman is reading those pages slowly, a pen in her hand. She asks the nurse what one paragraph means, and the nurse explains it, because she is required to. The woman has never heard of Macon County or of a brown envelope in San Francisco. She signs her name at the bottom, or she doesn't, and either way the choice is hers.

> Side note: The document behind nearly every research consent form in the United States is

named for a place. In February 1976, the national commission created after the Tuskegee revelations met for four intensive days at the Belmont Conference Center in Elkridge, Maryland, about ten miles south of Baltimore, to work out what researchers owe the people they study. They came away with three principles, respect for persons, beneficence and justice, and the report built on them took the name of the place where it was argued into shape. Each time a stranger explains a study to you honestly and waits for your answer, a few days of argument in a quiet corner of Maryland are still at work.

Question: When have you known something true that the people around you did not want to hear, and what did you do with it?

Question: What are three ways that what is happening could be kind?

Action: Give someone a sincere, specific compliment today: something true you have noticed about them and never said out loud. Most of us underestimate how much it will mean to them.

Chapter Eleven

The Missing Page

———

Green

"*Just as my ancestors planted for me, so I plant for my children.*" — Talmud, Ta'anit 23a

◆◆◆

Frances Kathleen Oldham was born in July 1914 in a country house near Cobble Hill, on Vancouver Island, in British Columbia. By the time she finished school in Victoria, at fifteen, she had decided she was going to be a scientist.

She did her degrees in pharmacology at McGill University in Montreal. In 1936 she wrote to one of the most respected pharmacologists in America, Eugene Geiling at the University of Chicago, asking whether he might take her on.

Geiling wrote back offering her a place. The letter was addressed to *Mr. Oldham*. He had seen the name Frances and assumed it belonged to a man.

She showed the letter to her professor at McGill and asked what to do. His advice, as she remembered it, was blunt. *Don't be stupid. Accept the job, sign your name and put "Miss" in brackets afterward.*

She did, and went to Chicago, and Geiling let the mistake stand. Years later she would wonder aloud what might have happened if her name had been Elizabeth, or Mary Jane.

◆◆◆

The next year, 1937, a company in Tennessee began selling a liquid form of a new antibacterial drug called sulfanilamide. To make it pleasant to swallow, the chemists dissolved it in a sweet-tasting solvent. Nobody tested the solvent. It was diethylene glycol, a close chemical cousin of antifreeze. More than a hundred people died, many of them children.

The government asked Geiling's laboratory to find out exactly what had killed them. Frances Oldham, a graduate student, worked on the answer. She watched the laboratory animals die. She saw, at twenty-three, what happens when a manufacturer's confidence meets a molecule nobody has examined.

The disaster led directly to a new law, the Federal Food, Drug, and Cosmetic Act of 1938, which required companies to show the government that a new drug was safe before they could sell it. It had a weakness that would matter later. Once a company filed its application, the government had sixty days to object. If it said nothing, the drug was approved automatically.

During the war, studying antimalarial drugs, she saw something else that most doctors of her generation had not absorbed. Some medicines cross the placenta. What a mother takes, her unborn child

may take too. In 1940 most physicians still imagined the womb as a sealed room. She knew it had a door.

◆ ◆ ◆

In the laboratory in Chicago she met another pharmacologist, Fremont Ellis Kelsey. They married in December 1943. A rule barred married couples from working in the same department, so she went to medical school, and she earned her medical degree in 1950. *As a woman*, she said later, *I needed the extra credentials.*

They had two daughters, Susan and Christine. After dinner the couple sat and read medical journals together. The rule of the household, her daughter Christine remembered, was simple: *just question everything.*

After some years in South Dakota, where Frances worked for a time as a country doctor, Ellis took a job in Washington in 1960, and Frances applied to the Food and Drug Administration. She was forty-six. On the first of August she reported for work as a medical officer in a hot, humid temporary building, one of seven full-time physicians reviewing every new drug application in the United States.

A few weeks later she was handed a file. She remembered later why it had been given to her. *They gave it to me because they thought it would be an easy one to start on.*

◆ ◆ ◆

The file came from the William S. Merrell Company of Cincinnati, a subsidiary of the pharmaceutical

firm Richardson-Merrell. It was an application to sell a sedative under the brand name Kevadon. Its generic name was thalidomide.

The drug had been developed in West Germany, where it had been sold without a prescription since 1957. By 1960 it was available in some forty countries. It was popular because it seemed so gentle. It helped people sleep. It was hard to overdose on. Doctors prescribed it to pregnant women for nausea and for sleeplessness.

Merrell was ready. It had printed its brochures. It had raw material on hand for some fifteen million pills. It wanted the drug on American shelves by Christmas, the busiest season of the year for sleeping pills. The application arrived in September 1960, a stack of binders, she later said, about the size of four telephone books.

She read it.

What she found was mostly praise. There were testimonials from physicians saying how marvelous the drug was, and very little that looked like careful science. Some of the testimonials came from doctors whose earlier publications she did not trust. The German originals and the English translations did not always match. The animal data was odd: the drug did not seem to make laboratory animals sleepy at the doses that put people to sleep, which suggested that nobody really understood how it worked. And there was almost nothing about pregnancy. The data the company had covered only women late in pregnancy. About the early weeks,

when a child's limbs and organs are forming, there was nothing at all.

She described her feeling about it later in a sentence that does not sound like heroism. *There was just a feeling that there was something in the data, or the absence of data, that was a cause of concern.*

Her job, as she put it, was to pick new-drug applications to pieces. This one came apart in her hands.

◆◆◆

A former FDA physician named Barbara Moulton had pointed out the one lever a reviewer had. The sixty-day clock could not be stopped. But if a reviewer declared an application incomplete, the clock started over.

On the tenth of November 1960, the reviewers wrote to Merrell that the application was incomplete.

The company's liaison with the agency was a physician named Joseph Murray, a man on friendly terms with many people at the FDA. A few days after the letter, he telephoned Kelsey, distressed. He called again the next day. In December he came to Washington with a colleague to see her in person. In January he complained to her superiors and asked, in effect, why they didn't get a different reviewer. In February the calls came again. The company called her, at various times and to various people, nitpicking, unreasonable, a stubborn bureaucrat. *Most of the things they called me*, she said, decades

afterward, *you couldn't print. They thought I was nuts.*

Her immediate boss, Ralph Smith, stood behind her. So did the deputy commissioner, Winton Rankin. So did the two colleagues who reviewed the drug's chemistry and pharmacology, Lee Geismar and Jiro Oyama, whom she named, for the rest of her life, every time anyone praised her.

◆◆◆

On the last day of 1960, a letter appeared in the *British Medical Journal* from a doctor in Scotland, A. Leslie Florence, under the title "Is thalidomide to blame?" Some of his patients who had taken the drug for months had developed tingling and numbness in their hands and feet, nerve damage called peripheral neuritis. In some of them it did not go away.

Kelsey read the letter in February. *The peripheral neuritis*, she wrote later, *did not seem the sort of side effect that should come from a simple sleeping pill.* A drug that could damage the nerves of an adult might do something worse to the nerves of a child still forming. She asked the company for studies of what thalidomide did in pregnancy. She wrote to Merrell that the drug's usefulness was such that untoward reactions would be highly inexcusable. A sleeping pill, in other words, did not justify any risk at all.

I had the feeling throughout, she said, *that they were at no time being wholly frank with me.*

Every sixty days she wrote again: incomplete.

At home, every evening, she read through the advertising flyers that drug companies mailed to doctors, looking for false claims. Christine called it her mother's after-work relaxation. Frances kept her medical license partly so that the flyers would keep coming.

◆ ◆ ◆

In April 1961 thalidomide went on sale in Canada, the country of her birth. It was licensed through the same company, Merrell, and sold under the same name, Kevadon.

Across the Atlantic, doctors were seeing something they could not explain. Babies were being born with arms and legs that had barely formed, hands growing directly from the shoulders, feet from the hips. The condition had been so rare that most physicians had never seen a single case. Now there were hundreds.

In November 1961 a German pediatrician named Widukind Lenz connected them. He had sat with the mothers and asked them, one by one, what they had taken in the first weeks of pregnancy. Again and again the answer was the same gentle sleeping pill, often only a few tablets, sometimes a single dose. On the twenty-seventh of November 1961 the German maker withdrew the drug from sale. In March 1962, Merrell withdrew its American application. Canada withdrew the drug that same month, though it lingered on some pharmacy shelves into May.

That April an American pediatric cardiologist, Helen Taussig of Johns Hopkins, came back from six weeks

in Germany and called the FDA. Kelsey and a colleague, John Nestor, drove to Baltimore to hear her. Taussig told them there could be thousands of these children.

Kelsey wrote to Merrell demanding the names of every American doctor who had been given thalidomide to try. While the application sat on her desk, the company had shipped the drug to doctors as an "investigational" sample, which the law of the time did not require anyone to track. The list came back with more than twelve hundred names. Only thirty-seven had appeared in the application. Some two and a half million tablets had gone out.

◆◆◆

In July 1962, a tip about the story reached *The Washington Post*. The editors gave it to a general-assignment reporter named Morton Mintz. He went to see Kelsey in her office. Before they talked about the drug, Mintz told her about his own daughter, who had been born with Down syndrome. The two parents understood each other.

His story ran on the front page on the fifteenth of July. *This is the story*, it began, *of how the skepticism and stubbornness of a Government physician prevented what could have been an appalling American tragedy, the birth of hundreds or indeed thousands of armless and legless children.*

Letters poured into the FDA, from doctors, from mothers, from schoolchildren writing reports. Strangers mailed her checks. She sent them back.

On the seventh of August 1962, on the lawn of the White House, President John F. Kennedy hung around her neck the gold medal of the President's Award for Distinguished Federal Civilian Service, the highest honor a career government employee could receive. She was the second woman ever given it. The citation praised her exceptional judgment and her steadfast confidence in her professional decision.

She thought of the medal differently. *I thought that I was accepting the medal*, she said, *on behalf of a lot of different federal workers. This was really a team effort.*

Two months later Congress passed, without a single vote against it, the Kefauver-Harris Amendments, a law that Senator Estes Kefauver had been pushing for years against the drug industry's resistance. It required that every new drug be proven not only safe but effective before it could be sold. It required that patients give their informed consent before taking part in a trial of an experimental drug, and that the government be told before such trials began.

Frances Kelsey was put in charge of enforcing it.

◆ ◆ ◆

The story the newspapers told was simple: one woman, one refusal, a nation spared. The truth has more in it.

Thalidomide did reach American mothers, through the investigational samples. The official count of American babies born with thalidomide damage is

seventeen: nine whose mothers had been given the American samples and eight whose mothers had obtained the drug abroad. A retired FDA historian, John Swann, and the author Jennifer Vanderbes, who have studied the records closely, believe the real number may be closer to a hundred. Merrell's own follow-up of where the pills went was, in Swann's words, sloppy.

Around the world, more than ten thousand children were born damaged by the drug. Many did not live to their first birthday.

In Canada, where Kelsey was born, the drug stayed on sale under the name she had refused, from the company she had refused, for months after Germany had withdrawn it. Some thirty Canadian children are thought to have been born damaged in that delay alone. Her kindness stopped at a border.

And Frances Kelsey herself was not, in the end, right for the reason the legend gives her. She did not foresee the birth defects. She foresaw that she did not know. Her early objections were about missing data and nerve damage. She asked about pregnancy because she had learned, long before, that the womb had a door, and the company could not answer her. That turned out to be enough.

◆ ◆ ◆

In 1966 Ellis Kelsey died. That same year, she was reportedly moved to a less prominent post. She kept working, checking for decades whether the doctors running clinical trials were honest, and retired in 2005, at ninety.

She never stopped calling it a team effort.

In early 2014, almost a hundred years old, she moved into her daughter Christine's house in London, Ontario. Asked whether she would like to see Cobble Hill again, where she had been born, she said: *I sure would.*

Her own country had never formally honored her. In the summer of 2015, Canada named her to the Order of Canada. She was too frail to travel. On the sixth of August, the Lieutenant Governor of Ontario came to Christine's living room and pinned the insignia on her.

Frances Oldham Kelsey died the next morning, the seventh of August 2015, at one hundred and one, with her daughter beside her.

It was fifty-three years to the day since the afternoon on the White House lawn.

◆◆◆

Mercédes Benegbi was born in Montreal in 1962. Her mother had been prescribed thalidomide. She was born without arms. Since 2002 she has led the Thalidomide Victims Association of Canada. When Canada honored Kelsey, Benegbi was reported to have said: *To us, she was always our heroine, even if what she did was in another country.*

Gwen Riechmann was born in the United States in the early 1960s, also without fully formed arms. Her mother had been given a sedative for nausea, one of the samples Merrell sent out while the application sat on Kelsey's desk. In 2018, Riechmann co-

founded a group called USA Thalidomide Survivors. *We go to doctors today*, she told a reporter in 2026, *who say it didn't happen here in the United States.*

Both stories are true, and so is the other one: the millions of American children who were born with their arms and their hands because one reviewer kept writing "incomplete." They grew up and learned to ride bicycles and write letters and hold their own children, with no reason ever to think of a woman reading a stack of binders in a hot building in Washington in 1960.

If you have ever taken a prescription drug, it reached you through rules that her refusal helped to write. The folded paper inside the box listing the side effects; the long recital of risks at the end of a medicine advertisement; the consent form a patient signs before joining a clinical trial; the requirement that a drug be shown to work, not just to be safe: all of it traces back to 1962. When the government reviewed the drugs already on the market under the new rules, more than a thousand of them were found not to work as claimed.

And thalidomide came back. In 1998 the FDA approved it for a painful complication of leprosy, and in 2006 for multiple myeloma, a cancer of the blood, under a program so strict that women taking it must prove, month after month, that they are not pregnant. The drug that maimed ten thousand children now helps keep people alive, behind exactly the safeguards her stubbornness made possible.

Side note: In 1952 an anesthesiologist named Virginia Apgar was asked by a young resident what a doctor should check in a newborn. She wrote five things on a napkin: heart rate, breathing, color, muscle tone, and reflexes, each scored zero, one, or two. The whole test takes moments. It is given one minute after birth, to see whether the baby needs help, and again at five minutes. From 1959 until her death in 1974 she directed research on birth defects for the March of Dimes, and during the rubella epidemic of 1964 and 1965 she pressed for every child to be vaccinated. Babies all over the world are still scored this way in their first minute of life.

Question: What page is missing from a decision you are being hurried to make?

Question: What are three ways that what is happening could be kind?

Action: Write a kind note to your future self and put it in your calendar for tomorrow.

Chapter Twelve

Two Weeks Before Christmas

———

Moss

"*I think it was a wise business decision, but that isn't why I did it. I did it because it was the right thing to do.*" — Aaron Feuerstein, to CBS News, *60 Minutes*, 2003

◆◆◆

On the evening of December 11, 1995, Aaron Feuerstein was at a party for his seventieth birthday. The birthday itself was eight days away. Somewhere in the evening the news reached him: his mill was burning.

The mill was Malden Mills, and it stood on the line between Lawrence and Methuen, in the Merrimack Valley of Massachusetts, north of Boston. His grandfather Henry Feuerstein, an immigrant from Hungary, had started the business in 1906 in the town of Malden, knitting and dyeing cloth. In the 1950s Aaron and his father moved the company into the old brick mills of Lawrence, and by the end of that decade he was running it.

Lawrence was a mill city from the start, and for generations its looms drew immigrant workers. By the 1950s most of New England's textile owners were closing their mills and moving south, where labor was cheaper. Feuerstein stayed. *Cheap labor is not the only ingredient that makes a successful business*, he said in 1973, when the state gave the company a citation for keeping its work in Massachusetts.

Staying had its own hard years. In 1981 the company went into Chapter 11 bankruptcy and laid off hundreds of people. What carried it out was a fabric. In the late 1970s the mill had been making a polyester bunting for baby clothes, and Feuerstein's people worked with Yvon Chouinard of Patagonia to turn it into something a climber could wear. Patagonia sold it as Synchilla in 1981. Malden sold the same fleece to everyone else, first as Polarfleece and, from 1986, as Polartec. By 1995 fleece was about half of the company's sales, which accounts put between four hundred and five hundred million dollars a year.

The people who made it were mostly immigrants and their children, and many of them were Hispanic. The company paid an average of $12.50 an hour, when the industry average was about $9.44. A local contractor named Norman Menzies put it plainly to a reporter: *This place here has put first-generation immigrants into the middle class.*

◆◆◆

Hundreds of people were on the night shift. A little after eight o'clock, by the count of the federal fire report, something exploded in the flock line, where fine nylon fibers were blown onto fabric to make upholstery cloth. Investigators later concluded that the fibers had probably been ignited by an electrical spark. The temperature was below ten degrees, with snow on the roofs and a wind of forty miles an hour.

The wind took the fire through the old brick buildings. Workers helped each other out; one firefighter climbed down from his engine and, with employees beside him, carried out two injured workers. Vernon Bushway of Lawrence was at work when it began. *It was raining fire*, he said. It consumed the Monomac building, where it began, and the process building, the main mill and the dye house. Before it was over, 434 firefighters had come to fight it. It was the largest property fire loss in the history of the state, estimated at five hundred million dollars.

Twenty-seven workers went to hospitals, twelve of them with critical burns. Accounts of the injured differ by the day and the source, from twenty-two to more than thirty, and every account agrees that no one died.

When it was out, three or four of the main buildings were gone, by differing accounts. Marcelle Gagnon had worked in them for twenty-five years, side by side with her husband. *Just like I got a knife right through my heart*, she said. Jean Gagnon gave the feeling its other name: *When you work there, that's your life burning.*

Somewhere between fourteen hundred and eighteen hundred people had no place to go to work. Accounts differ on the number, because the company employed about three thousand people in all and some divisions could keep running. Christmas was fourteen days away.

◆◆◆

Feuerstein stood in the ruins the next day and said he would rebuild, there, in Lawrence. *The only thing I can do*, he told the Boston Globe, *is resurrect a horrible situation.*

His managers urged him to wait. Insurance was uncertain; nobody yet knew what the company could afford. A man who had sat in those meetings, the former vice president for sales and marketing, Robert Himmel, remembered what Feuerstein said back to them: *I'm not throwing 3,000 people out of work two weeks before Christmas.*

On December 14, three days after the fire, more than a thousand employees came to hear him. He told them that every one of them would be paid full wages for at least thirty days, while the company found a way to start again. It would cost about one and a half million dollars a week. Their health insurance would continue for ninety days. He had already given each of them a $275 Christmas bonus.

The president of the union local, Paul Coorey, had worked in the mill for thirty-five years. *Thank God we got Aaron*, he said.

Feuerstein put it more simply to his wife. *I have to be worthy*, he told her. *Too many people depend on me.*

◆◆◆

Thirty days came, and the checks kept coming. He extended them by a week. On January 11, 1996, one month to the day after the fire, he extended them again, by thirty more days, and told the workers in front of him that he considered *the employees standing in front of me here the most valuable asset that Malden Mills has.* Most accounts say the pay ran for ninety days in all; a few say sixty. The health insurance ran longer, by some accounts six months and by others nine. A worker named Teresa Perkins said what many of them were saying. *It's unbelievable what the man's doing for us.*

The cost has been reported in different sums: about ten million dollars in Feuerstein's own estimate that March, fifteen million in a business magazine's account in 1999, twenty-five million in the Boston Globe and on *60 Minutes*. The weekly payroll alone, for the hourly workers, was a million and a half.

The town moved too. The union gave a hundred thousand dollars to a fund for the workers, and companies from Bank of Boston to Patagonia added more. The company's human resources staff rented space in an empty mall and turned it into a center where idle workers could pick up news, file for unemployment, and take classes; more than six hundred of them finished a course within the year.

And the workers came back to the mill before there was a mill. Tony Melo, who would spend more than thirty years there, remembered it decades later. *A lot of people volunteered to go there and help clean the ashes*, he said, so that the machines could run again. Within weeks the company had salvaged what it could, bought fifteen new machines, and set them up in a warehouse. By mid-January about two-thirds of the employees were back at work. By the end of March, eighty percent were. By the end of 1996, all but about four hundred had returned.

◆ ◆ ◆

The letters began the week of the fire and did not stop: three to five thousand by mid-January, and by the Globe's later count more than thirty thousand in all. In January 1996 he sat beside Hillary Clinton, as a guest of the President, at the State of the Union. The Globe called him the Mensch of Malden Mills, and the name stuck.

The praise made him uneasy. *I don't deserve credit*, he said. *Corporate America has made it so that when you behave the way I did, it's abnormal.* Years later he was blunter about it. *I got a lot of publicity*, he said, *and I don't think that speaks well for our times.*

He explained himself in the language of his faith. He was an Orthodox Jew, and he quoted Torah to anyone who asked. *You are not permitted to oppress the working man, because he's poor and he's needy*, he said, *amongst your brethren and amongst the non-Jew in your community.* When asked why he had

not simply taken the insurance money and retired, he answered with a question. *And what would I do with it? Eat more? Buy another suit? Retire and die?*

He also spoke as a businessman, and he meant that too. *I have the responsibility to the worker, both blue-collar and white-collar*, he said. *I have an equal responsibility to the community.*

◆◆◆

The new plant opened in September 1997, on the same ground, built to be safer and easier on the people who worked inside it. It had cost about four hundred and fifty million dollars. The insurance paid about three hundred million. Feuerstein borrowed the rest.

That was where the story began to cost.

While the mill was being rebuilt, other companies had learned to make fleece, and customers who could not wait for Polartec bought theirs elsewhere. A string of warm winters followed, which is a hard thing for a company that sells warmth. Feuerstein closed the flock division, the upholstery business where the fire had started, which had once brought in much of the company's revenue. It had employed several hundred people, many with ten to thirty years in the mill. Accounts differ on whether the closing came in 1997 or in February 1998. Between March and August of 1998, about four hundred workers were laid off.

The head of the Polartec division, Patricia Fitzpatrick, pressed him to automate. He refused. *And what will we do with our workers*, he asked her,

throw them out on the street? There will be no robots in my factory. She resigned soon afterward.

By 2001 the company owed about a hundred and forty million dollars, much of it to GE Capital. In November 2001 Malden Mills filed for Chapter 11 bankruptcy, the second time in twenty years. The new financing came with conditions, and none of Feuerstein's three children remained in the company's management.

He spent the next two years trying to buy his company back. He needed about ninety-two million dollars by August 21, 2003, to exercise his option. The City of Lawrence agreed to help back a ten-million-dollar loan. A group of the company's own accountants and administrators bought a lottery ticket, hoping to hand him the difference. They missed by one number. He did not raise the money. The creditors, led by GE Capital, took control. Accounts differ on whether he was pushed out in 2004 or early 2005; by 2005 he had left the board.

In January 2007 the company filed for bankruptcy again, and that year a private equity firm bought it and renamed it Polartec, after its famous fabric. The workers' pension plan, which covered about fifteen hundred current and former employees, was found to be only about half funded and was taken over by the federal Pension Benefit Guaranty Corporation, which guarantees such pensions up to a limit.

◆ ◆ ◆

The business writers argued about him for years.

To some, he was a warning. In 2004 the commentator Radley Balko wrote: *Feuerstein's pledge to continue paying his workers*, Balko wrote, *eventually cost them their jobs, and cost Feuerstein his company.* The arithmetic is mixed. The wages, at most twenty-five million dollars, were a small part of a rebuild that ran about a hundred and fifty million past the insurance, and the lost customers and warm winters did the rest. The wages added to the hole all the same. A Harvard law professor, Joseph Singer, used the case to make a different point: that the managers of a public company who did what Feuerstein did could be sued by their own shareholders for it. Feuerstein could do it because the company was his.

He knew that. *Well, I'm not poor*, he told the Globe reporter Bruce Butterfield, who wrote about him at length in 1996. *If it succeeds, I succeed.* Butterfield, who later became his biographer, described the man he came to know as *a businessman, kindly but with human flaws, a good and moral man, not a saint.* Some of what drove him, Butterfield thought, was the wish to rebuild the family business exactly as it had been.

The workers who stayed had their own way of saying it. *We're treated fairly. I mean, you'd better produce, he doesn't give it away*, said Bob Fawcett, an employee, in 2003. *But he takes care of his people. If you're hurting, you're in trouble, you got a place to go.* Jackie Hosty, another employee, had needed two brain surgeries. *Because of him*, she said, *I was able to get the doctors I needed.*

And Feuerstein, asked on *60 Minutes* what he hoped would be written on his tombstone, gave an answer in the plain grammar of the mill floor. *He done his damnedest.*

◆ ◆ ◆

The checks had bought time, and in Lawrence time meant years. The mill kept a workforce in the city through the bankruptcies and the sale, at union wages, for two more decades.

On December 10, 2015, one day before the twentieth anniversary of the fire, Polartec announced that it would close its Lawrence plant and move the work to Hudson, New Hampshire, and to Tennessee. About three hundred people still worked there, earning thirteen to fifteen dollars an hour. The mayor, Dan Rivera, said it felt *like the fire all over again.* Feuerstein was eighty-nine. He called it *a disgrace*. *All those jobs are lost*, he said, *after we dedicated ourselves to keeping them.*

The union fought the closing. Tony Melo was one of the workers who fought it, thirty-one years into his time at the mill. *It becomes like a family*, he said of the place. Of the man who had paid him through the winter of 1995 he said: *I don't think there's no more people with a heart like that.* The layoffs began on July 18, 2016, and by the end of that year the Lawrence plant had stopped making cloth.

◆ ◆ ◆

Aaron Feuerstein fell at his home in Brookline on October 27, 2021. He died on November 4, at ninety-five.

His memorial service was held at the Young Israel of Brookline, the synagogue his father had helped found. In January 1994, almost two years before the mill burned, that synagogue had burned too, and Feuerstein had written a check of about a million dollars to rebuild it. His son Raphael spoke there about the hard years after the fire, the loss of the business and a difficult divorce. *I couldn't do it myself*, he said, *and he opened the doors. Not a lot of people get a second chance.*

His granddaughter Marika had lived with him for his last two years. She began by saying she wanted to tell *a tale of two Zaides*. There was the grandfather before the fire, whom she had not known well. And there was the one who came after the mill was gone, who ate with her every week, who insisted the family come to Shabbat dinner, and who became her best friend.

◆◆◆

Today several of the old Malden Mills buildings in Lawrence stand along the Spicket River as homes. A developer turned them into a place called Loft Five50: a hundred and thirty-seven apartments, nearly all of them set aside for families of modest means. A greenway runs along the river past the door, almost four miles of it, to schools and stores and the train.

Picture a cold morning in Lawrence. In one of those apartments, a woman is zipping her son into a fleece jacket by the door. Her father worked the night shift at the mill in 1995, say, and through that winter,

with no building to go to, he cashed a paycheck every week, and it paid the rent that kept the family in the city. She has no reason to think about any of that this morning. She is checking the zipper, finding his hat, and opening the door, and the two of them step out into the wind off the river, warm.

> Side note: On February 15, 2010, his eighty-first birthday, Bob Moore, founder of Bob's Red Mill in Milwaukie, Oregon, set up an employee stock ownership plan for his 209 employees, the first step in giving them the company. He had turned down many offers to sell. *They thought I was just a lame-brained idiot because I didn't want to sell my company*, he said later. By April 2020 the mill was entirely owned by its employees. When he died on February 10, 2024, at ninety-four, more than seven hundred employee-owners held it.

Question: When has someone kept you on, paid you, or stood by you through a season when you had nothing to give back, and what did that time make possible?

Question: What are three ways that what is happening could be kind?

Action: Write a short note, by hand or by message, to someone who once kept you on when it would have been easier to let you go: an employer, a teacher, a coach, a landlord. Name one specific thing that their patience made possible, and send it today.

Chapter Thirteen

Sunlight on Clouds

———

Emerald

"*If it is not right, do not do it: if it is not true, do not say it.*" — Marcus Aurelius, Meditations, Book XII (trans. George Long)

◆◆◆

Stanislav Petrov was the son of a fighter pilot and a nurse.

He was born on 7 September 1939, near Vladivostok, at the far eastern edge of the Soviet Union, a week after the war began in Europe. He did not become a pilot. He became an engineer instead, trained in Kiev, a man whose work was systems and their faults rather than orders and their execution. In 1973 he married a woman named Raisa. They would have a son, Dmitry, and a daughter, Elena. In the early 1970s he was assigned to the organisation that ran the country's early warning system, the machinery built to notice, in the first minutes, if American missiles were on their way.

The newest part of that machinery was a set of satellites called Oko, which means *eye*. The system had become operational in 1978 and had been

placed on combat duty only in 1982. Its satellites flew in long looping orbits, called Molniya, high above the earth, and they watched the American missile fields for one thing: the infrared glow of a rocket engine's exhaust as a missile left the ground. What they saw went to computers, and what the computers concluded went to a bunker at a secret base south of Moscow called Serpukhov-15. There a duty officer and his crew sat through the night, watching the satellites' reports, ready to tell the generals the moment an attack began. Most nights, the job was to wait for nothing to happen, and to be fully awake when it did not.

By the autumn of 1983 Petrov was forty-four, a lieutenant colonel, and one of the officers who took turns in that chair.

◆◆◆

It was a dangerous autumn.

For more than two years the Soviet leadership had been half convinced that the United States was preparing a surprise nuclear attack. In May 1981 the KGB and military intelligence had begun a vast secret operation, known by its Russian initials as RYaN, to watch for the signs. NATO, meanwhile, was preparing to place new American Pershing II missiles in Western Europe, within quick reach of Soviet targets.

Then, on 1 September 1983, a Korean Air Lines Boeing 747 strayed far off course into Soviet airspace and was shot down by a Soviet fighter near Moneron Island, west of Sakhalin. All 269 people on

board were killed. President Reagan called it a *crime against humanity* and an *act of barbarism*.

Missiles from the American plains could reach the Soviet Union in a little over twenty minutes. Everyone whose job it was to think about such things was thinking about them.

On the night of 25 September Petrov was on duty at Serpukhov-15. What happened came shortly after midnight, so it is usually dated 26 September; a few accounts give the 27th.

The alarm went off.

He described it many times in the years that followed, in plain words. *Suddenly the screen in front of me turned bright red*, he told one interviewer. The sound, he said, was *loud enough to raise a dead man from his grave*. To another he remembered the main screen: *Giant blood-red letters appeared on our main screen, saying START.* In Russian, *start* is the word for a missile launch. The system was reporting that a single intercontinental ballistic missile had left the ground in the United States. The indicator of how certain the system was stood at its highest level.

This hit the nerves, he told the Associated Press. *I was really taken aback.*

The siren howled, he said, *but I just sat there for a few seconds*.

He did not pretend afterwards that he had been calm. *I'll admit it, I was scared*, he said. *I knew the level of responsibility at my fingertips.*

Then the system reported a second launch. Then more, until there were five.

His orders were clear. He was to pass the warning up the chain of command, to the generals and from them to the country's leaders, who would have a very few minutes to decide whether to launch their own missiles before the American ones arrived. He would not have pressed any button himself. His job was to tell the people above him what the machines had seen.

What he had to decide was whether the machines had seen it.

◆ ◆ ◆

Almost everything about how Petrov reasoned that night comes from what he said afterwards, starting fifteen years later, when he was nearly sixty and telling the story to journalists. His accounts agree with one another on the main points, and his old commander's memoir confirms the false alarm and the officer who handled it. But the inner details, the seconds and the feelings, are his memory, and they should be read that way.

He remembered the people around him. *My team was close to panic*, he told the Associated Press in 2015, *and it hit me that if panic sets in then it's all over.*

He remembered his own body. *All I had to do was to reach for the phone; to raise the direct line to our top commanders — but I couldn't move*, he told the BBC in 2013. *I felt like I was sitting on a hot frying pan.*

And he remembered that he did not know. *I realized that I had to make some kind of decision*, he said, *and I was only 50/50.*

He gave several reasons, in different interviews, for what he did next. An American first strike, he had been taught, would come all at once, hundreds of missiles at the same moment, to destroy the Soviet ability to answer. Five made no sense. The satellite system was new, on combat duty for little more than a year, and he did not wholly trust it. The alarm had passed through some thirty layers of the system's own checking faster than seemed right to him, as if nothing along the way had stopped to look. And the ground radars showed nothing, and went on showing nothing. They could not see beyond the horizon, so real missiles would appear on them only after some minutes in flight, but they were the second pair of eyes, and the second pair of eyes saw nothing.

None of that was proof. The radars might simply not have picked the missiles up yet. The system could have been right.

And the two mistakes open to him were not equal for the man who made them. If he passed the warning on and it turned out false, he would have done exactly what the procedures told him to do. The machine would take the blame, and the generals above him would carry the decision. If he called it false and it was real, he would be the officer who had let his country be struck without a word of warning, in the last minutes anyone would ever have to judge him. Passing it on was the safe choice for

Stanislav Petrov. Holding it back was the safe choice only for everyone else.

In the end, he said, it came down to something he could not fully explain. *I had a funny feeling in my gut.*

He judged the alarm false, and did not report an attack. By most accounts he told his superiors that the system was malfunctioning. Exactly what he passed up the line, and when, is one of the details on which the accounts differ.

I didn't want to make a mistake, he said later. *I made a decision and that was it.*

◆◆◆

Then there was nothing to do but wait.

If he was wrong, the first warheads would arrive in something over twenty minutes, and the country would have been struck without a word of warning from the man whose job it was to give one. If he was right, nothing would happen at all. There would be no signal that he was right, no light on any screen to say so. There would only be minutes going by, one after another, each one a little more likely to be the proof.

Years later, he still remembered how long it was. *Twenty-three minutes later I realized that nothing had happened*, he said in 2013. *If there had been a real strike, then I would already know about it. It was such a relief.*

The satellites had been fooled by the sun.

A state commission looked into the failure, and within a couple of months it had an answer. On that night the sun, the clouds and the satellite had lined up in a rare way. Sunlight striking high-altitude clouds over the American Midwest, near North Dakota, had reflected up into the satellite's sensors at an angle that looked, to the computer, like the heat of rocket engines rising. The program meant to filter out such false readings had not filtered them out. The five missiles were five patches of light on the tops of clouds.

The machine had been very sure. The man in the chair had not been sure at all, and had said so.

◆ ◆ ◆

What came next is the part of the story that is easy to leave out.

Petrov said later that the questioning began almost at once, and that it was hard. By his account, his commander, Colonel General Yury Votintsev, at first praised him and promised him a reward. Other accounts say Votintsev gave him no support at the time. Both may be partly true. What is not in dispute is how it ended.

Votintsev himself later said that Petrov's *correct actions* had been *duly noted*. There was no reward. Instead Petrov was reprimanded, officially, for failing to record the night's events properly in the duty log, the war diary that every shift was required to keep. Of everything that went wrong at Serpukhov-15 that night, what was written down against Petrov's own name was his paperwork.

Petrov said in later years that he had been neither rewarded nor punished. His own explanation for how he was treated was simple. The false alarm had exposed a serious flaw in a system that important generals and scientists had built and vouched for. To reward the officer who had caught the mistake would have meant punishing the people who had made it. It was easier to find a fault in the officer.

He was moved to a less sensitive post. He left the army in 1984. He always said he was not forced out. He also said that the strain of that night and what followed had brought on a nervous breakdown. Then his wife, Raisa, became ill with cancer, and he left that job to look after her. She died in 1997. They had been married for twenty-four years, and he had spent the last part of that time nursing her. By one account, she never knew what her husband had done that night.

For fifteen years almost no one outside a few offices knew that anything had happened at Serpukhov-15. The incident was classified, and he did not tell the story. He lived in Fryazino, a town northeast of Moscow, in a small flat.

◆ ◆ ◆

The story came out at last through his old commander.

In 1998, years after the Soviet Union had collapsed, Votintsev, who had commanded the Soviet missile-defence forces and was by then long retired, published his memoirs and described the false alarm of 1983 and the officer who had handled it. A

German tabloid picked up the story, and others followed. In 1999 the Washington Post ran his story under a line he had given them: *I had a funny feeling in my gut*.

He said himself that without Votintsev's memoir he *would have forgotten about it like a bad dream*.

After that, recognition came, mostly from abroad. A peace group in San Francisco gave him its World Citizen Award. In January 2006 he was honoured at a gathering at the United Nations in New York. In 2013 he was awarded the Dresden Peace Prize. A documentary drama was made about him. Strangers began to call him the man who saved the world. At home in Russia, his part in the story brought him little fame.

He did not claim it. When television reports began calling him a hero, he said, he was surprised. *I never thought of myself as one—after all, I was literally just doing my job. That was my job*, he said again, to other reporters. And, more drily, that *they were lucky it was me on shift that night*.

In a long interview in 2013 he added something more. Even then, thirty years later, he admitted he had never been completely sure, in the moment, that the alarm was false. He also thought that his training had mattered. He had been educated as a civilian engineer, he said, and many of the other duty officers were professional soldiers, trained to follow orders. He believed one of them might well have reported the launch.

◆◆◆

Not everyone agreed with the larger claims made for him, and he did not ask them to.

In January 2006, when he was honoured in New York, Russia's mission to the United Nations issued a statement saying that no single person could start or prevent a nuclear war. *Under no circumstances*, it said, could a decision to use nuclear weapons *be made or even considered* on the basis of data from a single source or system.

Historians of the Soviet arsenal have made a similar point more quietly. Pavel Podvig, who studies Russian strategic forces, has written that *there were at least three assessment and decision-making layers above the command center*, and that the Soviet Union would most likely have struck back only after nuclear explosions on its own soil. On that reading, Petrov's report would not by itself have launched anything.

Others see the same night differently. The American nuclear analyst Bruce Blair described the Soviet system of those months as *on hair-trigger alert* and *prone to mistakes and accidents*, and argued that a top leadership given only a couple of minutes to decide, told that an attack had begun, might well have answered it. Oleg Kalugin, a former KGB counter-intelligence chief, put the fear of that year in one sentence. *The danger was in the Soviet leadership thinking, 'The Americans may attack, so we better attack first.'*

No one can run that night again with a different man in the chair. What the record can say is smaller and

certain. A warning system reported, with the highest confidence it could give, that American missiles were in the air. The officer whose job was to pass that warning on did not pass it on as true, because he could not be sure it was. He said what he actually knew, which was that something was wrong with the system. He was right, and he paid for it.

Six weeks later, from 7 to 11 November 1983, NATO held a long-planned exercise called Able Archer 83, which rehearsed the steps to a coordinated nuclear attack. Some Soviet officials believed it might be cover for a real first strike. The exercise ended, and nothing happened. Whatever else was true that autumn, it was not a season in which a false report of five American missiles would have reached calm minds.

◆◆◆

Stanislav Petrov died on 19 May 2017, at the age of seventy-seven, in Fryazino. The cause was pneumonia. He had been living alone.

No one outside his family seemed to notice. There was no official announcement. The world learned only in September, and only because of a German friend.

Karl Schumacher, a German political activist, had championed Petrov's story in the West and had become his friend. In early September 2017 he telephoned Fryazino to wish Petrov a happy seventy-eighth birthday. He reached Petrov's son, Dmitry, who told him that his father had died nearly four

months before. Schumacher made the death known. No Russian government agency issued a statement.

We owe this man a lot, Schumacher said.

For almost four months the world had gone on without knowing that he was gone, as for fifteen years it had gone on without knowing what he had done.

A year later, on 26 September 2018, thirty-five years to the day after the alarm, the Future of Life Institute gave Petrov a posthumous award of fifty thousand dollars. His daughter, Elena, received it on his behalf, a woman accepting thanks, from people her father had never met, for a night he had kept silent about for fifteen years. The former Secretary-General of the United Nations, Ban Ki-moon, sent words of tribute, speaking of *the courageous judgement of Stanislav Petrov*.

◆ ◆ ◆

Anyone born after the autumn of 1983 has lived their whole life on the far side of that night. None of them can know what would have happened if the officer in the chair had been more obedient, or more frightened, or more certain. They know only that the twenty-three minutes passed, and the morning came, and that in time the satellites were fixed.

The alarms are different now. They do not come as red letters on a wall in a bunker. They come as a buzz in a pocket: a screenshot of a warning, a headline about a neighbour, a voice note from a friend of a friend, a terrible thing that someone heard is true. Each one arrives with its own

reliability indicator set to the highest level, and each one asks to be passed up the line, now, before it is too late. Most of them are sunlight on clouds. Some are not. The person holding the phone almost never knows which, and has only a few seconds and a feeling in the gut.

Tonight, somewhere, a young father is sitting on the edge of a bed in the light of his phone while his daughter sleeps across the room. A message has arrived in the family group: a screenshot, a warning, an outrage, something frightening that is supposed to happen tomorrow. His thumb is already over the button to send it on to his brother, his mother, the parents from school. He stops. He looks at the screenshot again, at the blurred name at the top, at a date that does not quite match. He does not know if it is true. He knows only that if he sends it, a dozen people will wake up to it, and some of them will send it on. He closes the message, puts the phone face down on the blanket, and listens for a while to his daughter breathing.

> Side note: Twenty-one years before Petrov's night, on 27 October 1962, at the height of the Cuban Missile Crisis, a Soviet submarine called B-59 was being forced to the surface by American depth charges. Her captain wanted to fire a nuclear torpedo. The launch needed three officers to agree. One of them, Vasily Arkhipov, said no, and talked the captain into surfacing instead. His wife, Olga, remembered him as calm and courteous, a man who seldom spoke about it. In 2017 the Future of Life

Institute gave its first award to Arkhipov's family. The next year, it went to Petrov's.

Question: When have you passed on something alarming, about the world or about a person, before you knew it was true, and what would it have cost you to wait?

Question: What are three ways that what is happening could be kind?

Action: Take your most depressing, angry or bitter recurring thought and write it down here. Then ask yourself: Can I absolutely know that this thought is true? Could I prove it is the truth, the whole truth and nothing but the truth in a court of law? Would everyone else believe me?

Chapter Fourteen

Ninety-Seven Miles

———

Jade

"*For to him that is joined to all the living there is hope: for a living dog is better than a dead lion.*" — Ecclesiastes 9:4, King James Version

◆◆◆

On the morning of 9 January 1909, four men left their tent on the high plateau of Antarctica and walked south without their sledge.

They had left it behind on purpose. A blizzard had kept them in the tent for the two days before, and now, with the wind dropped, they carried almost nothing: the flags, a camera, a few instruments. Without the weight they could move fast over the hard snow, Ernest Shackleton in front, with Frank Wild, Eric Marshall and Jameson Adams behind him. They were more than ten thousand feet up, on a plateau Shackleton had already named for King Edward VII. The thermometer read nineteen degrees below zero Fahrenheit, and the men had been on short rations for weeks.

When they stopped, Shackleton wrote down where they were. *We have shot our bolt*, he wrote, *and the*

tale is latitude 88° 23' South, longitude 162° East. They hoisted the Union Jack that Queen Alexandra had given them, and then a second one. They took photographs. Then they turned their glasses toward the south and looked for a long time.

There was nothing to see. *We looked south with our powerful glasses*, Shackleton wrote, *but could see nothing but the dead white snow plain.* The plateau ran on, smooth and unbroken, toward the place every explorer in the world wanted to reach. He was sure the Pole lay out there on that same plain. It was about ninety-seven nautical miles away, a little more than a hundred and twelve ordinary miles. No human being had ever stood so close to it.

They had not been able to take a proper sighting of the sun since 3 January, so the figure was worked out by dead reckoning, from distance walked and direction kept. Back in London, some members of the Royal Geographical Society would later question it. All four men stood by it for the rest of their lives.

They turned around. *Homeward bound at last*, Shackleton wrote that night. *Whatever regrets may be, we have done our best.*

◆ ◆ ◆

He had wanted this for a long time, and he had already been sent home from it once.

In 1902 Shackleton marched south with Robert Falcon Scott and the doctor Edward Wilson on Scott's Discovery expedition, and the march nearly killed him. He came down with scurvy and broke down on the march back, and in early 1903 Scott

sent him home on a relief ship. For a proud young man it was a humiliation. He went back to England, married Emily Dorman in April 1904, and began, almost at once, to plan a way to return to the ice on his own terms.

The Nimrod expedition was that plan. It was underfunded from the first day, kept alive by loans and guarantees from friends and businessmen, and named for the old sealing ship that carried it south. Shackleton wanted the Pole, and he told people so.

The southern party set out on 29 October 1908 with four Manchurian ponies pulling the sledges. The ponies failed one by one. The last, a pony named Socks, fell into a crevasse on 7 December, and Wild, who had been leading him, nearly went down into the dark after him. From then on the four men pulled everything themselves.

They climbed the Beardmore Glacier, a great river of ice running south to the plateau, through December, through hidden crevasses and blue ice, and reached the top after Christmas. On New Year's Day they passed 87 degrees south, farther toward either pole than anyone had ever been.

On 4 January he did the arithmetic that every leader of a sledge party has to do, and he did it honestly. The food would not carry four men to the Pole and back. He changed the goal. They would try to get within a hundred geographical miles of it, and then they would go home.

◆ ◆ ◆

It is worth saying plainly what he gave up.

The Pole was not a hobby to Shackleton. It was money, and he was deep in debt. It was fame, which meant lectures and books, which meant he could pay back the men who had trusted him. It was the answer to the day Scott had sent him home. It was also, simply, the thing he had dreamed about since he first saw the ice, the private wish under all the public ones. Every newspaper in Britain was waiting for one word, and he knew it. A few days of hard marching on empty stomachs might have put that word in his hands.

He also knew what the return journey would cost. The four men had to walk back the way they had come, more than seven hundred miles, from one cache of food to the next, and every day of delay at the far end meant a day without food somewhere on the way home. The ship would not wait forever. Nimrod had orders to leave McMurdo Sound by the first of March, before the sea froze around her. Had they gone on to the Pole, they would very likely have reached it. Very likely, too, they would have died on the way back.

Wild thought about it differently. He believed in his diary that they could have done it if two other strong men, Ernest Joyce and George Marston, had been with them instead of Marshall and Adams. Marshall, for his part, wrote privately that following Shackleton was *like following an old woman. Always panicking.* Wild, in his own diary, wished Marshall would fall down a crevasse. They were four exhausted men in a small tent, and they did not always like one another.

But all four of them walked back. And when they turned around on the plateau, after seventy-three days of travel south, the decision belonged to him alone.

◆◆◆

The march home was a race against hunger, and hunger nearly won.

Shackleton cut the rations again and again. They reached the head of the Beardmore on 19 January and started down. Adams, watching his leader on the descent, noticed something he wrote down later: the worse Shackleton felt, the harder he pulled. On 28 January they reached the depot at the foot of the glacier, and there the illness began.

Wild went first. He had dysentery so badly that he could hardly pull, and he could eat nothing but biscuit, the one food that was in shortest supply. They were living on pemmican and pony meat now, with a few thin biscuits each a day.

On the last day of January, in the morning, Shackleton took his own breakfast biscuit and pushed it on Wild. He did it privately, so that the others would not see, and he would not take it back. That evening he tried to do it again, and Wild would not let him.

Wild wrote about it that night in his diary. Shackleton, he wrote, *privately forced upon me his one breakfast biscuit, and would have given me another tonight had I allowed him. I do not suppose that anyone else in the world can thoroughly realise how much generosity and sympathy was shown by*

this. Then the words break into capitals. *I DO by GOD I shall never forget it. Thousands of pounds would not have bought that biscuit.*

Shackleton did not mention the biscuit in his own diary.

A few days later the others fell sick too, with enteritis from tainted pony meat. They could not stop to recover, because the food between the depots was measured to the day. So they walked sick. On 23 February they reached the Bluff Depot, which Joyce had come out and restocked for them, and found it full of things they had not tasted in months. *Good old Joyce*, Wild wrote. For a night they ate meals, as Shackleton put it, *fit for the gods*.

◆ ◆ ◆

They were not home yet. In the last days of February Marshall collapsed. He had dysentery and could not haul, and he was getting worse. They were still about thirty-three miles from Hut Point, and the ship might already be gone.

Shackleton made a choice in two parts. He left Marshall in the tent with Adams to care for him, and he and Wild went ahead as fast as they could. They reached Hut Point late on 28 February. There was no ship in sight.

They spent a cold night, and in the morning they set fire to a small hut as a signal. And then, far off, they saw the ship, lifted above the horizon by a mirage. Wild later called it the happiest sight he had ever seen. At eleven o'clock on the morning of 1 March they were aboard Nimrod.

Shackleton had been walking for more than four months. Three and a half hours after he climbed aboard, at half past two that same afternoon, he was back on the ice, leading a relief party of three men from the ship, Mackay, Mawson and McGillan, out onto the Barrier to bring Marshall and Adams in. Wild stayed aboard. Shackleton did not.

They found the two men and brought them back. At one o'clock in the morning on 4 March, all four men who had stood at 88 degrees 23 minutes were safe on board, and the ship turned north.

◆◆◆

Emily Shackleton had been waiting at home in England with their small children. She had used her social connections to help him find backers for the expedition, and while he was away she kept the family on her own independent income. When he came back to her in 1909, he said something she wrote down and kept.

The words have been retold so often that they come in several versions. By Emily's own record, as his biographer Roland Huntford gives it, he asked her: *A live donkey is better than a dead lion, isn't it?* Other tellings have him saying he thought she would rather have a live donkey than a dead lion. A newspaper, more than a century later, told it as Emily asking him which he was, the lion or the donkey. The words shift. The meaning does not. He had stood ninety-seven miles from what he wanted most, and he had come home to her instead.

Britain did not treat him as a donkey. King Edward VII knighted him. The expedition's debts were paid off only when the government made a belated grant of twenty thousand pounds.

He had not reached the Pole. Someone else would. And because he had turned back, the most famous fact about his greatest journey was the distance he had not covered.

◆◆◆

Two other men went south in the years that followed.

Roald Amundsen of Norway reached the Pole on 14 December 1911. Robert Falcon Scott, the man who had sent Shackleton home from the ice nine years before, reached it on 17 January 1912 with four companions and found a Norwegian tent waiting there, with a note inside. They had been beaten by thirty-four days.

Scott and his men started home across the same plateau Shackleton had crossed, and down the same Beardmore Glacier. Edgar Evans died near the bottom of the glacier on 17 February. On 16 March Lawrence Oates, his feet ruined by frostbite, walked out of the tent into a blizzard. Scott recorded what he said as he went: *I am just going outside and may be some time.* Scott, Wilson and Henry Bowers died in their tent at the end of March, probably on the 29th, about eleven miles short of a depot full of food and fuel. A blizzard had held them in place. In his last journal entry Scott wrote, *For God's sake look after our people.*

Edward Wilson had been with Shackleton and Scott on that first march south in 1902. A search party found the tent in November 1912, with the three men inside.

Nobody can say what Shackleton thought when the news reached him. What is on the record is what he did next.

◆◆◆

In 1914 he went south again, this time to cross the whole continent on foot. His ship, Endurance, never reached land. She froze fast in the pack ice of the Weddell Sea in January 1915, drifted with the ice for most of a year, and was crushed. Water poured into her in October, and on 21 November 1915 she slid under the ice and was gone.

That left twenty-eight men on a floating sheet of ice, hundreds of miles from anyone. Shackleton's first decisions were small ones. There were not enough reindeer-fur sleeping bags for everyone, and the fur bags were much warmer than the woollen ones. *It seemed fair to distribute the fur bags by lot*, he wrote later, *but some of us older hands did not join in the lottery.* He and the older men took the wool. He issued new clothing and new socks to every man. On those first nights on the ice he went out with Wild and the photographer Frank Hurley and carried hot milk from tent to tent. *We three ministering angels*, he called them.

They lived on the ice for months. In April 1916 the floe broke under them, and they took to three open lifeboats and reached Elephant Island, a bare,

storm-beaten rock far from any shipping route. On 24 April Shackleton and five others set out in the largest boat, the James Caird, to cross about eight hundred miles of the Southern Ocean to the whaling stations of South Georgia. Frank Wild stayed behind in command of the twenty-two men left on the beach.

The boat reached South Georgia on the wrong side of the island, and Shackleton, Frank Worsley and Tom Crean walked across its unmapped mountains to the whaling station at Stromness. It took four attempts and more than three months to get a ship through the ice to Elephant Island. On 30 August 1916 the Chilean tug Yelcho came into the bay. All twenty-two men were alive.

On the other side of the continent, the expedition's Ross Sea party, sent to lay depots for a crossing that never came, had lost three men, among them their commander, Aeneas Mackintosh. That is part of the record too. But of the twenty-eight men who stood on the ice when Endurance went down, every one came home.

◆◆◆

Frank Wild was the man who held the island.

For four and a half months the twenty-two men on Elephant Island lived under two upturned boats, eating penguin and seal, watching the sea. Wild had no way of knowing whether the James Caird had reached land or gone down in the first storm. He kept the men to a routine anyway. The men remembered later that most mornings he would roll

up his sleeping bag and tell them to do the same, because the Boss might come today. Some of them thought it was foolish. When the Yelcho came in, their gear was packed.

He had been at Shackleton's side since the plateau, and he stayed there. He was second in command on Endurance and second in command again on Quest. Nobody who knew the two men doubted where the loyalty had been fixed. It had been fixed in a tent on the Barrier, on the last day of January 1909, over one small square of hard biscuit that a hungry man had refused to eat.

Shackleton went south one last time in 1921, on a small ship called Quest. In Rio de Janeiro, on the way, he had what was almost certainly a heart attack, and he refused to turn back. The ship reached South Georgia on 4 January 1922. That evening he wrote in his diary: *In the darkening twilight I saw a lone star hover, gem-like above the bay.*

In the early hours he called for the doctor, Alexander Macklin, who had been with him on Endurance. They talked. Shackleton asked what he ought to give up. Macklin's answer, as he remembered it, was *Chiefly alcohol, Boss.* At 2:50 in the morning on 5 January 1922, Shackleton died. He was forty-seven. Frank Wild took command of Quest and carried on with the voyage the Boss had planned, because the men aboard still had to be brought home.

His body was taken as far as Montevideo, in Uruguay, on its way home to England. Then a message came from Emily. She asked that he be brought back to South Georgia and buried there, among the whalers, at the edge of the ice he had loved. On 5 March 1922 he was buried in the small cemetery at Grytviken, with a handful of whalers and officials standing by. His grave was set to face south, toward Antarctica, instead of east, as was the custom.

He left Emily debts of something like forty thousand pounds, and for years she lived carefully. She died in 1936, at sixty-eight, and is buried in the churchyard at Coldwaltham in Sussex, a very long way from her husband.

◆◆◆

On 5 March 2022, exactly a hundred years to the day after Shackleton was buried, a team searching the floor of the Weddell Sea found Endurance.

She lay more than three thousand metres down, sitting upright on the seabed, almost whole. The letters of her name were still clear across her stern, and rope still lay coiled where sailors had left it a hundred and seven years before. The team photographed her and touched nothing. She stays where she is.

And people still turn back.

In December 2017 the British explorer Ben Saunders was trying to cross Antarctica alone and unsupported, a journey his friend Henry Worsley had died attempting the year before. In the last days

of December, Saunders reached the South Pole on his fifty-second day. He had food for thirteen more days and a route that would take at least seventeen. Beyond the Pole lay a stretch of ice where no aircraft could reach him in bad weather. He stopped. *I made a promise to Henry to get home in one piece*, he said. The newspapers that reported it reached, almost at once, for a line about a donkey and a lion.

Somewhere tonight, a woman is sitting in her car outside a building she has spent ten years trying to get into, with her hands on the wheel, deciding not to go in. She does not yet know whether it is the bravest thing she has ever done. She starts the engine anyway, and drives home to the people who are waiting for her.

> Side note: Frank Wild, who never forgot the biscuit, died in South Africa in 1939, and his ashes sat forgotten for decades in a vault at Braamfontein Cemetery in Johannesburg. A writer named Angie Butler found them while researching his life. On 27 November 2011 they were buried at Grytviken, on the right-hand side of Shackleton's grave, with Shackleton's granddaughter standing by. The granite block reads *Frank Wild 1873–1939, Shackleton's right-hand man.* As Butler put it, his ashes were finally where they were always supposed to be.

Question: Is there a dream in your life that you have stood close to and turned away from, and what did turning back make room for?

Question: What are three ways that what is happening could be kind?

Action: Ask yourself: "What is the kindest thing I can do for the deepest, truest and most important parts of myself?" Brainstorm on this question and take one small step toward your answer.

Chapter Fifteen

The Mark

———

Turquoise

"*You can melt down all the gold medals and cups I have received, and they wouldn't come close to outshining the 24-carat friendship I felt for Luz at that moment.*" — Jesse Owens, "My Greatest Olympic Prize," *Reader's Digest*, October 1960

◆◆◆

His name was James Cleveland Owens, and at home they called him J.C.

He was born in 1913 in Oakville, Alabama, the son of a sharecropper, and his grandfather had been born a slave. When the boy was nine, the family went north to Cleveland, Ohio. On his first day at a new school, a teacher asked his name. He said *J.C.* in a soft Alabama accent, she heard *Jesse*, and he was too shy to correct her. The name stayed with him for the rest of his life.

He ran in school, and in 1933 he went to Ohio State University without a scholarship, working part-time jobs to pay his way. Five days before the Big Ten championships in Ann Arbor, Michigan, in May

1935, he hurt his back. On the day of the meet, the twenty-fifth of May, he had to be helped from the car to the dressing room. His coach, Larry Snyder, urged him not to compete: *It's not worth the risk.* Owens asked to try the first event. The hundred-yard dash started at a quarter past three. In about three quarters of an hour, in front of some twelve thousand people, he set or tied six world records. One of them was the long jump, on a single attempt. He flew 8.13 meters, the first jump in history past eight meters. The mark would stand for a quarter of a century.

◆◆◆

In the German city of Leipzig, a pharmacist's son named Carl Ludwig Long had built his own jumping pit when he was ten years old. Everyone called him Luz.

He was born in 1913, five months before Owens. He was tall, a little over six feet, and he studied law at the University of Leipzig while he jumped. He won the first of six German long jump titles in 1933, and in July 1936 he set a European record of 7.82 meters.

The government that ruled Germany by then had a use for a young man like him. It was preparing to host the Olympic Games, and it intended the Games to display a theory about which human beings were superior to which others. A tall, fair, educated German who could fly through the air was useful to that theory. Over the years the regime put Long on display at its sports festivals and military

championships, and he was a member of the SA, the Nazi Party's brownshirt organization.

The theory had no place for the American. Before the Games, a fan had written to Owens at the Olympic village urging him to refuse Hitler's handshake. The Gestapo intercepted the letter. Today the building where Owens slept in the Olympic village is a museum, and that letter is on display there.

◆◆◆

On the third of August 1936, in the new Olympic Stadium in Berlin, built to hold more than a hundred thousand people, Jesse Owens won the hundred meters. He was twenty-two. Luz Long, waiting for his own event, was twenty-three.

The next morning, the fourth of August, at half past ten, the long jump began. Forty-three men from twenty-seven nations were entered. The rule for the morning was plain: jump 7.15 meters, nearly a meter short of Owens's world record, and you went through to the afternoon.

Owens fouled on his first jump. He fouled on his second. One more foul and the world-record holder would be out of the Olympic long jump before it had properly started.

His third jump measured 7.64 meters. He was through.

What happened between the second jump and the third is where the story divides.

◆◆◆

The version most people know is the one Owens himself told. He told it most fully in *Reader's Digest* in 1960. In his telling, he was standing near the pit after the second foul, angry, kicking at the dirt, when the German walked over and said: *Something must be eating you.* Long told him he should qualify easily. Then he offered a suggestion. *Why don't you draw a line a few centimetres in back of the board and make your takeoff from there?* Owens took his takeoff back, he wrote, about a foot, and jumped safely through. That night, in his telling, he went to Long's room in the Olympic village to thank him, and they talked for two hours.

He told the story again, on film, standing in the Berlin stadium in 1964, for a documentary by the filmmaker Bud Greenspan. In another telling, which Long's family repeats today, Long showed him where to lay a towel on the runway as a marker.

Some historians doubt that the conversation in the morning took place. The most respected American sportswriter of the day, Grantland Rice, watched Owens through binoculars throughout the qualifying round, and later said he never saw him speak to Long. A track coach and writer named Tom Ecker says that in 1965 he and a colleague asked Owens about it directly, and that Owens admitted he had not met Long until after the competition was over. By Ecker's account, Owens explained that these were the stories audiences *like to hear*, so he told them.

So the advice in the qualifying round rests on Owens's own word, and Owens gave more than one

account of it. What happened in the afternoon took place in front of a full stadium, and it was filmed.

◆ ◆ ◆

The semifinal began at half past four, the final at a quarter to six. Through the late afternoon the competition narrowed to two men.

Owens went to 7.87 meters, an Olympic record. Long, jumping in his own country's capital, chased him. On his fifth jump he matched it, 7.87. Owens answered with 7.94. Long fouled his last attempt. Owens, on his last, landed at 8.06.

Owens wrote years later that Hitler was watching from the stands, *not a hundred metres away*. The first man to reach him was Luz Long.

On this point every account agrees, including Ecker's: Long came straight to Owens and congratulated him, shook his hand and embraced him. *Luz shook my hand hard*, Owens wrote, *and it wasn't a fake smile with a broken-hearted grip, either.* The two of them walked arm in arm along the track. They sat together on the infield grass and talked, and photographers caught them there, a Black American and a German, side by side. Leni Riefenstahl's cameras, filming the Games for the regime, recorded the competition. Naoto Tajima of Japan took the bronze.

On the podium afterward, the photographs show Owens saluting the American flag in the American way, hand at his brow. Long, behind him, raised his right arm in the Nazi salute. Both things are true of that afternoon.

Owens said, much later, that *it took a lot of courage* for Long to befriend him in front of Hitler. As for Hitler himself, who never received Owens, Owens remembered only a gesture from the stands. *He waved at me*, he said, *and I waved back.*

◆ ◆ ◆

Owens won the two hundred meters the next day and ran the opening leg of the American relay team that set a world record on the ninth of August. He left Berlin with four gold medals.

Long left with silver, and with a reputation. *Hitler was at the stadium*, his granddaughter Julia has said, *and he didn't like it, actually.* According to the family, a few days after the Games Long received a telephone call from Rudolf Hess, Hitler's deputy, who ordered him never to embrace a Black man again. Julia has said that the Nazis afterward classified him as *not racially conscious* and kept watch on him for years. His son, who later spent years studying his father's papers, wrote that Hess had threatened him.

Long went on competing, finished his law studies, and moved to Hamburg to practice law. In 1941 he married a woman named Gisela, and that year their son Kai was born.

The war came for him slowly. The army made him a sports instructor, then declared him fit for combat and assigned him to the Hermann Göring Division. In early May 1943 the division was sent to Sicily, to defend the island against an Allied invasion.

On the twenty-ninth of May he wrote home to Gisela. His unit was camped in tents, and he described where they were: *a lovely flower meadow, surrounded by mountains, completely peaceful.* By one account, the letter was written the day after the birth of his second son, Wolfgang.

The Allies landed on the tenth of July. That day, in the fighting for the airfield at Biscari, Long was wounded in the left thigh while his unit attacked armored cars on the runway, and he was left behind in territory the Allies took. He died in a British military hospital at Acate a few days later, at thirty years old. Accounts differ on whether he died on the thirteenth or the fourteenth of July. His unit listed him as missing. He was buried first by the Allies, as a prisoner of war. For seven years, Gisela searched for word of whether her husband was alive. In 1944 their younger son, Wolfgang, died of meningitis.

In 1961 his remains were moved, and Luz Long lies today in the German war cemetery at Motta Sant'Anastasia, near Catania.

◆ ◆ ◆

Jesse Owens came home a hero, and found the country he came home to unchanged.

New York gave him a ticker-tape parade. Then, at a reception in his honor at the Waldorf-Astoria hotel, he was not allowed through the front entrance and rode up to his own celebration in the freight elevator. *When I came back to my native country, after all the stories about Hitler*, he said, *I couldn't ride in the front of the bus.* The President of the

United States did not invite him to the White House and did not send him a telegram. Campaigning that October in Kansas City for the President's opponent, Owens said it plainly: *Hitler didn't snub me. It was our president who snubbed me.*

He had left a post-Games exhibition tour of Europe early to come home and earn a living, and the amateur athletic authorities suspended him for it. His amateur career was over at twenty-two. *That Avery Brundage feller*, his wife Ruth said years later, naming the official who ran American amateur sport, *tore a big hole inside Jesse.*

He was a world-famous athlete with a family to support and no way to earn a living from the sport that had made him famous. He took what work he could find. He pumped gas. For cash, he ran exhibition races against racehorses, given a head start of forty yards over the horse, often winning by a nose. *I had four gold medals*, he said, *but you can't eat four gold medals.* He later went bankrupt, and in 1966 a federal court convicted him of tax evasion.

He kept rebuilding. He became a public speaker and writer, and the story of the German who had helped him became one of the ones he told most.

◆ ◆ ◆

There is a letter that belongs to this story, and it has to be told carefully.

For decades, in books and articles and speeches, a letter has been printed that is said to be Long's last letter to Owens, written from the war. *My heart tells me*, it says, *if I be honest with you, that this is the*

last letter I shall ever write. It asks Owens to go to Germany when the war is over, to find Long's son, and to *tell him how things can be between men on this earth.* It is signed *Your brother, Luz.*

Neither family has ever seen the original. The letter describes a battlefield of *dry sand and wet blood*, the language of the desert war in North Africa, where Long never served. It is unlikely that a German soldier could have sent a letter to the United States at all. The last letter of Luz Long that his family keeps is the one about the flower meadow, written to his wife.

What Owens did for the boy is on the record.

In 1951, when Kai Long was ten and his father had been dead for eight years, Jesse Owens met him in Hamburg. In 1964, for Greenspan's film, Owens came back to Berlin, and he and Kai sat together in the Olympic Stadium, in the place where their two stories had crossed. Owens told the son, on camera, about the morning of the fouls, and said: *your father came to my assistance.* The two men recreated the old photograph of Owens and Luz together. Accounts differ on how many times the two met; the family has said twice. Kai never met his own father.

I would give up all the medals, Kai Long said, *to have my father back.*

◆ ◆ ◆

Jesse Owens died of lung cancer in Tucson, Arizona, on the thirty-first of March 1980, at sixty-six. *Perhaps no athlete*, said President Jimmy Carter,

better symbolized the human struggle against tyranny, poverty and racial bigotry.

Kai Long spent much of his life trying to learn who his father had been. He gathered photographs, family papers and his father's own writings, and in 2015 he published them as a book. One of Owens's grandsons, Stuart Rankin, wrote the foreword. *The image that is forever etched into my mind*, he wrote, *is of a smiling Luz Long.*

In 2004, when Berlin reopened the rebuilt Olympic Stadium, Kai asked his daughter, Julia, to represent the family. She stood in the stadium beside Gina Hemphill-Strachan, Owens's granddaughter, while eighty thousand people applauded the lighting of the flame. Julia said afterward that her knees trembled. *They were both there*, she said. *Jesse and Luz.*

Kai Long died in 2021, at eighty, having outlived the father he never knew by fifty years. The next year his family sent Luz Long's silver medal to auction, with his other keepsakes from 1936, under the title *The Beacon of Hope*. They hoped a museum or collector with the means to care for it would take it, and that the sale would carry the story to people who had never heard it. *The outside world needs* the story now, Julia said.

On the thirty-first of July 2024, in Paris, during the Olympic Games, the World Olympians Association honored Jesse Owens and Luz Long together, as Olympians for Life. Their granddaughters, Marlene Dortch and Julia Long, accepted the award side by side. *All these generations later*, Dortch said, *here*

we are together at the Olympics. Of what her grandfather and Luz Long had done, she said: *I think it proves that racism will not win.*

The story never ends, Julia Long said.

◆ ◆ ◆

The long jump runway looks much the same today as it did in Berlin. There is a white board set into the track, and beyond it the pit, raked smooth. Every jumper learns to count steps back from the board and to set a marker on the runway, so that the run will carry the foot onto the board and not past it.

Somewhere this afternoon, at a school meet, a girl has fouled twice. She is standing at the end of the runway with her hands on her hips, staring at the board. The girl from the other school, the one she has to beat, is sitting on the grass nearby, lacing her spikes. She may have heard about Jesse Owens and Luz Long. She may have heard the version with the line behind the board, or the one with the towel, or neither. She finishes her laces, gets up, and walks over.

> Side note: At the Winter Olympics in Innsbruck in 1964, the Italian bobsledder Eugenio Monti was chasing his first gold medal when he learned that his British rivals, Tony Nash and Robin Dixon, had a bolt missing from their sled and no spare. Monti took a bolt off his own sled and sent it to them. Nash and Dixon won Britain's first Olympic bobsled gold; Monti finished with bronze. A few days later, Monti's mechanics repaired a damaged axle on a Canadian sled, and the Canadians won the

four-man gold. When the Italian press criticized him, Monti answered: *Nash didn't win because I gave him the bolt. He won because he had the fastest run.* He became the first winner of the international Fair Play award, and four years later, at forty, he won two golds of his own.

Question: Who is your rival right now, the person you measure yourself against, and what would it look like to walk over and help them do their best?

Question: What are three ways that what is happening could be kind?

Action: Think of someone you compete with, at work, in school or in sport, and send them a short,

specific message today praising one thing they did well recently. Mean it, and expect nothing back.

Chapter Sixteen

Escort

———

Sky

"*The quality of mercy is not strain'd, / It droppeth as the gentle rain from heaven / Upon the place beneath: it is twice blest; / It blesseth him that gives and him that takes.*" — William Shakespeare, *The Merchant of Venice*

◆◆◆

Charlie Brown grew up on a farm without electricity near Weston, West Virginia. By December 1943 he was twenty-one years old, a second lieutenant, and the pilot of a B-17 bomber stationed at an airfield called Kimbolton, in the flat green farmland of eastern England.

His plane was a B-17F with the serial number 42-3167. The crew called it *Ye Olde Pub*.

On the morning of the twentieth of December 1943, five days before Christmas, they took off on Brown's first combat mission as aircraft commander. The target was a factory in Bremen, in northern Germany, that built Focke-Wulf fighter planes.

There were ten men aboard. Brown, the pilot. Spencer "Pinky" Luke, his co-pilot. Albert "Doc"

Sadok, the navigator. Robert "Andy" Andrews, the bombardier. Bertrand "Frenchy" Coulombe, the engineer, in the top turret. Dick Pechout on the radio. Lloyd Jennings and Alex "Russian" Yelesanko at the waist guns, Samuel "Blackie" Blackford folded into the ball turret beneath the belly, and in the tail, alone, a twenty-three-year-old sergeant from the hills of central Pennsylvania named Hugh Eckenrode, who had been in Europe for seven weeks.

◆◆◆

They flew the bomb run at twenty-seven thousand feet, where the air outside was sixty degrees below zero. Flak burst around them. A shell shattered the Plexiglas nose. One engine died. Another was damaged. The bomber could not keep up with the formation, and a bomber that falls behind becomes what the crews called a straggler, the one the fighters go for.

A dozen or more German fighters came at them, again and again, for more than ten minutes. Bullets and cannon shells tore through the fuselage. They hit a third engine, the oxygen system, the hydraulics, the electrics. Half the rudder was shot away. The cold froze most of the guns. In the tail, Hugh Eckenrode was killed. Yelesanko was hit badly in the leg. Pechout was hit in the eye. Blackford's feet froze when his heated suit shorted out. A fragment struck Brown in the right shoulder. The morphine in the first-aid kits was frozen solid.

At one point, turning into an attack, Brown rolled the bomber and blacked out. When he came to, the plane was flying level, low over Germany, under a thousand feet. The fighters had gone. They had apparently decided the B-17 was finished.

Brown gave the crew the choice to bail out and become prisoners of war. They said no. Yelesanko was too badly hurt to jump, and they would not leave him.

So *Ye Olde Pub*, with one good engine and two half-working ones, a shattered nose, a dead man in the tail, and three men badly wounded, turned toward the North Sea and England, low and slow, alone over Germany.

◆◆◆

On an airfield below them, near the coast at Jever, a German pilot named Franz Stigler was refueling and rearming his Messerschmitt 109.

He was twenty-eight. He had grown up in Regensburg, in Bavaria, in a Catholic family that, by his own account, had no love for the Nazis. In 1940 his only brother, August, also a pilot, had been killed. Stigler had fought in North Africa, under a commander named Gustav Rödel, who once told him, as Stigler remembered it: *If I ever see or hear of you shooting at a man in a parachute, I will shoot you myself.*

That morning he had already shot down two American bombers. One more victory would earn him the Knight's Cross, one of Germany's highest military honors.

He saw the B-17 pass overhead, low and limping. He took off after it, with an American bullet still lodged in his own plane's radiator.

◆◆◆

He came up behind the bomber and lined up for the kill. Then he saw it closely.

He would later call it the most heavily damaged aircraft he ever saw that was still flying. He could see through the holes in the fuselage. He could see the tail gunner slumped over his guns. He could see wounded men in the waist. No one was firing at him.

What Stigler remembered thinking, and told an American air force historian decades later, was this: *I cannot kill these half-dead people. It would be like shooting at a parachute.*

He pulled up alongside the bomber, close, off its left wing. In the cockpit, Charlie Brown turned his head and saw a German fighter flying formation with him, so near he could see the pilot's face.

Stigler nodded. He gestured, pointing down: land in Germany, surrender, your men will get a doctor. Brown did not understand, or would not. By Stigler's account, he then pointed north and tried to mouth the word *Sweden*, a neutral country half an hour away, where they could land and be safe. Brown did not understand that either.

By one account, Brown told Frenchy Coulombe, in the top turret, to aim his guns at the fighter and hold his fire. So for a while the German pilot who

was sparing them flew with an American gun trained on him.

Then they reached the coast. Along the German shore were anti-aircraft batteries that would have finished the bomber in seconds. By Stigler's account, he stayed on the bomber's wing, so that the gunners on the ground would see a German fighter in formation and hold their fire. The bomber passed over the coast and out over the gray water of the North Sea.

Out over the sea, Franz Stigler raised his hand and saluted. Then he rolled his plane over and turned back toward Germany.

As he left, he later said, he thought: *Good luck. You're in God's hands.*

◆◆◆

By his own account, he knew that if anyone reported what he had done, he could be court-martialed and shot. Stigler told no one. He would go on flying for the rest of the war and would claim more than two dozen Allied aircraft in all. The mercy of that afternoon was one hour in a long career of killing, and he knew it.

Ye Olde Pub crossed some two hundred and fifty miles of open sea and came down at the first airfield Brown could reach, in Norfolk.

At the debriefing, Brown described the German fighter that had flown beside him and let them go. The report was stamped secret. The crew received no medals. Hugh Eckenrode was buried in England,

far from Pennsylvania. Brown flew his last mission the following April and went home.

◆ ◆ ◆

Both men carried the afternoon for forty-six years without knowing what had happened to the other.

Stigler emigrated to Canada in 1953 and eventually built a business near Vancouver. Brown served in the United States Air Force and the Foreign Service, then retired to Miami, married, and raised two daughters.

In the 1980s, Brown began having nightmares about the twentieth of December.

In 1986, at a gathering of veteran pilots, someone asked him about his worst mission, and he told the story of the German who had let them go. Afterward he began to search. For four years he wrote to archives and veterans' associations. Finally he placed a notice in the newsletter of the association of former German fighter pilots, asking whether the pilot who had escorted a crippled B-17 out over the North Sea on the twentieth of December 1943 was still alive.

In January 1990, a letter arrived at his house in Miami from Canada.

Dear Charles, it began. *All these years I wondered what happened to that B-17, did she make it home? Did her crew survive their wounds? To hear of your survival has filled me with indescribable joy.*

Brown called. He asked the voice on the other end to describe what had happened that day. When

Stigler described the escort and the salute over the sea, details no one else could have known, Brown said: *My God, it's you.*

Later that year, they met in person, in a hotel lobby. Two old men, one who had tried to kill the other and could not, embraced and wept.

◆◆◆

They became friends. They went fishing together. Brown organized a reunion of his surviving crew, and the men who had been in the waist and the turrets and the radio room met the pilot who had spared them. Someone made a video of the crew's children and grandchildren, and Stigler watched it and cried.

At some point Stigler gave Brown a book about the fighter wing he had flown with in North Africa, and wrote an inscription in it:

In 1940 I lost my only brother as a night fighter. On the 20th of December, 4 days before Christmas, I had the chance to save a B-17 from her destruction, a plane so badly damaged it was a wonder that she was still flying. The pilot, Charlie Brown, is for me, as precious as my brother was. Thanks Charlie. Your Brother, Franz.

He miscounted the days. It was five days before Christmas. He did not miscount the rest.

Brown's daughter Dawn later said that after her father found Franz Stigler, the nightmares went away.

◆◆◆

In February 2008, sixty-four years after the mission, the United States Air Force finally recognized the crew of *Ye Olde Pub*. The surviving men, and Hugh Eckenrode posthumously, received the Silver Star.

Franz Stigler died in British Columbia on the twenty-second of March 2008, at ninety-two. Charlie Brown died in Miami that November, at eighty-six. They had known each other for eighteen years, and had spent forty-six before that each wondering whether the other was alive.

In 2012 a writer named Adam Makos, who had interviewed both men at length, told their story in a book called *A Higher Call*. Much of its inner detail comes from Stigler's memory, recalled half a century later, and some historians and veterans have questioned how much of the chivalry of the German air force it romanticizes. The core of the story stands on the record: the secret debriefing, the medals, the letter, the two men in the hotel lobby.

◆ ◆ ◆

Nine men came home from Bremen that day. Every child and grandchild of those nine exists, in part, because a German pilot looked through the holes in a bomber and could not pull the trigger.

Picture one of them: a woman in her forties, say, a schoolteacher in Pennsylvania, whose grandfather sat in the waist of *Ye Olde Pub* with a frozen gun. She grew up knowing he had been in the war and did not talk about it. She has two children of her own. On some ordinary afternoon she is standing at a kitchen counter, packing lunches, and she does

not think about the North Sea at all. She does not have to. That is what the salute bought.

There is a rule now, written into the laws of war in the Geneva Conventions, that a person parachuting from an aircraft in distress may not be made the object of attack, and that an enemy who is wounded, helpless, and out of the fight is no longer a target. It was written for the world after 1945. A commander in North Africa had already said it to a young pilot in plainer words, and one afternoon over Germany the young pilot remembered.

> Side note: On the second of March 1942, in the Java Sea, the Japanese destroyer *Ikazuchi* came upon hundreds of Allied sailors from the sunken British destroyer *Encounter* and the American destroyer *Pope*. They had been in the water about twenty hours, many so coated in oil they could not see. Her captain, Lieutenant Commander Shunsaku Kudō, ordered them brought aboard, though stopping left his ship exposed to submarines. His crew pulled 442 men from the sea. One of them, a young officer named Sam Falle, became a British diplomat. In December 2008, long after Kudō's death, Falle visited his grave. Kudō had been so quiet about it that his family first learned what he had done when Falle came to see them.

Question: Who is in front of you, out of the fight and unable to defend themselves, waiting to see whether you will be merciful?

Question: What are three ways that what is happening could be kind?

Action: Sit for five minutes and silently wish someone well: first someone you love, then a stranger, then someone you find difficult. "May you be safe. May you be well. May you be at ease." Notice what changes in you by the third person.

Chapter Seventeen

Railway

———

Cobalt

"*Forgiveness is possible when someone is ready to accept forgiveness.*" — Eric Lomax, The Forgiveness Project

◆◆◆

Eric Lomax loved railways before he loved almost anything else.

He was born in Edinburgh in 1919. At sixteen he left school for a job at the Post Office, tapping out telegrams, and he would photograph trains and write about them for the rest of his life.

In 1939, at twenty, he joined the Royal Corps of Signals, and at the end of 1940 he was sent east as a second lieutenant. In February 1942 Singapore fell to the Japanese, and Lomax, twenty-two years old, was one of tens of thousands of British and Commonwealth soldiers marched into captivity at Changi.

Then the Japanese army found a use for him too. It needed a railway.

◆◆◆

The line was to run about four hundred and fifteen kilometres, from Thailand through the jungle and the mountains to Burma. Engineers had looked at the route before and turned it down. The Japanese built it anyway, from 1942, with Allied prisoners of war and a far larger number of labourers conscripted from across Southeast Asia. Around twelve thousand Allied prisoners died building it. More than ninety thousand of the Asian labourers died. It became known as the Death Railway.

Lomax was sent to Kanchanaburi, the base town on the river where the line began its climb toward Burma. The boy who had loved engines in Edinburgh was now building a railway with his hands, for an enemy.

He and a few other officers did something dangerous. They put together a radio receiver from scrap parts and hid it, so that they could hear the news of the war and pass it quietly through the camp. Lomax also drew a map. It showed the railway and the ground the prisoners were held in. To the men who found it, it looked like an escape plan, or a spy's chart.

In August 1943 the radio was discovered. Ten men were arrested. They were beaten so badly that two of them died. Lomax was beaten for hours. His arms were broken and his ribs were broken. One account counts nine hundred blows in six hours. Then he was handed to the Kempeitai, the Japanese military police, for interrogation. Through everything that followed, he refused to confess to what they wanted him to say.

◆◆◆

In the room with the Kempeitai was a small man in uniform who spoke English. His name was Takashi Nagase, and he was the interpreter.

Lomax would never forget his voice. The questions came through him, about the radio and about the map, and the accusation behind them was spying. The radio could only receive; it could not send a word to anyone. It made no difference. They forced water into his nose and mouth. At night he was kept in a cage. Through all of it, there was the interpreter's flat English voice. Lomax remembered it intoning the same sentence: *Lomax, you will be killed.* That voice followed him home and into his sleep for half a century, along with the interpreter's face.

Nagase remembered the room differently, and he remembered it for the rest of his life. He said later that as he watched what was being done, he felt he was going to lose his mind. He was the one who checked whether the prisoner was still alive. *I thought he was going to die*, he said, *and I still remember my relief when I felt his pulse.* According to one retelling of Lomax's own memory, when the sessions ended the interpreter would sometimes tell him to keep his chin up.

At one point, as his obituary in the Guardian recorded, he threw himself down a flight of steps so that he would be sent to hospital, away from the room. Lomax and five others were convicted of anti-Japanese activities. He was sent to Outram Road

Prison in Singapore, where he stayed until the war ended in 1945. A year later the army mentioned him in despatches for his services as a prisoner of war. He went home to Scotland a captain, and he was not, he said, the same man.

◆◆◆

Nagase went home too, but first he did something nobody required of him.

He was born in 1918, in or near Kurashiki in Okayama prefecture. He had studied English at Aoyama Gakuin University, which is why the army had made him an interpreter. He was never tried for what happened at Kanchanaburi. He maintained that he had only interpreted, and some who later wrote about the case agreed that he had not laid hands on the prisoners himself. Lomax never saw it that way. To the end, he called Nagase *my interrogator and torturer.*

When Japan surrendered, the Allied forces sent search parties up and down the railway to find the prisoners who had been buried where they fell along the line. Nagase went with them as a volunteer interpreter. For seven weeks he helped locate the bodies, around thirteen thousand of them, so that they could be gathered and properly buried.

The work of searching for bodies changed my whole life, he said.

Back in Japan he became an English teacher. He thought about killing himself. Instead he began, slowly, to speak. He wrote and lectured about what the Japanese army had done on the railway, and he

criticised the military and the system that had sent it there. It did not make him popular. He said, and kept saying, that the Emperor should apologise for what had been done in his name. In 1976 he organised the first reunion between former prisoners of war and former Japanese soldiers on the bridge at Kanchanaburi, and Japanese newspapers criticised him for holding the Thai flag instead of his own. By the mid-1980s he had spent much of his own money building a small Buddhist temple for peace near the bridge. He was ordained as a monk so that he could dedicate merit to the dead. He set up a foundation that paid for poor students in Kanchanaburi to go to school.

He kept going back. By his own count, by 2005 he had made the journey to Thailand more than a hundred and twenty times. He said the trips calmed his soul.

He also wrote a short book about the war, which appeared in English in 1990 as *Crosses and Tigers*. In it he described the discovery of the radio, the interrogation of a young British officer, and the bodies he had helped dig up afterward. He wrote that when he visited the graves, his sense of guilt had lifted. He believed, he wrote, that he had been pardoned.

◆ ◆ ◆

In Scotland, Eric Lomax said nothing.

Within weeks of coming home, on 20 November 1945, he married Agnes Dickson, called Nan, a telegraphist from the Post Office. They had three

children. He worked in the Colonial Service, then for the Scottish Gas Board, and lectured at the University of Strathclyde. From the outside it was an ordinary, decent, productive life.

Inside it, he was still in the room at Kanchanaburi. He had nightmares. He could not talk about the war with his wife or his children, and he could not stop it talking to him. His relationship with his father broke down. He later wrote that *the privacy of the torture victim is more impregnable than any fortress.* He admitted to an intense and implacable hatred for Japanese people. *I had to admit*, he said, *that I wanted to make them pay, pay more than they had already done.* For decades he fantasised about finding the interpreter and getting his hands around his neck. *I wanted to drown him, cage him and beat him*, he said, *as he had done to me.*

His family paid for it. When he died, the Guardian's obituary said so plainly: in some ways his family was made to pay for his suffering. His first marriage lasted thirty-seven years and broke under the strain.

In 1980, on a train, he met a Canadian-born nurse named Patricia Wallace, called Patti, seventeen years younger than he was. He and Patti married in 1983. On their honeymoon she began to see what she had married. *He had flashbacks*, she said, *long silences if I happened to say something that triggered a memory.* It was two years of counselling before she understood, piece by piece, what had been done to him on the railway.

◆◆◆

He had retired in 1982, and with time on his hands he began to dig, slowly and painstakingly, years before anyone could look anything up on a screen. *After my retirement in 1982*, he said, *I started searching for information about what had happened in Siam.*

In 1987 he found his way to a small charity in London, the Medical Foundation for the Care of Victims of Torture, founded two years earlier by Helen Bamber and a group of doctors. He was among its first patients, some say the very first. Bamber listened, and kept listening. A journalist who wrote about Lomax a few years later described how patiently she uncovered the hidden traces that torture leaves and brought them back into the light. Nothing about it was quick. The fortress he had built around that room in Kanchanaburi had stood for more than forty years. Patti came to sessions with him in 1988 and 1989. *For the first time*, he said later, *I was able to unload the hate that had become my prison.*

Some time before, in the mid-1980s, a fellow former prisoner had sent him a newspaper cutting. It was about a Japanese man who had been an interpreter on the railway and who was now working for reconciliation. The man was Nagase. He was alive. He had built a temple. He was doing good works.

His first feeling had been cold scepticism. *I couldn't believe in the notion of Japanese repentance*, he said. Then *Crosses and Tigers* came into his hands, and he came to the passage about the young British

officer and the radio, and he realised that the prisoner Nagase was describing was himself.

◆ ◆ ◆

Patti read the book too, and she was angry.

It was, she said later, a really cold anger. The man who had stood in that room was writing that he felt forgiven. Nobody had asked her husband. With Eric's permission, she sat down and wrote to Nagase. She asked him how he could feel forgiven when Eric Lomax had not forgiven him.

A letter came back from Japan. She did not want to open it. It seemed to her an evil thing. When she did open it, she found a man who was not defending himself at all. *The dagger of your letter thrusted me into my heart to the bottom*, Nagase wrote, in English. He wrote about his life since the war and his work in Thailand, and he asked whether he might meet her husband.

Patti's anger went out of her as she read. So, in time, did a good part of Eric's. He would describe it later as compassion arriving where rage had been, compassion for both of them, for the young officer and the young interpreter. The letters went back and forth for months, and it was about two years before Lomax agreed to a meeting. His psychiatric advisers told him not to go.

He went.

◆ ◆ ◆

In March 1993, Eric and Patti Lomax travelled to Kanchanaburi. Patti had arranged it, letter by letter,

over the two years since she first wrote. A film crew under the director Mike Finlason came with them. The meeting took place by the river, near the bridge the prisoners had built. Lomax was seventy-three. As late as 1991, by his own account, he had not spoken to a single Japanese person since 1945, and he was not inclined to forgive. He said afterward that he had arrived simmering with rage.

Nagase was seventy-five, small and frail, in a straw hat and a loose jacket. He bowed formally. Lomax stepped forward, held out his hand, and said in Japanese, *Good morning, Mr Nagase, how are you?*

Nagase was trembling and in tears. He kept saying the same words. *I am so sorry, so very, very sorry.* And the man who had wanted for fifty years to drown him found himself comforting him by the river.

We both survived, Lomax said.

I think I can die safely now, Nagase said.

He told Lomax that he had never forgotten his face, and especially his eyes. *Fifty years is a long time*, he said, *but for me it is a time of suffering.* He told him he had been the one who measured his pulse. Later he tried to ask for forgiveness and could not find the words, so he asked something smaller instead. He asked whether they could be friends. Lomax said yes.

They spent several days together in Kanchanaburi. To their own surprise, they talked about books, about teaching, about history, and about the railway itself, which both of them had come to see as a futile

thing, since most of the track had been torn up after the war. Some of the time, Lomax said, they even laughed. Before he left Thailand he went to the war cemetery at Chungkai, where many of the men who had built the railway are buried.

◆◆◆

The forgiveness itself came later, and in private.

Nagase invited the Lomaxes to Japan, and within weeks of the meeting by the river they were there. They were treated as honoured guests in Kurashiki. They saw the cherry blossom. Eric laid flowers at Hiroshima. Then, in a quiet hotel room in Tokyo, with no cameras, the two men sat down alone, and Lomax took out a letter he had written and read it aloud.

He told Nagase that he could never forget what had happened at Kanchanaburi in 1943. He told him that he admired the courage it had taken to speak against militarism in his own country and to work for reconciliation. And he told him that he gave him his total forgiveness. He suggested, too, that Nagase need no longer carry on his own shoulders the guilt of the whole Japanese nation. Nagase was overcome.

Lomax said that after that he never again felt the old anger toward him. They wrote to each other and telephoned for the rest of their lives, and exchanged Christmas cards. In 1995 Lomax published his account of all of it, *The Railway Man*. It won the NCR Book Award and the PEN/Ackerley Prize. Its last line is plain: *Some time the hating has to stop.* One retelling places those words earlier, spoken to

Patti at the cemetery at Chungkai before they left Thailand. Either way, they were his.

The friendship outlived the cameras by almost twenty years.

After our meeting, Lomax said, *I felt I'd come to some kind of peace and resolution.* In his book he called the interpreter his blood-brother.

Nagase, meanwhile, would not stop. In July 2005, at eighty-seven, frail and with a weak heart, he apologised to a group of British high school students in Japan for what his country's army had done to their grandfathers' generation. *The shame belongs to the whole Japanese race*, he said. He wanted the railway declared a World Heritage Site, so that it would never be forgotten.

Asked about it, Lomax did not hesitate. *He has my complete support*, he said. He himself had no romance left about the line he had helped to build. *The railway*, he said, *is a dead end in the jungle.*

None of it was simple, and he never pretended it was.

I have not forgiven Japan as a nation, he told the New York Times in 1995, *but I have forgiven a man because he experienced great personal remorse.* In the same year he admitted that, before all this, *I would have been happy to murder him. The psychological damage*, he said of what was done to him, *stays with you forever.*

Nor did the reconciliation reach backward into everything the war had broken. His daughter Linda

died on 13 December 1993, the same year as the meeting by the river. His first family had lived through the years of his silence, and that cost was not undone by a meeting in Thailand or a letter in Tokyo.

In 2013 the story became a feature film, with Colin Firth as Lomax and Nicole Kidman as Patti. The film gave him a climax he never had: a confrontation by the river in which the older Lomax threatens Nagase with a knife. None of that happened. In life the two men had written to each other for a long time before they met, and they met with a camera crew and a wife looking on, and the first thing the old soldier did was say good morning.

Nagase died in Kurashiki on 21 June 2011, at ninety-three. Eric Lomax died in Berwick-upon-Tweed on 8 October 2012, also at ninety-three, before the film was finished. Patti lived on in Berwick, and when the film came out she was the one who told his story, to anyone who asked. When she died there in August 2022, at eighty-five, Nicole Kidman wrote that she had been all heart and soul.

◆ ◆ ◆

Kanchanaburi is a busy town now. Trains still cross the steel bridge, and tourists walk across it between them, taking pictures of the river.

Near the old prisoners' base camp is the Kanchanaburi War Cemetery. It holds 6,982 graves, in long, quiet rows. Many of the men who lie there were found in the jungle by search parties after the war, and some of them were found with the help of a

young Japanese interpreter who could not stop looking.

In London, the small charity Lomax found in 1987 is now called Freedom from Torture. People still come through its doors from every part of the world, carrying rooms of their own that they have never described to anyone, and someone sits with them and listens until they can.

Somewhere in Kanchanaburi this morning, a girl in a white school blouse is waiting at the level crossing for a train to pass, her books held against her chest. Perhaps her school fees, or her mother's, were once paid by an old man from Japan who came back more than a hundred times. The train goes by. The barrier lifts, and she crosses the tracks.

> Side note: Helen Bamber, who sat with Eric Lomax when he could not yet speak of the railway, learned to listen in 1945, when she was twenty. She went into the liberated camp at Bergen-Belsen with one of the first relief teams. *After a while*, she said, *I began to realise the most important role for me there was to bear witness.* Forty years later, in 1985, she helped found the Medical Foundation for the Care of Victims of Torture in London. She kept bearing witness until she died in 2014, at eighty-nine.

Question: Is there someone who once hurt you whose own regret you have never let yourself see, and what might it change to look at it?

Question: What are three ways that what is happening could be kind?

Action: Write a letter of forgiveness to someone who hurt you, one you will not send. Say plainly what happened and what it cost you. Then write what you are choosing to set down.

Chapter Eighteen

They Need Praying For

———

Blue

"*None of our babies are born into the world knowing anything about disliking one another.*"
— Ruby Bridges, NPR, November 2020

◆◆◆

Ruby Bridges thought it was Mardi Gras.

She was six years old, and she had lived in New Orleans since she was four, long enough to know what a crowd lining a street meant. People stood shoulder to shoulder on the sidewalks. They shouted and waved their arms and threw things. To a child in New Orleans, that was a parade. *Living in New Orleans,* she said many years later, *I thought it was Mardi Gras that day.*

It was Monday, the 14th of November, 1960. Four deputy United States marshals had come to the Bridges house that morning in a car, big men in suits, to drive a first-grader to school. Her parents had told her almost nothing about where she was going. She did not know the school was white. She did not know that a federal judge had ordered New Orleans to integrate its public schools, or that she

was one of only a handful of Black children in the city who had passed the entrance test the Orleans Parish School Board had designed, by most accounts, to keep Black children out. Three of the others were sent together to another school. Ruby was sent to William Frantz Elementary alone.

Her parents gave her one instruction. *Ruby,* she remembered them saying, *you're going to go to a new school today, and you better behave.*

The marshals walked her up the steps between them, and she went inside.

◆ ◆ ◆

She did not go to a classroom that first day. There was too much going on. She spent the whole day in the principal's office, sitting with her mother, and through the door and the windows she watched white parents come into the building and take their children home. They came in the morning and kept coming. By her own count, given decades later, about five hundred children walked out of William Frantz that day, and most of them never came back while she was there.

She did not understand why. Nobody explained it to her. The next morning the marshals came again, and the crowd was waiting again. *By the time I got there on the second day,* she said, *the school was totally empty.*

That second morning a woman in the crowd told her she was going to poison her. After that, the marshals ruled that Ruby could eat only food that came from her own home. On another morning a woman stood

in the crowd holding up a small Black doll lying in a wooden coffin. The shouted threats frightened her less than the doll did.

The crowd gathered every morning and every afternoon, and the marshals walked her through it. When she needed to use the restroom during the day, a marshal walked her down the hall and waited. She was not allowed outside for recess. Charles Burks, one of the four men who walked beside her, later described what he saw. She showed a lot of courage, he said. She never cried. She never whimpered. *She just marched along like a little soldier.*

◆◆◆

The teacher waiting for her in that classroom was named Barbara Henry, and she was twenty-eight years old.

She had grown up in Boston, in classes that included Black students and Black teachers, and had taught at an Air Force base school in France. She and her husband had been in New Orleans only about two months when the superintendent of schools offered her a first-grade position, two days before Ruby arrived. She asked him whether the school would be integrated. He asked her whether that would make any difference to her. She said it would not.

Every other white teacher at Frantz refused to teach the new girl. So for the rest of that year, and into the next, Barbara Henry taught one child in an empty room as if she were teaching a full class, the

whole first-grade program, lesson by lesson, for an audience of one.

Ruby had never had a white teacher. When she first saw Mrs. Henry, she said, *she looked exactly like the mob outside the classroom.* It did not take long for that to change. *She cared about me,* Ruby said, *she made school fun, and ultimately I felt safe in that classroom.* When the shouting outside grew loud, Mrs. Henry closed the window and put on music. *Inside that room,* Ruby said, *it was filled with love.*

There were small troubles that the adults did not see at first. Ruby was not allowed to eat in the cafeteria, and she began to hide the sandwiches her mother packed in a storage cabinet in the classroom instead of eating them. The janitor eventually found them, along with the mice and cockroaches they had attracted. After that, Mrs. Henry ate her lunch with Ruby in the empty room.

Ruby called her *Mrs. Henry* then, and she still called her *Mrs. Henry* as a grown woman. *She was very nurturing,* Ruby said. *She was like another mother to me.*

◆◆◆

As the weeks went on, Ruby began to suspect that she was not the only child in the building. She could hear other children somewhere. A few white families, it turned out, had started sending their children back, and the principal kept them in another part of the school, away from her. Mrs. Henry kept going to the principal about it, again and

again. Ruby did not learn until much later how often her teacher had argued on her behalf.

Others followed, a few at a time. But Ruby was kept apart from them, and when at last she found them, she was simply glad. *I was so excited,* she said. *It didn't matter to me what they looked like.*

A little boy among them told her he couldn't play with her. *My mom said not to play with you.*

That, she said, was the moment it all came together. The crowd outside, the empty desks, the marshals, the doll. *The reason why there were no kids here was because of me, and the color of my skin.* She was six. She called it her first encounter with racism, and she said the little boy was the one who *actually made it make sense.*

◆◆◆

That fall, a young doctor named Robert Coles happened to be driving past William Frantz Elementary on his way to an early appointment. He was a military psychiatrist, in New Orleans for his own psychoanalytic training. He saw the crowd. He saw a small girl come out between the marshals. He heard what people were screaming at her, which included the promise that she was going to die. He decided he wanted to understand what this was doing to a child.

He reached the Bridges family, and he began to visit Ruby every week, at home and at school, for the whole of that year. He asked her to draw, and her pictures made the white people large and strong. He asked the questions a psychiatrist asks: how she was

sleeping, how she was eating, how she felt. Ruby and her mother kept telling him she was fine. Her teacher told him the same thing in a different way. *You know, I don't understand this child,* she said. *She seems so happy. She comes here so cheerfully.*

Then one morning Ruby's teacher told him something else. *I saw Ruby talking to those people on the street this morning.* On the walk in, between the marshals, she had stopped, and she seemed to be speaking to the crowd.

Coles asked Ruby about it. She told him she had not been talking to them. *I was just saying a prayer for them.*

She prayed for them every morning on the way in and every afternoon on the way home, she said, and again at night, when she went through the people one by one, like a list. Coles asked her why. *Because they need praying for,* she said.

Her mother explained where it came from. The family went to a Baptist church, and their minister prayed for the people in the crowd from the pulpit every Sunday. *We think that we all have to pray for people like that, and we think Ruby should, too,* Lucille Bridges told him. Ruby's mother had told her something simpler too, as Ruby remembered it later: that if she was ever afraid and her mother was not with her, she should say her prayers. Ruby found that the prayers took some of the force out of the words being shouted at her.

Coles pressed. He suggested that this was a great deal to ask of a six-year-old. Ruby did not think so.

Especially it should be me, she told him. *Because if you're going through what they're doing to you, you're the one who should be praying for them.* Her minister had said that Jesus went through a lot of trouble, she explained, and that he had said, *Forgive them, because they don't know what they're doing.*

Coles went home and talked about it with his wife, Jane. He told her honestly that he would not pray for people who did what that crowd was doing. They tried to imagine what they would do instead. They would call the police, they decided. They would hire a lawyer. They would write about it. Ruby had none of those things. What she had was the prayer.

He tried, for a while, to file it under something he understood. Perhaps it was denial, or a child's ignorance of what was really happening to her. Plenty of people with far more education and power than Ruby, they came to see, would never say those words at all. Coles thought of the educated, cultivated Germans who had cheered for the Nazis, and the idea that ignorance explained the crowd, or explained Ruby, came apart in his hands. He began to wonder instead what it was that he had been taught, and what he had not.

He had come south from Boston, where he had treated the anxious children of comfortable families. Now he sat in a small house in New Orleans with a girl who was, by every measure he had been trained to use, coping better than most of his patients ever had.

Coles told the story for the rest of his life, in lectures and essays and a children's book, and the details shift a little from one telling to the next. In his 1985 account, the teacher saw Ruby stop and seem to speak to the people on the street. In later retellings, her lips are moving as she walks through the crowd, and the prayer itself is given in her voice: *Please, dear God, forgive them, because they don't know what they're doing.* Every version keeps the center: a six-year-old girl, walking through people who were shouting that they would kill her, praying that they would be forgiven. Coles admitted that his training as a psychiatrist gave him no way to explain it.

◆ ◆ ◆

The crowd was not the only cost.

Ruby's father, Abon, had not wanted her to go. He and Lucille had been sharecroppers in Mississippi before they came to New Orleans, and he believed, as many did, that segregation was there to stay. Lucille argued that it was a step forward for every Black child in the city, and he gave way.

The Bridges family had very little to lose. Lucille cleaned other people's houses, often leaving before dawn, and cared for the children at home. Then Abon lost his job. Ruby's accounts and most later histories say he was let go from the filling station where he worked; Coles, writing in 1985, described him as a janitor. The family's grocery store told them not to come back. In Mississippi, Ruby's grandparents were turned off the land they had sharecropped for more than twenty-five years.

There was another side to the neighborhood. A neighbor found Abon a new job. People on the street took turns watching the Bridges house. Some of them babysat Ruby's younger brothers and sisters. And on the drive to school, neighbors walked behind the marshals' car. Years later Ruby learned that the clothes she had worn to school in those first weeks had been sent to her family by a relative of Robert Coles.

Barbara Henry paid too. Her contract was not renewed, and she went home to Boston. Ruby went into second grade without her, and found it harder than first grade. *She was my best friend,* Ruby said of Mrs. Henry, *and second grade was much worse for me than first.* Her parents later separated.

◆◆◆

In 1963, the painter Norman Rockwell, newly free of his long contract with the Saturday Evening Post, began a canvas of that walk. It ran across the center pages of Look magazine on January 14, 1964, under the title *The Problem We All Live With.* A small Black girl walks in profile, carrying her school things. Four marshals walk with her, two in front and two behind, cut off at the shoulders so that she is the only person whose face can be seen. Behind them, on a wall, are a slur and the letters KKK and the red smear of a thrown tomato. The crowd is not in the picture at all. The viewer stands where the crowd stood.

Rockwell received sacks of angry mail, and at least one letter called him a traitor to his race. Ruby

never met him. As an adult she came to admire the courage it had taken to paint it.

She grew up. She worked for about fifteen years as a travel agent. She married Malcolm Hall, and they had four sons. For a long time she did not speak much about William Frantz.

In 1993, her youngest brother, Malcolm, was shot and killed in New Orleans. Ruby took in his four young daughters and raised them. The girls went to school at William Frantz Elementary, which by then had become an all-Black school, and Ruby went back with them. She began working at the school as a parent liaison, in the same building where she had once been the only child in a classroom.

In 1995, Coles published his picture book, *The Story of Ruby Bridges,* and gave its royalties to support Ruby's work with children.

Then the book found its way to a boy in Boston named Ruben Croft. His mother, Diane Croft, had helped produce a print-and-braille edition, and he took a copy to his school, where it turned out that one of the staff was Barbara Henry. She wanted the book, and she had been trying for years to find out what had happened to the little girl. When Diane Croft called the publisher, Scholastic, she learned that Ruby had been looking for her teacher too. In 1996, after thirty-five years apart, they met again on television, on The Oprah Winfrey Show. Ruby, a grown woman with children of her own, called her *Mrs. Henry,* and was greeted with open arms.

They kept meeting after that. They gave talks together, with Ruby at the center and her teacher beside her. Barbara Henry, asked about that year, turned the gift around. *As much as I was there for her,* she said, *she was there for me.*

◆◆◆

In 1999 Ruby founded the Ruby Bridges Foundation, to teach children what she had learned in that empty building. Its guiding words are a sentence she has repeated for decades: *Racism is a grown-up disease, and we must stop using our children to spread it.* On July 15, 2011, she stood in a hallway of the West Wing of the White House, near the door of the Oval Office. The Norman Rockwell Museum had lent *The Problem We All Live With* to hang there, and the president had invited her to see it. Barack Obama stood beside her and looked at the small girl walking between the marshals. *I think it's fair to say,* he told her, *that if it hadn't been for you guys, I might not be here, and we wouldn't be looking at this together.* He asked her whether she could still put her head back into those times. She told him she could, and that she went back there often. Ruby, by then fifty-six, said what she had come to say to every audience. *We all stand on the shoulders of those who have gone before us.*

In September 2013 she sat down with Charles Burks again. He was ninety-one, the last of her four marshals still alive. They had met only once since 1960, in 1995. He told her that walking her to school had been one of the highlights of his life. *It was a privilege to be able to do what I did,* he said, *even*

though it was one of my duties. Ruby thanked him. *Thank you, Charlie,* she said, *for doing what was right at a time when it might not have been the easiest thing to do.*

In 2014 a statue of her as a six-year-old was unveiled at William Frantz. She has told the story to children in schools across the country for decades now. She tells it in the plainest words. She says that at six she knew nothing about racism, and that she learned it, in that building, from a little boy who had learned it from his mother. She says the lesson she took from that year is that none of us know anything about disliking one another when we come into the world. She says it is passed on to us. She does not tell children to hate the people who shouted at her.

◆◆◆

Somewhere this morning, a little girl is sitting at a desk by a classroom window with a new box of crayons. It is her first week at this school. She does not yet know anyone's name, and at recess she stood by the fence for a while before a girl with braids asked her to turn one end of a jump rope. She does not know the name of the woman who once walked into a school between four men in suits, or that a teacher from Boston once ate lunch beside a six-year-old in an empty room so that the child would not have to eat alone.

The boy at the next desk has not spoken to her all morning. When he drops his pencil, it rolls under her chair. She picks it up and hands it back to him, and he says thank you, and she goes on with her

drawing. Her teacher, passing between the rows, stops for a moment to look at it. It is a house, and a yard, and a great many people, all of them the same size.

> Side note: On the second day of the boycott, a Methodist minister named Lloyd Foreman walked his five-year-old daughter, Pam, through the same mob outside William Frantz Elementary and took her to school. Other white parents slowly began to follow, and the protests eventually faded. Fifty years later, in 2010, Ruby Bridges went back to the school for a reunion marking the anniversary, and she marked it there alongside Pam Foreman Testroet, the little girl whose father had walked her in.

Question: Is there someone who has been unkind to you whom you could, like Ruby, quietly wish well today, even if you never tell them?

Question: What are three ways that what is happening could be kind?

Action: Give yourself, or someone around you, a warm hug and say clearly: "I'm glad you are here!"

Chapter Nineteen

Corn

———

Dark Blue

"*Whilst I live I will never forget this kindness they have showed me.*" — Massasoit, sachem of the Pokanoket Wampanoag, 1623, as recorded by Edward Winslow

◆◆◆

In the summer of 1614, an English ship anchored off the coast of what is now Massachusetts, near a village called Patuxet.

The ship was commanded by Thomas Hunt, who had stayed behind to trade. He invited some twenty men of Patuxet aboard with the promise of trade goods. When they were aboard, he seized them. He sailed south to Cape Cod and took seven more men from the Nauset people. Then he crossed the Atlantic to the Spanish port of Málaga.

A notary's record from October 1614, found in the city archive of Málaga four centuries later, records the sale of twenty-five Native Americans by Hunt.

One of the men taken from Patuxet was called Tisquantum. The English would later shorten it to Squanto.

◆◆◆

Nobody knows exactly how he got from Spain to England. By around 1615 he was living in London, in the house of a merchant, and he learned English. From London he went to Newfoundland, and there he met a sea captain named Thomas Dermer, who was planning a voyage to New England.

In 1619, five years after he had been taken, Tisquantum sailed home with Dermer.

He found Patuxet empty.

Between 1616 and 1619, an epidemic had swept the coast of New England, a disease most likely carried on European ships, though no one is sure what it was. In some villages almost everyone died. Patuxet was one of them. His family, his neighbors, everyone he had grown up with, were gone. The cleared fields were growing back to brush.

He was, as a Mashpee Wampanoag historian named Paula Peters has put it, a man without a country.

◆◆◆

He did not stay with Dermer. The neighboring sachem, Massasoit, leader of the Pokanoket Wampanoag, whose people had suffered in the epidemic too, took Tisquantum into his community, under a watchful eye. To Massasoit, a man who had lived among the English, spoke their language, and had come back on an English ship was useful, and possibly dangerous.

In November 1620, another English ship arrived, the *Mayflower*, carrying about a hundred people who

wanted to build a godly community in a new world. They landed first on Cape Cod. Within days a party of them found baskets of corn the Nauset people had buried for the winter, and took it. They named the place Corn Hill. They also dug into graves. The corn they took, their governor William Bradford wrote later, gave them seed for the spring, without which they might have starved. In 1970 a Wampanoag man named Frank James would put it more plainly: within days of arriving, the newcomers had robbed the graves of his ancestors and stolen their corn and beans.

The English settled at the empty village of Patuxet and called it Plymouth. Their first winter there, about half of them died.

◆◆◆

On the sixteenth of March 1621, on a fair, warm day, a tall man walked boldly and alone into the English settlement, carrying a bow and two arrows, and greeted them in English. His name was Samoset, and he was an Abenaki leader from Maine who had learned some English from fishermen. They put a coat around him, fed him, and kept watch over him all night.

Six days later, Samoset came back, and he brought with him a man who spoke English much better than he did. It was Tisquantum.

The same day, Massasoit came, with sixty men, and with Tisquantum translating, the English and the Wampanoag agreed to a treaty of peace and mutual defense. Each would help the other if attacked.

Neither would come armed to the other's meetings. The treaty held for more than fifty years.

When Massasoit left, Tisquantum stayed with the English.

◆◆◆

That spring he showed them how to plant corn.

He showed them how to set the seed in small hills. He showed them when the herring ran up the town brook in April, and how to catch them, and that they must put fish into the hills with the seed, because these old fields, as Governor Bradford wrote, would otherwise come to nothing. They planted about twenty acres of corn, and that autumn they had, as Edward Winslow wrote, a good increase.

Historians still argue about where the fish came from. Some scholars believe putting fish in the cornfields was an old Native practice. Others believe Tisquantum may have learned it in Europe or in Newfoundland during his years of captivity and travel, and brought it home. Either way, the man who had been kidnapped by the English taught the English how to stay alive.

Bradford wrote about him in words that are still quoted in American classrooms. Tisquantum, he wrote, *was a special instrument sent of God for their good beyond their expectation.* He directed them how to set their corn, where to take fish, and how to get other things they needed. He was their pilot to unknown places. He never left them till he died. *He was a native of this place*, Bradford wrote, *and scarce any left alive besides himself.*

◆ ◆ ◆

That autumn, after the harvest, the English celebrated. Winslow's letter says the governor sent men out to hunt birds, and that many of the Native people came, among them Massasoit with about ninety men, and for three days they ate together, and the Wampanoag men went out and killed five deer and brought them in. It is one paragraph in one letter. Two centuries later, a historian would footnote it as "the first Thanksgiving," and in 1863 Abraham Lincoln would proclaim a national holiday that Americans came to connect with it.

A Mashpee Wampanoag elder known as Mother Bear has said of that feast: it was never repeated, and that should tell you something.

◆ ◆ ◆

Tisquantum was not a saint, and the record does not pretend he was.

Standing between two peoples, he learned what a man in the middle can do. According to Winslow, he told the surrounding villages that the English were about to attack them, and that he could prevent it, in exchange for gifts. He told them the English kept the plague buried in a pit under their storehouse and could let it out whenever they chose. It was the colony's gunpowder. It is worth pausing on who was telling that lie: a man whose entire village had been killed by a plague.

Bradford's verdict was blunt. Tisquantum, he wrote, sought his own ends and played his own game.

In the summer of 1621, a sachem hostile to the English, Corbitant, seized him and held a knife to his chest. The English marched out at night and rescued him. The following spring, Massasoit learned how his interpreter had been using his name, and he demanded Tisquantum's death, as the treaty entitled him to. His messengers came to Plymouth carrying beaver pelts as payment and Massasoit's own knife, with which Governor Bradford was to cut off Tisquantum's head and hands.

Bradford told the messengers that it was not the manner of the English to sell men's lives at a price. He refused the pelts. He stalled. Tisquantum, told what was being asked, said he would accept whatever the governor decided. The governor did not decide. Then a boat appeared offshore and gave him an excuse to send the messengers away.

◆◆◆

In November 1622 the colony was short of food again, and Bradford sailed around Cape Cod to buy corn from the Native villages. Tisquantum went with him as pilot. At a place called Monomoit, now Chatham, he fell ill.

Bradford described it. He fell sick of an Indian fever, *bleeding much at the nose (which the Indians take for a symptom of death)*, and within a few days he died there. He asked the governor to pray for him, *that he might go to the Englishmen's God in Heaven*. He gave away what he had to his English friends, *as remembrances of his love*.

Nothing he gave away is known to survive. Nobody knows where he was buried.

Some historians have wondered whether Massasoit had him poisoned. It cannot be known.

◆ ◆ ◆

Four months later, in March 1623, word reached Plymouth that Massasoit himself was dying. Edward Winslow and a Wampanoag man named Hobbamock walked to his village. They found him surrounded by people chanting and rubbing his limbs, unable to see. Winslow cleaned his mouth and tongue and fed him small amounts of fruit preserve and broth, and cared for others in the village who were sick. Massasoit recovered.

Now I see the English are my friends and love me, he said, as Winslow recorded it, *and whilst I live I will never forget this kindness they have showed me.*

He kept his word. For the rest of his life, nearly forty years, through every provocation, Massasoit held to the treaty with the English.

◆ ◆ ◆

He died around 1660. His sons, Wamsutta and Metacom, whom the English called Alexander and Philip, succeeded him. By then English settlements had spread over Wampanoag land, and English courts claimed authority over Wampanoag people. In 1675 the strain broke into war.

That war, called King Philip's War, was, for the size of the population, one of the deadliest in American history. Thousands of Native people died in the

fighting and of the hunger and sickness that followed. English towns burned. In August 1676 Metacom was shot at Mount Hope by a Native man fighting on the English side. The English cut off his head and displayed it on a pole in Plymouth for a generation.

Hundreds of Wampanoag and other Native captives were sold into slavery in the Caribbean, Bermuda, Spain, and Portugal. Among them was Metacom's nine-year-old son, Massasoit's grandson. The ministers of Plymouth debated whether a child should suffer for the sins of his father. Then he was sold overseas.

Of Massasoit's children, only one, a daughter, survived the war.

◆◆◆

The Wampanoag did not disappear. They are still in southeastern Massachusetts and on Martha's Vineyard, in the Mashpee and Aquinnah communities, and they tell their own history now.

In 1970, for the three hundred and fiftieth anniversary of the Pilgrims' landing, the state of Massachusetts invited an Aquinnah Wampanoag man named Frank James, known as Wamsutta, to speak at a banquet. When the organizers read his speech in advance, they would not let him give it. So on Thanksgiving Day he went to Cole's Hill, above Plymouth Rock, beside the statue of Massasoit, and gave it there. Native people have gathered on that hill every Thanksgiving since, for what they call a National Day of Mourning.

Paula Peters has said that Americans don't even ask themselves why Squanto spoke English. If they got the real answer, she said, they would be surprised, and they would be informed. She has also pointed out that the Wampanoag give thanks many times a year, for the first strawberries, for the corn, for the turn of the seasons, and that a single annual day of thanks belies that truth.

A Mashpee woman named Jessie Little Doe Baird has spent her life reviving Wôpanâak, the language Tisquantum grew up speaking. Children in Mashpee are learning it again.

◆ ◆ ◆

This Thanksgiving, in a kitchen somewhere, a grandmother is shucking corn while her granddaughter sits on the counter swinging her legs. Corn is the largest crop in the United States by far. It is in the bread on the table, the syrup in the cranberry sauce, the feed of the turkey in the oven. The granddaughter will be told, maybe, the story of the friendly Indian who helped the Pilgrims. Perhaps, some year, she will be told the rest: the ship in 1614, the empty village, the lie about the storehouse, the knife on the governor's table, the fever at Chatham, the boy sold overseas. And perhaps she will understand that both stories are true, and that the corn in her hands has passed through all of it.

> Side note: In 1847, word reached the Choctaw people, in what is now Oklahoma, that families in Ireland were starving. The Choctaw had only recently survived their own forced march west

on the Trail of Tears, and they had little to spare. They gathered $170 and sent it for famine relief. In Bailick Park, in the town of Midleton in County Cork, there now stands a sculpture called *Kindred Spirits*, dedicated in 2017: nine stainless steel eagle feathers, each about twenty feet tall, no two alike, arranged in a circle in the shape of an empty bowl.

Question: What on your table tonight, or in your life, grew out of someone else's loss, and whose name should you know?

Question: What are three ways that what is happening could be kind?

Action: The next time someone serves you, at a register, a counter or a kitchen, learn their name, use it, and thank them for something specific.

Chapter Twenty

Wooden Feet

———

Indigo

"*I'd want someone out there searching for me.*"
— Albert Dow, to his mother, Christmas 1981,
as remembered by his family

◆◆◆

Hugh Herr was the youngest of five children in a Mennonite family from Lancaster, Pennsylvania, and he had been climbing for as long as anyone could remember. By seventeen he was regarded as one of the best rock climbers in the United States.

In January 1982 he went north to New Hampshire with a climbing partner from Lancaster, Jeff Batzer, who was twenty. They wanted ice. On Friday, the 22nd, they hiked in to the Harvard Cabin, below Huntington Ravine on the eastern side of Mount Washington.

Mount Washington is not a tall mountain by the standards of the world. But it stands where several storm tracks meet, and its summit has recorded some of the worst weather on earth. It has killed more than a hundred people.

On Saturday morning, the 23rd, the two of them set out to climb Odell's Gully, a long ribbon of ice in the ravine, about a thousand feet of it. Snow was falling heavily. They climbed it in about an hour and a half. Their plan had been to come down by the Lion Head trail, and they had left their overnight gear behind, and their compass with it. At the top of the gully, with the snow still coming, they decided to try for the summit, some sixteen hundred feet higher.

◆◆◆

The wind found them above the ravine.

That weekend the wind on the mountain blew at more than 140 miles an hour. There was nothing to see in any direction but white. Somewhere on the way down, the wind pushed them off their line, and they went the wrong way, away from the cabin. By one account they ended up descending into the Great Gulf, a huge glacial bowl on the far side of the summit from where anyone expected them to be.

Twice, Hugh fell into a stream. In that cold, his lower legs began to freeze. Jeff took off his own dry wool pants and gave them to him.

They kept moving until they could not. In the trees they found a large rock, and behind it they made a shelter of cut spruce boughs and crawled inside. The temperature fell to around twenty degrees below zero. They lay against each other for warmth. Every half hour or so, Jeff said later, they beat each other with branches.

They prayed. They talked about dying. At some point, both of them stopped holding on to each other

for warmth, because it no longer seemed to matter. Hugh said to Jeff, *I think this is it.* Jeff answered, *I think so, too.*

They stayed there three nights. Some accounts of the story count four; the official accident report counts three, from Saturday to Tuesday. Neither of them knew where they were. Nobody else knew either.

◆◆◆

On Saturday night, when they did not come back to the Harvard Cabin, the caretaker there, Matt Pierce, radioed the Mountain Rescue Service for help.

The Mountain Rescue Service was an all-volunteer team based in North Conway, many of them climbers and climbing guides. Nobody was paid. On Sunday a group went up, but the snow was blowing so hard they could not see their own feet, and they turned back.

One of the volunteers who went up on Monday, when the weather finally cleared, was Albert Dow.

He was twenty-eight. His full name was Albert Henry Dow III, and he came from Tuftonboro, a small town on Lake Winnipesaukee. He taught climbing for the Eastern Mountain Sports Climbing School in North Conway. Joe Lentini, who had worked beside him for three and a half years, called him *one of the more dedicated members of MRS who made climbing very much a part of his life.* He was engaged to a woman named Joanie Wrigley. They were to be married in two weeks.

Less than a month before, at a Christmas party at his parents' house, his mother, Marjorie, asked him why he had risked his life a few weeks earlier, searching the mountain for a missing Snowcat driver. His answer was simple. *I'd want someone out there searching for me.* People who do mountain rescue in New Hampshire still say much the same thing to one another when they explain why they go.

◆◆◆

On Monday, the 25th of January, Albert Dow and another volunteer, Michael Hartrich, climbed Odell's Gully themselves, looking for any sign of the two boys. At the rim of the gully they found kick marks in the snow. Following the clues as best they could, they started down toward the Lion Head, the route Hugh and Jeff had meant to use.

Coming down the summer trail, they crossed the line of the winter trail and walked into a slope that had not been thought dangerous. The snow above them broke loose, probably triggered by their own crossing, somewhere between half past one and a quarter to two in the afternoon. The avalanche carried both men down through the trees.

Hartrich came to rest mostly buried. He managed to dig out his head and one arm and the radio, and he called for help. Other searchers reached the slide within about twenty minutes. They heard Hartrich yelling from below and dug him out, injured but alive. Then they formed a probe line and went through the debris for Albert. They found him close to where Hartrich had stopped, under two to four

feet of snow. He had struck a number of trees on the way down. There was no sign that he had breathed beneath the snow, and nothing they did could bring him back.

The official report places the avalanche near the base of the Lion Head, well below treeline; some later retellings put it higher, near the top of the gully, and one account says the search for Albert's body took closer to two hours. One retelling says he broke his neck in the fall through the trees.

The rescuers still had two missing climbers on the mountain, and they kept looking. Joe Lentini was one of them. Decades later, in front of a camera, he admitted what he had felt in those days. *I hated the people we were searching for,* he said. Then he went further. *But I realized I hated this young man because my friend was dead.* He did not pretend the boys had made no mistakes. *Sometimes, you just push that little too far,* he said. *And you don't know what's too far.* And then: *You're learning. Hopefully, you learn from it.*

His funeral was held that Thursday in Melvin Village, near the lake where he grew up. Albert Dow remains the first, and so far the only, member of a backcountry search and rescue team killed in the line of duty in the White Mountains.

◆◆◆

Hugh and Jeff did not know any of this.

On Tuesday, the 26th, a young woman named Cam Bradshaw, who worked the night watch at the Pinkham Notch camp, went out on snowshoes. She

came across a set of tracks that wandered and floundered, the tracks of someone in trouble, and she followed them. They led to a rock ledge with boughs set around it, and under it she found two men, alive. She asked whether they were the missing climbers. *We spilled out a yes,* Hugh remembered. *She gave us some raisins and a sweater.*

She snowshoed back out for help. A National Guard helicopter lifted both climbers out and flew them to the hospital in Littleton.

Hugh was close to death from the cold. His legs were frozen solid to the middle of his calves. Jeff was badly frostbitten too. By Thursday morning the hospital listed both young men in satisfactory condition. Hugh's legs, by then, could not be saved.

Dave Warren, who coordinated the search, called the outcome bittersweet. When Jeff was told that a man had died looking for them, he cried. *The thought that someone would put his life out on a limb for us,* he told a reporter that week, *was really something that we haven't gotten over.* Both of them said that if their feet ever recovered, they would like to join a mountain rescue team.

Their feet did not recover.

◆◆◆

Hugh spent more than a week in the hospital in Littleton, in agony and in a haze of morphine. Then he was moved home to Pennsylvania, to Presbyterian hospital in Philadelphia, where surgeons amputated both of his legs about six inches

below the knee. Jeff lost his lower left leg, all the toes on his right foot, and the thumb and fingers of his right hand.

Hugh was seventeen. He lay in a hospital bed with two short legs and the knowledge that a man he had never met was dead because of a decision he had made in a snowstorm. He described what followed plainly. The shock, he said, turned into *rage at myself for making bad decisions in the mountains and really putting others at risk.* He called it *the lowest point in my entire life.*

The accident report published the next year listed the causes in its heading, one after another: frostbite, hypothermia, bad weather, exposure, lost, inadequate equipment. It noted that the two of them had left their compass behind with their overnight gear. Hugh did not argue with any of it. He carried it.

He also decided what he would do with it. *I took on the view,* he said, *that I was going to use every cell in my body to do something positive in my life.* The rage, he said, was what drove him, ironically, to climb again. *I thought it would be an insult to the memory of Albert Dow,* he said, *to pity myself and to stay in a wheelchair.* In another telling, he said it would have been a degradation to Albert's memory if he did not use the rest of his life for something good. Three decades on, he told a magazine writer that the guilt was no longer a daily thought, but that it was still *an underlying driver.*

Albert Dow's death changed the mountain too. People who work search and rescue in New Hampshire speak of that January as the start of a new era. In its aftermath, New Hampshire changed how it protected volunteer rescuers who were hurt in the field. Rescuers in the White Mountains came to rely far more on avalanche beacons and helicopters, and the Mountain Rescue Service got better radios.

◆◆◆

The legs the doctors fitted for Hugh in 1982 were crude. He remembered looking at them and thinking, *Really? That's it?*

He had gone to a vocational high school and had never planned on college. What he had was a climber's eye and the skills he had picked up in a tool-and-die shop. So he went to a local machine shop in Lancaster and began building his own legs. A writer who met him that year, a seventeen-year-old building legs in a machine shop, wondered whether the boy's good cheer was simply denial. Hugh's father answered the question for him. *I don't think Hugh has a day without intense pain,* he said.

He made legs of rubber, metal, plastic and wood. He made small wooden feet for climbing, and feet with stiff toes that could stand on an edge of rock as narrow as a coin, and feet with titanium spikes for ice. He made legs of different lengths, so that he could set his height anywhere from about five foot seven to over seven feet, depending on where the next hold was. He took them out to the rock and

tinkered with them there until he could do things on a cliff that he had not been able to do before.

Within months of the amputation, accounts put it at five months or seven, he was back on the cliffs of the Shawangunks in New York, leading routes graded 5.11. His friends called him the Mechanical Boy. In 1983, with Lynn Hill and Russ Clune, he made the first ascent of a route called Vandals, which climbers count as the first 5.13 on the East Coast.

He did not stop at climbing. He studied physics, then earned degrees at MIT and Harvard, and came back to MIT, where he leads the Biomechatronics group at the Media Lab. He describes the work in plain terms. *It's when you build robots that attach to the body.* He tests many of the prototype feet and ankles himself, on his own legs.

He holds patents on the world's first powered ankle-foot prosthesis, which had sensors in the foot that read the force of each step and a small onboard computer that told a motor how much energy to add. Hugh explained the difference simply. *It's like a car. The other prostheses are like bicycles.* He wears two of them himself. At the end of a talk in 2010 he tap-danced on them. *I'm completely happy with my bionic limbs,* he told a writer. *I think my body is far more interesting than a normal body.*

On April 15, 2013, two bombs went off at the finish line of the Boston Marathon, a few miles from his lab. Hugh was walking the Camino de Santiago in Spain. *I felt hopeless, powerless,* he said. *I was so far away.* Among the injured was a ballroom dancer

named Adrianne Haslet, who lost her left leg below the knee. After she heard him speak, she came to MIT and tried his ankle. *Now I know I'll dance again,* she said.

In March 2014 he spoke on the TED stage in Vancouver. With him was Adrianne Haslet-Davis. In front of the audience she danced again, for the first time since the bombing, on a bionic leg built in his lab.

◆◆◆

The Dow family did their own work with their grief.

Albert's sisters, Caryl Dow and Susan Dow Johnson, kept his name in the mountains. They have said that his death was not in vain. The family paid for the extreme-weather exhibit in the museum of the Mount Washington Observatory, on the summit, which was rededicated to Albert and to the Mountain Rescue Service. At the ceremony, the president of the observatory thanked them. Joanie Wrigley, the woman Albert had been two weeks from marrying, came. Hugh Herr came too.

Hugh has spoken of Albert in his lectures for years, by name. He has said that he tries *to remember Albert's vision of love and service to his fellow humans. I try to do good in his name.*

Caryl Dow, whose brother had died searching for him, put it this way. *Hugh is my brother's living legacy.*

Jeff Batzer, the friend who gave up his dry pants on the mountain, went on to become an ordained minister.

Hugh married a woman named Patricia Ellis, and they had two daughters, Alex and Sage. The girls grew up with a father whose legs were metal, and they had simply assumed that Papa was different. When Alex was small, she set out with her mother to climb every mountain in New Hampshire over four thousand feet. Mount Washington is the highest of them. It was only after Alex was well into that quest that Hugh sat his daughters down and told them how he had lost his legs. They were horrified. *Did it hurt, Papa?* they asked him. *Were you cold?*

◆ ◆ ◆

In the mid-1980s, a climber named Jim Ewing became one of Hugh's climbing partners. Decades later, in 2014, Ewing shattered his left ankle in a climbing accident, and the leg had to come off below the knee.

Hugh had been working with a surgeon in Boston on a new way of amputating a leg. In an ordinary amputation, the muscles that work in pairs, one pulling the foot up and the other pulling it down, are simply cut. In the new procedure, the surgeons stitched the ends of each pair together inside the remaining limb, so that the muscles could keep telling the brain where the missing foot was in space. Ewing was the first person to have it. It is called the Ewing amputation now.

In 2024 Hugh's group published a study of seven people who had undergone the new surgery and were fitted with a powered ankle that took its commands directly from their own muscle signals. They walked about as fast as people with no amputation at all. They went up stairs, lifting the prosthetic toes to clear each step as a living foot would. The surgery gave them back less than a fifth of the sensation a whole leg provides, and still their bodies found their way to a natural gait. *I believe that in this century,* Hugh has said, *we will forever eliminate disability in this world.* And, more simply: *There's no such thing as a broken, disabled person.*

◆ ◆ ◆

Somewhere this evening, a man in his fifties is climbing the stairs of a train station at the end of a long day. Two years ago a truck ran a red light, and he woke up in a hospital without his right foot. He spent the first months afterward angry, at the driver and at himself and at the stairs in his own building.

Now, under his trouser leg, a small motor hums at each step, and the carbon foot lifts its toe over the edge of the stair because he thought, without thinking, to lift it. He is carrying a bag of groceries in one hand, and with the other he is texting his daughter that he will be home in twenty minutes. He does not know the names of the surgeon or the engineer who made the ankle he is standing on, or the name of a twenty-eight-year-old climbing guide who once went up a mountain in January to look for two boys he had never met. The doors of his train

are open. He steps in, catches the rail, and the train pulls out into the dark.

> Side note: In Wolfeboro, New Hampshire, the town next to Albert Dow's hometown of Tuftonboro, people started a triathlon in his memory and called it the Granite Man. Its proceeds created the Albert Dow III Scholarship, given to a graduate of Kingswood Regional High School who shares his commitment to helping others. Over the years it has given away about a quarter of a million dollars to young people Albert never met. The fund now sustains itself, so the race's money goes to the town's community programs instead.

Question: Is there a hardship or a regret in your own life that you could carry, as Hugh carried Albert's name, as a reason to do something good for someone else?

Question: What are three ways that what is happening could be kind?

Action: What would be the kindest thing for your body right now: a stretch, a rapid aerobic run, or a deep breath and a slow exhale with a wish for something beautiful, a blessing? Do that now.

Chapter Twenty-One

Squeeze My Hands

———

Midnight

"*If I could choose one gift for my leprosy patients it would be the gift of pain*." — Dr. Paul Brand, *Pain: The Gift Nobody Wants* (with Philip Yancey, 1993)

◆◆◆

The hills where Paul Brand grew up were called the Kolli Malai, and the people on the plains below had another name for them. They called them the mountains of death, because of the malaria that lived in the forests and came down at dusk with the mosquitoes. About twenty thousand people lived up there, in the south of India, and none of them had a doctor.

His parents went anyway. Jesse Brand had trained as a builder and taken a short course in medicine. Evelyn Brand had studied at a homeopathic hospital in London. Together they built a bungalow on the hillside, and by Paul's own account he was born in it, in July 1914. Other records place his birth elsewhere in the south, at Ootacamund, or simply in a remote district some distance from Mysore. The bungalow is

the place he remembered. His parents ran clinics and a school and took in children no one else wanted. During afternoon naps, the boy lay listening to rats and green snakes moving in the ceiling beams.

One day three men came up to the bungalow with a basket of fruit as a gift. Paul saw their hands. Years later he described them without softening anything: *These men had stiff hands covered with sores. Fingers were missing.* Their feet were stumpy and misshapen. The children were kept inside while their father went out to treat the men, and he wore gloves to do it. When the visitors had gone, the gloves were burned, and so was the basket of fruit. In Brand's memory it was his mother who lit the fire; another account says his father did. What stayed with the boy was the smoke, and the fear behind it. He decided, as a child, that whatever else he did with his life, *Medicine was not for me.*

◆◆◆

In 1923, when he was nine, Paul and his little sister, Connie, were sent to England for school. It was the custom for missionary children, and it meant that the two of them did not see their parents again for six years.

Letters went back and forth by sea mail, weeks behind events. In the summer of 1929, when Paul was about fifteen, a telegram arrived. His father had died of blackwater fever, a deadly turn of malaria, after two days of illness. He was forty-four. The telegram read: *Break news gently to the children.* It

ended, *The Lord reigneth.* For weeks afterward, letters in his father's handwriting kept coming, written before the fever, still crossing the ocean.

Evelyn Brand came back to England for a year, and her son hardly recognized her. He remembered *a hunched-over figure with hair prematurely gray and the posture of a woman in her eighties.* Then she did something hard. She went back to the Kolli Hills alone. She rode her dead husband's horse along the mountain trails, and she kept working there for decades. She died a few weeks short of her ninety-sixth birthday and was buried beside Jesse, a little way down the slope from the bungalow. Her stone reads *Mother of the Hills.*

◆ ◆ ◆

Paul did not go to medical school. He was, by his own admission, a poor student, and he spent about five years in the building trades, learning carpentry, masonry and stonework, meaning to help with his parents' work. He took a course in tropical medicine at Livingstone College to prepare for mission work. During that training he stood in the emergency room of a charity hospital while a young woman, nearly dead from blood loss, was brought back by a transfusion. The boy who had sworn off medicine entered University College Hospital in London in 1937.

At medical school he met Margaret Berry, a fellow student who beat him to first place in the first term's examinations. They married in June 1943. Brand

trained as a surgeon during the Blitz, when the wards filled with bomb casualties.

In 1946, Dr. Robert Cochrane, a dermatologist and one of the world's leading authorities on leprosy, invited the Brands to the Christian Medical College in Vellore, in the south of India. Paul would teach surgery. Margaret, who had chosen ophthalmology, would work on eyes. They went. Paul Brand was thirty-two, and he was going back to the country of the three men and the burning basket.

◆◆◆

Early in 1947, Cochrane took him to the Lady Willingdon Leprosy Sanatorium at Chingleput, where Cochrane was the superintendent. Brand walked through the settlement and looked at hands. Sulfone drugs could now halt the disease, but they could not give back what it had already taken, and what it had taken was everywhere: fingers curled into claws that could not open, fingers gone to stumps, hands that were no longer quite hands. People with leprosy were outcasts. They could be cured, in the medical sense, and still be thrown out of their villages for the rest of their lives because of the way their hands and feet looked.

Brand noticed something that the textbooks did not explain. A man was struggling with the strap of his sandal, working the leather free of the buckle with the side of his thumb and his palm because his fingers would not do it. Brand bent down to help. Then he took the man's hands, pried open the stiff, curled fingers, and said in Tamil, *Squeeze my hands.*

The man squeezed. The grip was so strong that it hurt, and the man's long fingernails dug into the surgeon's hand.

It was a small pain, and it changed the course of his life. A paralyzed hand cannot grip like that. The muscles in this hand were alive. Something else was wrong. At that time, almost everyone, including most doctors, believed that leprosy made the flesh itself rot, that fingers and toes simply fell away as the disease ate them. Brand stood in the settlement with his hand stinging and began to doubt it.

Cochrane had challenged him to find out what could be done for the disabilities of leprosy, and Brand took the challenge literally. He went to the medical literature for help and found almost nothing on the hands and feet of people with leprosy. So he started from the beginning, with a question a carpenter might ask. If the muscles were alive, what was destroying the fingers?

◆◆◆

The answer came slowly, over years, out of watching. Patients walked for miles on feet with open wounds and did not limp. Some of them put their hands into live coals to move a cooking pot and did not flinch. Leprosy attacks the nerves, and where the nerves die, feeling dies with them. Brand began to suspect that the disease did not destroy the hands at all. The hands were being destroyed by ordinary life, by a thousand small injuries that a person with feeling would never allow to happen, because pain would stop them first.

To test it, he and his team turned the young patients into detectives. Every day, the boys inspected their own numb hands and feet. Every new mark had to be accounted for. Where did this blister come from? This cut? This swelling? The answers piled up. A splinter of wood, driven in and never felt. A burn from a cooking stove. Blisters across the knuckles that turned out to come from the hot glass of a lantern, touched every evening while the patient turned the valve knob to adjust the flame. The team added an extension to each knob, and the blisters stopped.

Some of the answers came in the dark. A patient would go to sleep with ten fingers and wake with a raw wound where a fingertip had been, and no memory of anything. In the night, a rat had come and gnawed it, and the sleeper had felt nothing at all. The remedy, when it came, was almost tender in its plainness: the hospital began to send a kitten home with each rehabilitated patient.

Feet were worse, because feet carry the whole weight of a life. Tight shoes rubbed the same place hour after hour, and the skin broke, and the patient kept walking. Brand began designing shoes and padded footwear that spread the pressure, and he taught his patients to inspect their feet every day.

Once the patients learned to treat every injury at once, the new deformities largely stopped. It took Brand years to gather the evidence, and longer to persuade the world, but the conclusion held. The old fear of rotting flesh, the fear that had made his father pull on gloves and his mother burn a basket

of fruit, was wrong. Leprosy took away pain, and the loss of pain did the rest.

◆ ◆ ◆

If the problem was mechanical, Brand reasoned, some of the damage might be undone mechanically. He had spent five years learning how weight and force move through wood and stone. Now he studied how they move through tendons.

One of his first patients was a young man named Krishnamurthy, who had every sorrow the disease could give: hands clawed shut and ulcers on the soles of his feet from walking on twisted bones. Brand operated on two fingers at a time, borrowing techniques from the American hand surgeon Sterling Bunnell, then on the thumb, and after each operation came weeks of physiotherapy. Some of the early procedures he tried failed when they were repeated on other patients. This one held. The claw opened and closed. A biography of Brand describes the result as a claw that *turned into a human hand.* After a year, Krishnamurthy walked out of the hospital. He had listened to the Christians around him, and he was baptized with a new name, John.

Brand went on to develop the tendon transfer that surgeons still call the Brand operation, rerouting a working muscle from the forearm to do the job of a dead one. In 1950 he and his colleagues opened the New Life Centre in Vellore, built like a small village rather than a ward, where patients could live and recover without being treated as untouchable. By 1959, surgeons at Vellore and the nearby center at

Karigiri had performed about five thousand reconstructions of hands and feet. Brand had done roughly half of them himself. In 1960 he received the Lasker Award for his leadership in rehabilitation.

Restored hands raised a hard question. A man who could hold a tool again still had a face, a name and a history that his village knew. The surgery gave him back his fingers. It did not automatically give him back his place. That was why the New Life Centre mattered, and why Brand kept saying that the goal of all the cutting and stitching was a person who could earn a living, keep his dignity and go home.

◆ ◆ ◆

In 1953, Brand was in New York at the end of a study tour. He had a fever and nausea but gave the speech he had come to give anyway, at the American Leprosy Mission. On the subway ride back to his cheap student hostel, he fainted and woke up on the floor of the swaying car. He made it to his room and was too weak to call a doctor. He had come to America to talk about people whom the world left alone, and now he was one of them, a stranger with a fever in a rented room. For six days a bellman brought him orange juice, milk and aspirin, until Dr. Eugene Kellersberger of the American Leprosy Mission tracked him down by working through the hotels in the Yellow Pages.

He recovered enough to sail home, took the train to London, and arrived at his aunt's house worn out.

That night, as he took off his shoes, he found that half of one foot had no feeling at all.

He took a ballpoint pen and pressed it into his heel. Nothing. He found a sewing needle and pushed it in. Nothing. He had spent six years handling the hands and feet of people with leprosy, and he knew exactly what this meant. *A dread fear worse than any nausea seized my stomach*, he wrote later. When his aunt knocked to ask if he was all right, he told her he was fine, only tired. He noticed, even then, that he was doing what his own patients did: hiding it.

He lay on the bed fully clothed through the night, in despair. In the morning he got up, took the needle again, and began to map the numb patch. He jabbed his heel. A sharp, bright pain shot up his leg.

He sat there in the London morning feeling it. The long, cramped train ride had pressed on the main branch of his sciatic nerve and cut off its blood supply for a time, and overnight the nerve had come back. He did not have leprosy. He had a sore heel. *Thank God for pain!* he prayed, and afterward he said it was a prayer he repeated, in one form or another, hundreds of times for the rest of his life. He returned to India with a new understanding of what his patients would give to feel a pinprick.

◆ ◆ ◆

In 1966 the United States Public Health Service asked the Brands to come to Carville, Louisiana, to the National Hansen's Disease Center, the only leprosy hospital on American soil. Paul became chief of rehabilitation. He set up a laboratory to study

hands and feet without feeling, and he stayed for twenty years.

At Carville he met people for whom painlessness was not a disease that could be halted but the way they had been born. A mother brought in a four-year-old girl he called Tanya, who had a rare inherited condition: she could feel pressure and temperature, but nothing hurt her. Her left ankle was fully dislocated. Ulcers on the soles of both feet went down to the bone, and she watched calmly while he examined them. At about eighteen months she had bitten off the tip of her own finger and painted with the blood on the sheets of her playpen. Her father had left the family, saying they had *begotten a monster.* Seven years later her mother called Brand from St. Louis. Tanya was eleven, living in an institution. Both legs had been amputated. She had lost most of her fingers. Her tongue was scarred from being chewed.

Brand never forgot her. When people asked him why anyone would call pain a gift, he could tell them what a life looked like without it.

His work at Carville also reached far beyond leprosy. Two doctors in Houston had read about bone changes in the feet of people with diabetes, and they wrote to Brand because the X-rays looked like the ones he knew. In Texas they put up a diabetic foot; he matched it with a leprosy foot. Nearly every time, the damage was the same. Speaking to a gathering of diabetes specialists, he told them that most of the foot injuries they saw were preventable. Decades later, by Yancey's count,

Americans with diabetes were still undergoing about a hundred thousand amputations a year, roughly half of all the amputations in the country, and a person with diabetes over sixty-five had nearly a one-in-ten chance of losing a foot. Diabetes, like leprosy, can kill the nerves of the feet. The ulcers that led to amputation came from walking, unfeeling, on small wounds.

One listener was skeptical. Dr. John Davidson ran the diabetes clinic at Grady, a charity hospital in Atlanta that saw more than ten thousand patients with diabetes a year. Back home, he made a new rule: at every visit, shoes and socks came off, and a podiatrist looked at every foot. A few months later he reported what he had found. *I discovered that 150 of our patients had amputations last year*, he said. Most of them the clinic had never known about. The patients felt no pain, so they did not mention the sores, and they went to surgeons only when it was too late, and then came back to the clinic on artificial legs and said nothing. Once the clinic started looking at feet, it cut its amputation rate in half. Brand observed that in America it was easier to get a good artificial leg than a good pair of shoes.

C. Everett Koop, the former Surgeon General, later told Philip Yancey that Brand's work could prevent *some 50,000 amputations per year* in the United States alone.

◆◆◆

Brand never pretended pain was easy. He called the existence of pain the most problematic aspect of creation. He also believed, after a lifetime among people who could not feel it, that *God designed the human body so that it is able to survive because of pain.* He had seen what happened to a body that could not hear the warning.

In the spring of 2003, Paul Brand had a mild stroke. Three weeks later, on June 19, he was carrying a box of books down the stairs of his home when he lost his footing and fell backward, gashing the back of his head. Surgeons removed a blood clot from his brain, and he never woke up. On July 8, 2003, nine days before his eighty-ninth birthday, he died in Seattle.

◆◆◆

The work did not end with him. The federal Hansen's disease program, the one Carville had housed, built his lessons into a five-step plan called Lower Extremity Amputation Prevention. It is meant for anyone who has lost protective feeling in the feet, from leprosy or diabetes or any other cause. The first step is a screening done with a single nylon filament, pressed against the sole until it bends at ten grams of force. If a person cannot feel it, the foot is at risk. Everything after that is Brand's detective game in plain clothes: look at your feet every day, report every wound, never walk barefoot, even at home, buy shoes with half an inch of room past the longest toe.

Somewhere tonight, in a small apartment, a man with diabetes is sitting on the edge of his bed with his reading glasses on and a hand mirror held low, turning his foot to see the sole. He cannot feel the floor very well anymore. He is looking for a blister he cannot feel, the way a boy at Vellore once looked at his hands, and the way a surgeon once sat in his aunt's house in London, holding a sewing needle, waiting to be hurt.

> Side note: Margaret Brand found that leprosy could blind people through the same silence. When the nerves of the face die, the eye stops blinking, the cornea dries out, and small injuries go unfelt until sight is gone. She developed an operation that borrowed a muscle used for chewing, the temporalis, and connected it to the eyelid, so that patients could close their eyes by clenching their jaws. A visiting doctor who ate lunch with her patients remembered looking around the table and seeing all of them winking and squinting as they chewed.

Question: When has a pain in your body or your life turned out to be warning you about something you needed to know?

Question: What are three ways that what is happening could be kind?

Action: Put a hand on your heart. Say to yourself the words you would say to a friend who was hurting the way you are now. Breathe there for one minute.

Chapter Twenty-Two

The Kitchen Table

———

Charcoal

"*Two are better than one … For if they fall, the one will lift up his fellow: but woe to him that is alone when he falleth; for he hath not another to help him up.*" — Ecclesiastes 4:9–10

◆◆◆

In the summer of 1934, in the village of Manchester, Vermont, a man named Ebby Thacher was painting his family's big old summer house, and the pigeons kept fouling the fresh paint.

He was thirty-eight, from a prominent Albany family, and by then a hopeless drunk. That summer, according to the histories that followed, he got out a shotgun and fired at the pigeons on the roof, and alarmed the whole neighborhood. He had already been fined twice. A third offense meant six months in the state prison at Windsor or commitment to the asylum at Brattleboro.

Two old drinking companions of his had, by then, stopped drinking. Cebra Graves and Shep Cornell had joined a religious movement called the Oxford Group, whose members confessed their faults to one

another and tried to change their lives by carrying their experience to someone else. That summer they were staying in nearby Bennington with a wealthy man named Rowland Hazard.

Rowland Hazard had been a hopeless drunk too.

Some years earlier, by the account that would later become famous, Hazard had gone to Zurich, as a last resort, to be treated by the great Swiss psychiatrist Carl Jung. When Hazard relapsed and went back, Jung told him the truth: that he had the mind of a chronic alcoholic, that further medical or psychiatric treatment was hopeless, and that the only hope he knew of was what he called a vital spiritual experience, which was rare. Hazard had come home, joined the Oxford Group, and stopped drinking.

Now Hazard, Graves, and Cornell heard that Ebby Thacher was going to be locked away. They went to the judge. The judge was Cebra Graves's father, Collins Graves. They asked him to release Ebby into their custody. He did.

Rowland Hazard took Ebby to New York, where he dried out at a rescue mission run by an Episcopal church on Twenty-Third Street, and stayed sober.

◆◆◆

Across the river, in Brooklyn Heights, in a house at 182 Clinton Street, an old school friend of Ebby's was drinking himself to death.

His name was Bill Wilson. In the 1920s he had been a successful stock speculator, and the crash of 1929

had wiped him out. His wife, Lois, took a job at Macy's department store for nineteen dollars a week and kept them alive. She came home exhausted, Bill wrote later, to find him drunk.

They were living in a room in the house Lois had grown up in, her father's house. Her mother had died there of cancer at Christmas 1930, and Bill had been too drunk to go to the funeral.

In the family Bible, Bill had written promises. In January 1929: *To tell you once more that I am finished with it. I love you.* In September 1930: *Finally and for a lifetime, thank God for your love.* After that he stopped writing promises.

By the autumn of 1934 he had been in and out of a Manhattan hospital for alcoholics three times. The physician there, William Silkworth, had told Lois that her husband would probably have to be locked up. He was fifty thousand dollars in debt. He was thirty-nine.

In late November the telephone rang at 182 Clinton Street. It was Ebby. He wanted to come by. Lois invited him to dinner.

◆ ◆ ◆

Bill told the story many times for the rest of his life, and he wrote it down in the first chapter of a book he would publish in 1939. He was sitting in the kitchen, drinking. *The cheery voice of an old school friend asked if he might come over. He was sober.*

Bill had heard Ebby had been committed for alcoholic insanity. He was glad to see him. He would be able to drink openly with his old friend.

The door opened, Bill wrote, *and he stood there, fresh-skinned and glowing. There was something about his eyes.*

Bill pushed a drink across the table. Ebby would not take it.

Come, what's all this about? Bill asked him.

I've got religion, Ebby said.

Bill was aghast. Last summer, he thought, an alcoholic crackpot. Now, apparently, a little cracked about religion. But Ebby did not preach. In a matter-of-fact way, he told Bill how two men had appeared in court and persuaded the judge to suspend his commitment, how they had told him about the Oxford Group, how he had tried what they suggested, and how he had not had a drink since. When Bill balked at the word *God*, Ebby made a suggestion that Bill never forgot. Why not, he asked, choose your own conception of God?

Then Ebby went home, and Bill kept drinking. But in no waking moment afterward, he wrote, could he get that man and his message out of his head.

◆◆◆

Ebby kept coming back. On the seventh of December Bill, drunk, wandered into the rescue mission on Twenty-Third Street with a drinking companion and began interrupting the service. Just

as he was about to be thrown out, Ebby arrived and sat him down to a plate of beans.

On the eleventh of December, Bill bought four bottles of beer on his way to the hospital and drank them. They were the last drinks of his life.

Three days later, in a bed at the hospital, after Ebby had come to visit, Bill hit bottom. He cried out, as he told it later, that if there was a God, let Him show Himself. The room filled with white light. He felt, he wrote, *lifted up, as though the great clean wind of a mountain top blew through and through.* He had been given belladonna as part of the hospital's treatment, and skeptics have always pointed to that. Dr. Silkworth, when Bill told him, listened carefully and said: *Something has happened to you I don't understand. But you had better hang on to it.*

The next day Ebby brought him a copy of William James's *The Varieties of Religious Experience*. Bill read it in the hospital. He left on the eighteenth of December and never drank again.

◆◆◆

He did not stay sober by keeping still. He went looking for other drunks, and preached to them about his white light, and none of them got sober. Dr. Silkworth told him to stop preaching and start with the medical facts: the craving, the obsession, the way the body and the mind conspired. Bill kept at it.

In the spring of 1935, a business deal took him to Akron, Ohio, and fell through. On a Saturday in May he found himself alone in the lobby of the Mayflower

Hotel, sober five months, almost broke, pacing. Music and chatter drifted out of the hotel bar. He thought about going in and sitting with a ginger ale.

At the other end of the lobby, there was a glass-covered directory of local churches.

He understood, standing there, that he needed to find another alcoholic to talk to, or he was going to drink. He went to the directory, picked a name, and spent a nickel on a phone call to a minister. The minister gave him other names. One of them led him to a woman named Henrietta Seiberling, who lived in the gatehouse of a great estate. She was a member of the Oxford Group. She had been praying for a friend of hers, a surgeon, who could not stop drinking.

When Bill called her, he introduced himself, as she later told her son, as a member of the Oxford Group and a rum hound from New York.

She took it as an answer to her prayers. She called the surgeon's wife.

The next day was Mother's Day. The surgeon, Dr. Robert Smith, was so hung over that he could barely stand, and he agreed to come to Henrietta's house only on the condition that he could leave after fifteen minutes. At five o'clock he and his wife, Anne, arrived at the gatehouse. Bill and Dr. Bob went into the library.

They talked until after eleven o'clock at night.

◆◆◆

Bill stayed in Akron that summer, living in the Smiths' house at Anne's invitation. In June, Dr. Bob went off to a medical convention in Atlantic City and came back drunk. He had an operation to perform. On the morning of the surgery, so the story is told, Bill handed him a bottle of beer to steady his hands. It was Dr. Bob's last drink.

Alcoholics Anonymous counts its beginning from that day, the tenth of June 1935: a man handing another man a beer so his hands would stop shaking.

Later that month, Bill and Dr. Bob sat by a hospital bed in Akron with a lawyer named Bill Dotson. He became the third. One drunk sitting with another. That was the whole method.

◆◆◆

Ebby Thacher stayed sober for two years and seven months. Then, in 1937, he drank.

For most of the next thirty years he was in and out of drinking, jails, and hospitals. In 1961, the day after the woman he loved died, he drank again.

Bill Wilson never stopped calling him his sponsor. He wrote to him once: *No day passes that I do not remember that you brought me the message that saved me.* In 1964, Bill arranged for Ebby to live on a small rest farm in upstate New York. Ebby never drank there.

He died sober on the twenty-first of March 1966, at sixty-nine. Bill and Lois flew back from Mexico for the funeral in Albany. About twelve people came.

Lois Wilson, who had kept the house going on her Macy's wages, who had picked up the phone and invited Ebby to dinner, found that once Bill was sober, strangers could help him in a way she never had, and she resented it. Out of that resentment, and her honesty about it, came something new: in 1951 she and a friend named Anne Bingham founded Al-Anon, for the families of alcoholics.

Bill Wilson himself was not a saint. He suffered for years from crushing depression. He smoked until emphysema put him on oxygen, and kept smoking. One biographer reports a long affair, which some historians doubt. In his last weeks, sick and confused, he asked his nurses for whiskey four times. They said no. He died in January 1971, thirty-six years sober.

In January 1961, ten years before his death, Bill had written to Carl Jung, to tell him that a sentence he had spoken to a hopeless patient in Zurich decades earlier had become the first link in a chain that now reached hundreds of thousands of people. Jung wrote back a few months before he died. The craving for alcohol, he wrote, was the equivalent, on a low level, of the spiritual thirst of our being for wholeness. *You see*, he wrote, "*alcohol*" *in Latin is* spiritus, *and you use the same word for the highest religious experience as well as for the most depraving poison.*

◆ ◆ ◆

Tonight, in a church basement somewhere, the coffee is on. Folding chairs are set out in a circle. A

woman who has been sober for one year is about to be handed a small bronze coin, and she is trying not to cry. A man who came in drunk last week is sitting at the back, with his coat still on. Somebody who has been coming for twenty years will walk over to him afterward and sit down next to him, the way Ebby sat at Bill's kitchen table, and say almost nothing, and give him a phone number.

Alcoholics Anonymous now has more than a hundred thousand groups and close to two million members around the world. Bill called Ebby his sponsor for the rest of his life, and the word is still used for the person who walks beside you in recovery.

Most of the people in those rooms tonight have never heard of Ebby Thacher. They do not know that the chain of their recovery runs back through a judge in Vermont who was somebody's father, a shotgun and some pigeons, a psychiatrist in Zurich who told a rich man the truth, a plate of beans in a mission, a nickel in a hotel lobby, and a drink pushed across a kitchen table and pushed back.

> Side note: In August 1939, four years after Bill Wilson and Dr. Bob first met, the nun in charge of admissions at St. Thomas Hospital in Akron quietly took in an alcoholic patient. The hospital did not admit drunks, so Dr. Bob wrote the diagnosis as acute gastritis. Her name was Sister Ignatia Gavin, and she had been born in the village of Shanvalley, in County Mayo, Ireland. Over the next quarter century she helped thousands more. As each one left the hospital, she gave him a small Sacred Heart medallion. If he ever decided to drink again,

she told him, he was to bring the medallion back to her first.

Question: Who in your life is sitting at a kitchen table right now, waiting for someone who has been where they are to knock on the door?

Question: What are three ways that what is happening could be kind?

Action: Call someone you have been meaning to reach, with your voice, not a text. Ask how they really are, and listen.

Chapter Twenty-Three

A Sad Sweet Feeling

———

Gray

"*You are sure to be happy again.*" — Abraham Lincoln, letter to Fanny McCullough, December 23, 1862

◆◆◆

William McCullough had one arm and one good eye, and he wanted to go to war.

He had lost the arm to a threshing machine and the sight of the eye to a gun accident. He was forty-eight years old when the fighting began in 1861. In Bloomington, Illinois, he was one of the most respected men in McLean County. As clerk of the circuit court he worked alongside the lawyers who rode into town on the Eighth Judicial Circuit. One of those lawyers was a tall man from Springfield named Abraham Lincoln. When the circuit brought Lincoln to Bloomington, he sometimes stayed with the McCulloughs, and McCullough backed him all the way to the White House.

The army did not want a one-armed clerk near fifty. McCullough asked anyway, and it appears the President intervened. The Fourth Illinois Cavalry

elected him its lieutenant colonel. The men who rode with him said he was a fine horseman.

On December 5, 1862, near Coffeeville, Mississippi, the regiment was pulling back in the failing light when Confederate troops caught them in an ambush. McCullough was called on to surrender. By the accounts that reached home, he refused, and he was killed there in the dusk. Six days later his body came back through the lines under a flag of truce. He was buried in Bloomington on December 14, with full military honors.

◆ ◆ ◆

He left a wife and daughters. One of them was Mary Frances, whom everyone called Fanny. She was twenty-two.

Her older sister, Nannie, came to tell her, with two family friends, Leonard and Laura Swett. Leonard Swett was a lawyer who had ridden the circuit with Lincoln for years. Fanny was so agitated and so beyond comfort that Swett sent for a doctor. Then she went into her room and locked the door.

On December 13, Laura Swett wrote to another old friend of the family, David Davis, who had once judged the circuit Lincoln rode and now sat on the Supreme Court. Fanny, Laura Swett reported, *neither ate or slept.*

Davis had already heard of McCullough's death from Fanny's brother-in-law, William Orme, and had told the President. Lincoln, Davis wrote, felt the loss keenly, and would write to Fanny. Then Davis added a worry that says a good deal about that winter in

Washington. With everything the government was carrying, he warned, the matter might slip from the President's mind unless someone kept reminding him. So Davis kept reminding him.

◆ ◆ ◆

It was the worst December of Lincoln's presidency.

On December 13, the same day Laura Swett sat down to write about Fanny, the Army of the Potomac had thrown itself against the Confederate lines at Fredericksburg, Virginia. Wave after wave of Union soldiers crossed open ground toward a stone wall and were cut down. By the time the battle was over, more than twelve thousand of them were dead, wounded or missing. In the days that followed, the Republican senators turned on the cabinet, two cabinet secretaries offered their resignations, and the government nearly came apart. Ahead of him was the Emancipation Proclamation, which he had promised in September to sign on the first day of the new year.

And there was another grief in the house. Ten months earlier, in February, his eleven-year-old son Willie had died upstairs in the White House, of what the doctors called bilious fever and what was almost certainly typhoid from the water. His wife, Mary, had not recovered. He was fifty-three years old.

On December 23, two days before Christmas, Lincoln took a sheet of paper headed *Executive Mansion* and wrote to a young woman in Illinois who had locked herself in her room.

Dear Fanny, he began. He told her that it was with deep grief that he had learned of the death of *your kind and brave Father*, and that he had heard how hard it was falling on her young heart. Then he wrote the sentences that people still quote:

In this sad world of ours, sorrow comes to all; and, to the young, it comes with bitterest agony, because it takes them unawares. The older have learned to ever expect it.

He did not tell her to stop crying. He told her that he wanted to ease what she was going through, and that full relief could come only with time. Then he spoke to her the way a person speaks to someone who cannot see past the next hour. *You can not now realize that you will ever feel better. Is not this so? And yet it is a mistake. You are sure to be happy again.*

It is the only question in the letter. *Is not this so?* He stopped, in the middle of a page written by the most burdened man in the country, to ask a twenty-two-year-old how it felt from where she sat, and he answered for her, gently, because he already knew.

He asked her to trust him on this, and he gave his reason. *I have had experience enough to know what I say.* If she could only believe it, he said, she would feel better at once.

The letter ended with a promise about memory. The thought of her father, which was now an agony, would become in time *a sad sweet feeling in your heart, of a purer and holier sort than you have known before.* He asked her to give his kind regards

to her mother. He signed it *Your sincere friend, A. Lincoln.*

It was barely more than a dozen sentences long. It contained no advice about keeping busy, no reminder that her father had died for a great cause, nothing about God's plan. It said three things: that grief this sharp falls hardest on the young, that it would not last in this form forever, and that the man writing it knew this from the inside. Then it stopped.

◆◆◆

He did not explain what experience he meant. He rarely did. But it went back a long way.

In the autumn of 1818, in the woods of southern Indiana, a sickness went through the settlement at Little Pigeon Creek. Neighbors died of it, and then Nancy Hanks Lincoln died of it, on October 5, at the age of thirty-four. Most accounts say it was milk sickness, which came from cows that had grazed on white snakeroot; some said it was a quick consumption. Her husband, Thomas, built the coffin, and their nine-year-old son, Abraham, whittled the wooden pegs that held the planks together. For more than a year afterward, his sister Sarah, who was eleven, kept house and looked after him. Nancy's grave had no proper headstone for sixty years.

Sarah grew up and married a neighbor, Aaron Grigsby, in the summer of 1826. On January 20, 1828, she died giving birth. She was not quite twenty-one. People who knew Abraham as a teenager remembered how badly her death broke

him. As a grown man he hardly spoke of his mother or his sister at all.

In New Salem, Illinois, there was a young woman named Ann Rutledge. She had been engaged to a merchant named John McNamar, who went back east promising to return and marry her. His letters grew formal, and then they stopped. She died on August 25, 1835, at twenty-two, most likely of typhoid. What she was to Lincoln is one of the long arguments of American history. The story of a romance was first made public by his law partner, William Herndon, in a lecture in 1866, built from interviews with old New Salem neighbors. Some historians have treated it as legend, and some, after weighing the same testimony, have concluded that he loved her and was crushed by her death. One old friend, Isaac Cogdal, said that years later he asked Lincoln directly, and that Lincoln told him he had *loved the woman dearly and soundly.* What is not much in dispute is that after that summer Lincoln sank into a melancholy so heavy that it lasted for months.

◆◆◆

The worst of it came in the winter of 1841.

He was thirty-one, a rising lawyer and legislator in Springfield, and he was engaged to Mary Todd of Kentucky. On the first day of the new year the engagement ended, and Lincoln, who blamed himself, came apart. Years later he still called it *that fatal first of January.* Friends feared he would take his own life. On January 23 he wrote to his law

partner John T. Stuart, who was in Congress: *I am now the most miserable man living. If what I feel were equally distributed to the whole human family, there would not be one cheerful face on the earth.*

The friend who stood closest to him through it was Joshua Speed. When Lincoln arrived in Springfield in 1837, Speed had offered to share his room above his general store, and they shared it for nearly four years. That winter Speed went home to Kentucky, and in the summer of 1841 Lincoln followed him to the Speed family place near Louisville. He stayed for three weeks or a month, by different accounts. He came home recovered.

The help ran both ways. Speed was, as Lincoln once put it, *naturally of a nervous temperament*, and in the following months, as Speed courted a young woman named Fanny Henning and was seized by doubts of his own, it was Lincoln who wrote to steady him. Speed married her in February 1842. In November of that year, Abraham Lincoln married Mary Todd.

He never stopped being a melancholy man. But he had learned some things about living with it. He worked. He told stories. He turned, again and again, to funny books and comic writers, and he kept them close.

◆◆◆

They had four sons. The second, Edward, called Eddie, was born in March 1846. In December 1849 he fell sick, and he stayed sick for fifty-two days. He died on the morning of February 1, 1850, a few

weeks short of his fourth birthday. Three weeks later, writing to his stepbrother, Lincoln said only a little about it, and then four plain words: *We miss him very much.*

Willie was born that December. He was ten when the family moved into the White House in 1861, and the war came into the family almost at once. In May 1861 Elmer Ellsworth, a young officer who had studied law in Lincoln's Springfield office, was shot dead in Alexandria, Virginia, after pulling down a Confederate flag. The next day Lincoln wrote to Ellsworth's parents. *In the untimely loss of your noble son*, he wrote, *our affliction here, is scarcely less than your own.* He ended with a prayer: *May God give you that consolation which is beyond all earthly power.* Of the young man himself he wrote something a parent would want to read: *What was conclusive of his good heart, he never forgot his parents.* One of Lincoln's secretaries said the President grieved for Ellsworth as he would have for a son.

In February 1862, Willie and his little brother Tad both fell ill. A large reception had been planned at the White House, and Mary thought of calling it off. Lincoln suggested asking the doctor first, and the doctor said Willie was improving. So the reception went ahead. Some guests wanted dancing, and Lincoln said no. Downstairs the Marine Band played, and upstairs, where the boy lay hot with fever, the music came through the walls as *soft, subdued murmurs.* All evening, Mary kept leaving her guests

and climbing the stairs to sit by his bed and hold his hand.

Tad grew stronger. Willie did not. He died on February 20, in the bedroom known as the Prince of Wales Room.

The woman who washed and dressed his body was Elizabeth Keckley, Mary Lincoln's dressmaker. She had been born enslaved, had bought her own freedom and her son's, and the summer before, her only son had been killed fighting for the Union in Missouri. *I assisted in washing him and dressing him*, she wrote later. When her own boy had been killed, it was Mary Lincoln who had written to her, a letter Keckley remembered as *full of golden words of comfort.* Now the comfort ran the other way.

She watched the President stand over the boy for a long time. Then he spoke. *My poor boy, he was too good for this earth. God has called him home. I know that he is much better off in heaven, but then we loved him so. It is hard, hard to have him die! He buried his head in his hands*, she wrote, *and his tall frame was convulsed with emotion.* She said she never forgot the sight of a man so overcome.

Mary Lincoln could not go to the funeral. She stayed in bed for three weeks. She never again entered the room where Willie died. Keckley remembered a day when Mary's grief was at its worst and Lincoln led her to the window, pointed to the large white asylum on the hill, and begged her to try to control her grief, or it would drive her mad. It was a husband standing at a window with a wife he could not reach.

After the funeral, by one account, he shut himself in a room alone and wept.

◆ ◆ ◆

Fanny McCullough's sorrow did not end with the letter. According to one account of the family, a young man who had been courting her, Joseph Orme, a brother of her sister's husband, died on the last day of 1862, only days after Lincoln's letter arrived. Joseph Orme was a soldier, and a family history says he was killed by fire from his own side.

Her sister's grief came more slowly. Nannie's husband, William Orme, came back from Vicksburg and New Orleans with his health broken. He came home to die, and he wanted to die there, he said, with her *sweet words of hope and consolation* in his ear. She was thirty-two.

The war went on for more than two years after that Christmas. By the time it ended, somewhere between 620,000 and 750,000 soldiers were dead, and for each of them there was a house like the McCulloughs', a room with a locked door, a girl who neither ate nor slept. Most of those families learned the news the ordinary way, from a telegram, a letter from an officer, or a name printed in a newspaper's list of the dead, read standing up at a doorway.

Letters of condolence became part of the work of the presidency, and not all of them were his alone. In November 1864 a letter went out over his signature to Lydia Bixby, a widow in Boston who was reported to have lost five sons in the war. It spoke of *the solemn pride that must be yours to*

have laid so costly a sacrifice upon the altar of freedom. It was printed in the Boston papers the day she received it. Later research found that two of her sons had been killed, one had deserted and survived, one had been captured and lived, and the fate of the fifth is still unclear. Scholars still argue over whether Lincoln wrote it or his young secretary John Hay did. The original has never been found. No such question hangs over the letter to Fanny. It was in his own hand, written to one young woman in whose family's house he had slept, because a friend would not let him forget.

◆◆◆

He had signed the Emancipation Proclamation on New Year's Day of 1863, nine days after that letter, and he had kept sending men south. On the night of April 14, 1865, he was shot at Ford's Theatre, and he died the next morning at 7:22. Mary was not in the room. When his funeral train left Washington for Illinois, the small coffin of his son Willie went home with him. In Louisville, Joshua Speed organized a memorial service for the friend he had once shared a room with above a store.

For Mary Lincoln the losses kept coming. Tad died in 1871, at eighteen. She was buried, in 1882, in the tomb in Springfield with her husband and three of her sons, Eddie and Willie and Tad, who had been brought there to lie together.

Fanny lived. In time she married Frank Orme, another of the Orme brothers, and they moved to Washington, the city where her letter had been

written. She outlived the man who had written to her by more than half a century, long enough to see automobiles in the streets where his funeral procession had passed. She died on March 4, 1920, at about eighty years old, fifty-seven years after a man who knew grief from the inside had told her she would be happy again.

The letter was still hers when she died.

◆ ◆ ◆

Somewhere this evening, in an apartment kitchen, a young woman is standing at the counter with her coat still on, opening a stack of cards that came after her father's funeral. Most of them say the printed words. One of them is from an older neighbor, written by hand in blue ink, and she reads it twice, and then she sets it apart from the others and leans it against the sugar bowl where she will see it in the morning.

The neighbor who wrote it lost her husband nine years ago. She sat at her own table for a long time before she wrote anything at all, and then she did not write that she understood, or that he was in a better place. She wrote that the first year is the hardest, and that it does change, and that she would come by on Sunday with soup.

> Side note: Fanny McCullough kept Lincoln's letter for the rest of her life. After she died in 1920, it passed down through her family, and in the early 1950s, when scholars gathered every surviving word Lincoln had written into his *Collected Works*, the letter was still with a relative, Alice Orme Smith, in Fairfield,

> Connecticut. It later sold to a collector for sixty thousand dollars, a price one historian called the highest ever paid for a Lincoln letter. It had cost Lincoln a page and a little time, two days before Christmas, in the worst month of his presidency.

Question: Who has helped you through a loss by telling you, from their own experience, that you would be happy again, and who might need to hear that from you now?

Question: What are three ways that what is happening could be kind?

Action: Send a short message today to someone you haven't spoken to in a while, just to say you were

thinking of them. People almost always appreciate it more than we expect.

Chapter Twenty-Four

A Window

———

Violet

"*You matter because you are you, and you matter to the end of your life.*" — Cicely Saunders, The Management of Terminal Disease

◆ ◆ ◆

Ela Majer Tasma, whom people in London called David, was a waiter.

He was about forty years old in 1947. He had come from Warsaw, where his grandfather had been a rabbi, and he had left that world behind him long before he arrived in England. Most accounts say he escaped the Warsaw Ghetto; in her own recollection, given many years later, the woman who knew him best said only that he had got out of Warsaw before the uprising. Either way, the city he came from no longer existed in the form he had known it. He had no relatives in England. He had very few friends. He rented a room from a landlady, carried plates in a restaurant, and lived the kind of life that leaves almost no mark on the official record.

Then a doctor told him that the pain in his body was cancer, and that it could not be operated on.

He went on as an outpatient for a while, then went home to his room and waited to be called into hospital. He was, as the woman who sat with him would later put it, a man who felt he was just not an important person. He felt he had achieved little. He was forty, he was alone in a foreign city, and he was going to die there.

◆◆◆

The woman was Cicely Saunders, and in 1947 she was twenty-nine and not yet anything in particular.

The daughter of a prosperous surveyor, she had gone up to Oxford in 1938 to read politics, philosophy and economics. When the war came she left to train as a nurse at St Thomas's Hospital.

Her back would not let her. Early in her training she slipped a disc, and in 1944 she was invalided out. Late in life she said that the pain of bereavement had taught her far more than the pain in her back.

She went back to Oxford, took a wartime degree, and trained as a lady almoner, the job that would later be called medical social work. Along the way she became a Christian, with a faith that would stay with her for life. An almoner's first task was to work out what a hospital patient could afford to pay. The rest of the work was whatever the patient needed and nobody else had time for: a letter to a landlord, a word with a frightened relative, an hour at a bedside. She qualified in 1947. One of her first patients with cancer was the waiter from Warsaw.

◆ ◆ ◆

She met him in 1947, in the course of her almoner's work at St Thomas's, and she kept in touch with him after he went home. When he collapsed a few months later, it was his landlady who contacted her. Biographers place his last weeks on a surgical ward in a hospital at Archway, in north London; her own appointment diary records visits to him in January and February 1948, and the records do not agree on the hospital's name. The ward had fifty beds, and she remembered it as very busy. A man with no family and no visitors was easy to overlook on a ward like that.

She came anyway. Over the two months that he was dying she visited him about twenty-five times. A later account says she risked her job to keep going back. She kept a detailed diary of their meetings.

They talked. He was an agnostic, and she was a young woman who had recently become a committed Christian. She knew many of the Psalms by heart, and she said them to him at his bedside. One day he told her what he wanted from her. *I only want what is in your mind and in your heart*, he said.

She carried that sentence for the rest of her life. Long afterward, when she was a famous physician who ran a research hospital, she said that the whole of her work rested on it: everything that could be learned with the mind, offered with the friendship of the heart.

They talked, too, about what she wanted to build. She had seen enough of hospital wards to know

what they did to people who were dying. Medicine in those years was a profession of cure, and a patient who could not be cured was, in a quiet and unspoken way, a failure. In the hospitals, as she later put it, patients were *earning their morphine by having pain*. She and David talked about a different kind of place: something more like a home than a hospital, where a person at the end of life could be comfortable, and known, and not alone.

Their friendship was close, and it was fragile; he was very ill, and she was very young, and there was so little time. Somewhere in those weeks, they fell in love. It was brief, and both of them knew how it would end. Her biographers have called it a spiritual love affair. He quietly returned to the faith of his fathers before he died, though he never saw a rabbi.

◆ ◆ ◆

David Tasma died on 25 February 1948.

He had made her the executor of his small estate, and in his will he left her five hundred pounds. It was a substantial sum in 1948, and a great deal for a man who carried plates for a living. With it came a sentence. In her own telling, given in an interview in 1993, his words were: *I'll be a window in your home.* Other accounts of the same moment, including some written by those who worked with her, give it as *Let me be a window in your home* or *I will be a window in your home*. The meaning in every version is the same. He wanted to be part of the place they had talked about.

There was no home. There was no plan, no money beyond his, and no building for the window to be set into. Cicely Saunders was a twenty-nine-year-old social worker with a bad back.

She grieved him, and she also felt something she found hard to name. Decades later she said that when he died she had *an absolute assurance* that he was safe, and that she could let him go *in inner peace*.

When his coffin went to the Jewish cemetery, only two people followed it: Cicely, and the man who had employed him.

She kept the notes she had made about him. They are in her papers at King's College London to this day, along with the diary in which she wrote down the dates of her visits. There is also a photograph of him, taken around 1940.

◆ ◆ ◆

That same year she began spending her evenings as a volunteer nurse at St Luke's, a home for the dying poor in Bayswater.

What she saw there changed her. At St Luke's, the nurses gave their patients oral morphine on a regular schedule, every few hours, in doses balanced to each person's need. They did not wait for the patient to be in pain and then ask a doctor's permission. The dose came before the pain did. She saw that people who were dying could be clear-headed and comfortable at the same time, and that the old fear, that morphine given freely would leave patients stupefied or addicted, did not hold at the

bedside. She credited the nurses, not the doctors, with this. The nurses were with the patients all day, she said, and they simply wanted them comfortable.

She wanted to bring that to everyone, and she did not yet know how. In 1951 she was working as an almoner for a thoracic surgeon named Norman Barrett, and she told him about her hopes. His answer redirected her life. She should study medicine, he told her. *It's the doctors who desert the dying.* If she tried to change their care as a nurse or a social worker, he said, she would only be frustrated. There was so much more, he told her, to be learned about pain.

So at thirty-three, a woman who had studied politics and philosophy and had never taken a science course, she enrolled at St Thomas's Hospital Medical School and began with physics, biology and chemistry, alongside students more than ten years younger. She qualified in 1957. She was nearly forty.

◆◆◆

In October 1958 she took up a research fellowship that placed her at St Joseph's Hospice in Hackney, in the East End of London, a home for the dying run by the Irish Sisters of Charity. The sisters had no drug charts, no patients' notes, no ward reports. Pain relief was given on demand, which meant a patient had to be in pain to earn it.

She brought what she had learned at St Luke's. She introduced a regular schedule for pain medication, given by the clock so that the pain never had the

chance to build. She later said the effect was *like waving a wand over the house*. She introduced patients' notes. She tape-recorded hundreds of conversations with patients about what they were going through, and she studied the drugs carefully. She brought in diamorphine, the medical form of heroin, and compared it patiently with morphine, dose by dose, publishing what she found. She called herself, in that Catholic house, a *Protestant heretic*.

And she fell in love again.

Antoni Michniewicz was a patient at St Joseph's. Like David Tasma, he was Polish, and like David Tasma he was dying. The record about him is thinner than the record about David, and most of what is known comes from the few close friends she confided in. She loved him, and she stayed with him so that he would not die alone. He died in 1960. Within a year her father had died as well, in June 1961, and so had a patient called Mrs G whom she had known for seven years. She described what followed as *pathological grieving*.

Out of Antoni's death she took one conviction that she would teach for the rest of her life. She had watched him grow weaker and had seen something else grow stronger. *As the body becomes weaker*, she said, *so the spirit becomes stronger.*

◆◆◆

At St Joseph's she was gathering the pieces of an idea. In 1963 a patient named Mrs Hinson gave her the words for it. Asked to describe her pain, Mrs

Hinson said that it began in her back, *but now it seems that all of me is wrong*.

Cicely Saunders called this *total pain*. A dying person's pain was physical, but it was also fear, and loneliness, and worry about who would look after the children, and money, and the questions that come at three in the morning about whether a life has meant anything. Treat only the body, she argued, and you have treated a part of the pain. She began to say that the family, and not only the patient, was the unit of care. She wrote and lectured about total pain for the rest of her working life, and the idea became one of the foundations on which palliative care was eventually recognised as a medical specialty of its own.

She also began, in earnest, to build the home. The name came from a patient: St Christopher, the patron saint of travellers. In 1963 the King's Fund provided land in Sydenham, in south-east London. She spent years raising money, writing letters, giving talks, and lobbying anyone who would listen, and she was not always gentle about it. Years later she said that she expected to spend *the first 100,000 years of the next life apologizing for the toes I stepped on in this one*.

In 1963, too, she walked into a London gallery and saw the paintings of a Polish émigré artist named Marian Bohusz-Szyszko. She bought some for the chapel she was planning, and she came to know the man who had painted them.

◆◆◆

St Christopher's Hospice admitted its first patient, a Mrs Medhurst, on 13 July 1967. Eleven days later, on 24 July, Princess Alexandra formally opened it. It had been built and staffed with every debt cleared by opening day. It was the first hospice anywhere designed from the start to combine care for the dying with research and teaching. Soon afterward it began sending its staff out to care for patients in their own homes, the first team of its kind in Britain.

At the entrance there was a window. It was a plain sheet of glass, set in memory of a waiter from Warsaw. A concrete statue of St Christopher stood beside it to welcome whoever came through the door. The hospice records his words with it as *I will be a window in your home.* The room where the old entrance stood is now named after her.

She said of it, simply: *It took me nineteen years to build the home round the window.*

She never let anyone forget whose window it was. In 1993, when she was seventy-five and the hospice movement had spread across the world, she told an interviewer that David Tasma was the founder of the modern hospice movement. Everything that mattered, she said, had been there by his bed in 1948: openness, the mind and the heart, the freedom of the spirit. The rest had taken nineteen years of committees and fund-raising and building work.

Not everyone admired what she did or how she did it. Her firm opposition to legalising euthanasia, which she held for religious reasons and because

she believed good pain control made it unnecessary, made her opponents as well as admirers. In the 1980s, when AIDS was new and frightening, she wrote to the government that St Christopher's had *strong reservations* about admitting patients with the disease to its existing wards, and that position has been quoted against her since.

Even among her opponents there was respect. In 1961, years before the hospice opened, the chairman of the Voluntary Euthanasia Society told her: *I feel there would be little or no problem of euthanasia* if care like hers were widely available. Her own view, given to an interviewer many years later, was shorter. *Suffering is only intolerable when nobody cares.*

She was made a dame, and in 1989 the Queen appointed her to the Order of Merit. She kept working.

Inside St Christopher's, the front windows looked out over a park, and the rear windows over a flower garden and a goldfish pond. Patients were given their medicine by the clock, and the family was cared for along with the patient. Students came to learn, and the hospice published what it found, so that the care inside it could be copied elsewhere.

Every person deserves a good death, she told an interviewer in 1990.

Today St Christopher's and its community programmes support more than 7,500 people in south-east London, most of them living in their own homes.

◆◆◆

Marian Bohusz-Szyszko had a wife in Poland from whom he had long been estranged, whom he continued to support, and he was a devout Catholic. He and Cicely were friends, then more than friends, for seventeen years. His wife died in 1975. In 1980 he and Cicely married. She was sixty-one. He was seventy-nine.

She called him *the third great Pole in my life*. His paintings hung in the hospice's corridors and its chapel. She said she was happier than she had ever been. In his last years, when he was over ninety and frail, she brought him into the hospice with her every day. He died at St Christopher's in 1995.

In 2002 she was diagnosed with breast cancer. It spread to her hip and pelvis. In February 2005 she moved into a room on the Nuffield Ward of the hospice she had built, and became, at last, one of its patients. She was not serene about it every day. Those close to her said she sometimes seemed to welcome death and sometimes pushed it away, wanting more time to tidy things up. She had once said that *the hardest thing of all is learning to be a patient*.

That April, while she lay on the ward, her portrait was unveiled at the National Portrait Gallery in London. She had become a national figure. On the Nuffield Ward, she was simply the patient in her room, being given her medicine by the clock.

She died at St Christopher's on 14 July 2005, at the age of eighty-seven, almost exactly thirty-eight years

after Mrs Medhurst arrived as its first patient. Her ashes were buried in the hospice garden, beside Marian's.

◆◆◆

When she died, the movement that began beside a waiter's bed had spread across the world. Today the World Health Organization estimates that some fifty-seven million people need palliative care each year, about twenty-six million of them in the last year of their lives, and most of them in low- and middle-income countries. Only about one in seven receives it. In much of the world morphine is still scarce, held back by fear and by regulation. In 2018, by the WHO's count, about four-fifths of the world's people, most of them in poorer countries, received only about thirteen percent of the morphine used for pain, and people still die in the kind of pain she spent her life learning to prevent. But there are now thousands of hospice and palliative care services in more than ninety countries, and in nearly all of them the practices she fought for are ordinary: medicine given by the clock, before the pain comes back; the family treated as part of the care; a person asked what is frightening them, and listened to.

Somewhere tonight, in a quiet room, a woman is dying of the same illness that killed David Tasma. A nurse comes in before the hour is up, checks the chart, and gives the next dose before anyone has to ask for it. The woman's daughter is asleep in the chair by the bed with her shoes off. Down the corridor, a volunteer is rinsing cups. Someone has written the woman's name on the board by the door,

and under it, in a different hand, the name she likes to be called. There is a window in the room. Outside it, the streetlights have come on, and nobody in the room is in pain.

> Side note: In June 1990, a Californian woman named Kate Munger sat beside her friend Larry, who was in a coma and dying of AIDS. She did not know what else to do, so she sang to him, the same simple song over and over, for two and a half hours. *I felt as if I had given generously of my essence to my dear friend while I sang to him*, she said later. Ten years afterward she founded the Threshold Choir, small groups of volunteers who sing softly at the bedsides of the dying. Today there are more than 180 of them around the world, with more than 1,300 singers.

Question: Was there a time when someone sat with you, or you sat with someone, and offered nothing but what was in your mind and in your heart?

Question: What are three ways that what is happening could be kind?

Action: Buy yourself or someone else a flower you really like.

Chapter Twenty-Five

Ode

———

Purple

"*Weeping may endure for a night, but joy cometh in the morning.*" — Psalm 30:5

◆◆◆

In the summer of 1802, on his doctor's advice, a thirty-one-year-old composer rented rooms in the village of Heiligenstadt, in the vineyards outside Vienna, to rest his ears.

His name was Ludwig van Beethoven, and he was going deaf.

It had begun about four years earlier, a roaring and humming in his ears that would not stop, and a slow fading of everything else. He had told almost no one. A musician who could not hear was finished, and he was only at the beginning. To an old friend from Bonn he had written, the year before, that his hearing had been growing worse for three years; that at the theater he had to lean close against the orchestra to follow the actors; that he could not hear the high notes of the instruments or the voices if he sat a little way off. *How often*, he wrote, *have I cursed my existence!* To another friend he wrote: *I*

beg you will keep the fact of my deafness a profound secret.

In company he could not follow conversation, so he avoided company. People thought he had become arrogant, cold, withdrawn. He let them think it rather than tell them why.

His pupil Ferdinand Ries later remembered walking with him in the countryside near Vienna and pointing out a shepherd playing a pipe at the edge of the woods. Beethoven heard nothing.

◆◆◆

On the sixth of October 1802, near the end of his stay, he sat down and wrote a letter to his two brothers. He never sent it.

Oh! ye who think or declare me to be hostile, morose, and misanthropical, it begins, in a translation made in 1866, *how unjust you are.* He explained that he had not been able to bring himself to say to others, *Speak louder; shout! for I am deaf!* He described the humiliation of standing beside someone who heard a flute in the far distance, while he heard nothing.

Then he wrote the sentence that has been read by millions of people since. *Such things brought me to the verge of desperation, and well-nigh caused me to put an end to my life. Art! art alone deterred me. Ah! how could I possibly quit the world before bringing forth all that I felt it was my vocation to produce?*

He had decided, he wrote, that he must now choose patience as his guide. He left instructions for his brothers about his few possessions. He told them: *Recommend Virtue to your children; that alone, and not wealth, can ensure happiness.* He ended: *Farewell! Love each other.*

Four days later, on the outside of the folded letter, he wrote a postscript. *As autumn leaves fall and wither*, he wrote, *so are my hopes blighted.* And then a prayer:

O Providence! vouchsafe me one day of pure felicity!

The word the translator rendered as felicity was, in his German, *Freude*. Joy.

He folded the letter away and kept it, unsent, among his papers, for the next twenty-five years. Nobody saw it until after he died. And he went back to Vienna, and lived, and wrote.

◆◆◆

What he wrote in the years that followed is much of what we mean by music.

He wrote the "Eroica" Symphony, and the Fifth, with its four famous knocking notes. He wrote the "Emperor" Concerto and the Violin Concerto and the "Pastoral" Symphony, with its birds and its brook and its storm. He wrote an opera about a woman who disguises herself as a man to rescue her husband from a political prison. His hearing went on failing. He went on writing.

In 1809, when a post abroad threatened to take him away, three noblemen in Vienna signed a contract to

pay him four thousand florins a year for the rest of his life, on one condition: that he stay in Vienna. They wanted, they said, to free him from material worries so that he could devote himself to his art. One of them was the Archduke Rudolph, the Emperor's youngest brother and Beethoven's only composition pupil, then twenty-one.

Almost at once, the arrangement began to fall apart. War devalued the currency, one prince went bankrupt, and the other was killed in a fall from his horse. Only the young archduke, Rudolph, paid his share faithfully, every time, for the rest of Beethoven's life. Beethoven dedicated to him some of the greatest music he ever wrote.

From 1818, Beethoven could no longer follow speech at all. His visitors wrote their side of the conversation in small notebooks, and he answered them aloud. About a hundred and forty of these conversation books survive.

◆◆◆

Since he was a young man in Bonn, he had wanted to set to music a poem by Friedrich Schiller called "An die Freude," "To Joy." It was a long, exuberant, slightly drunken poem about joy as a spark of the divine, and about all people becoming brothers. In 1793, a professor in Bonn wrote to Schiller's wife that a gifted young musician there intended to set the whole thing.

He carried it with him for thirty years.

In the early 1820s, deaf, often ill, often lonely, quarreling with his family, short of money, he finally

began. He put it at the end of a symphony, his Ninth, after three great movements for orchestra alone. When the last movement begins, the orchestra plays fragments of each of the earlier movements, and rejects each in turn. Then a baritone stands and sings words Beethoven wrote himself, not Schiller: *O friends, not these sounds! Let us raise our voices in more pleasing and more joyful ones.*

And then the choir sings: *Freude!*

◆◆◆

The symphony was first performed on the seventh of May 1824, in the Kärntnertor Theater in Vienna. It was the first time in about ten years that Beethoven had appeared on a concert stage.

Michael Umlauf was conducting. He had quietly told the musicians to follow him and not the composer, who stood beside him on the stage, beating time and turning the pages of his score, deep inside the music only he could hear. A violinist who was there remembered him throwing himself back and forth like a madman.

During the second movement the audience broke into applause, which in those days was not unusual. At the end, the story has been told for two hundred years, Beethoven was still facing the orchestra, a few bars behind, still conducting, and could not hear the theater exploding behind him. Caroline Unger, the twenty-year-old contralto, stepped forward, took him gently by the sleeve, and turned him around, so that he could see what he could not hear: the whole

audience on its feet, waving hats and handkerchiefs in the air so that a deaf man would know.

Exactly when it happened, after the second movement or at the end, the witnesses do not agree, and no one has traced the first telling of it. It is told anyway, everywhere, because it is the right story.

The concert lost money. Beethoven died three years later, in March 1827, at fifty-six. Among his papers, his friends found a letter addressed to his brothers, dated October 1802, never sent.

He had prayed for one day of pure *Freude*. He did not get it, not in the way he meant. He gave it away instead.

◆ ◆ ◆

In June 1918, near the end of the First World War, the Ninth Symphony was performed in Asia for the first time, in a prison camp.

The camp was at Bandō, on the Japanese island of Shikoku. It held about a thousand German and Austro-Hungarian soldiers captured by Japan in China in 1914. Its commandant, a lieutenant colonel named Matsue Toyohisa, ran it with unusual decency, and the prisoners were allowed to give concerts. On the first of June 1918, the camp orchestra and a choir of eighty men performed the Ninth. There were no women, so men sang the women's parts. Prisoners in their captors' country sang about all people becoming brothers.

The town around the camp, now called Naruto, performs the Ninth every year on the first Sunday in June.

Today, in December, Japan performs the Ninth more than any country on earth. It is called simply *Daiku*, Number Nine. There are hundreds of performances every winter, many with amateur choirs, and in Osaka there is one with ten thousand singers. A former mayor of Naruto, Toshiaki Kamei, has said that singing together helps people accept one another.

◆◆◆

Under the dictatorship of General Augusto Pinochet in Chile, in the 1970s and 1980s, groups of women whose husbands, sons, and brothers had been taken as political prisoners would gather outside the prisons and detention centers at night and sing the "Ode to Joy" in Spanish. Inside, the prisoners heard them, and knew they had not been forgotten.

In the spring of 1989, in Tiananmen Square in Beijing, as the army moved in, students played the Ninth over makeshift loudspeakers to drown out the government's broadcasts.

That same year, on the ninth of November, the Berlin Wall opened. On Christmas Day, in the old Schauspielhaus on the eastern side of the city, the American conductor Leonard Bernstein led the Ninth with musicians from both Germanys and from the four nations that had occupied the city since the war: Britain, France, the Soviet Union, and the United States. In the last movement, he changed one

word. Instead of *Freude*, joy, the choir sang *Freiheit*, freedom. He said he was sure Beethoven would have given his blessing. The concert went out live, on television and radio, to more than twenty countries.

In living rooms in Rotterdam and Eindhoven, in Akron and Montreal and Miami, wherever the broadcast reached, the sound of a deaf man's prayer for one day of joy came through the speakers.

Today, without words, the melody is the anthem of Europe.

◆ ◆ ◆

Somewhere this morning a child is practicing the piano before school. She is eight, and her feet don't reach the floor, and the tune in her beginner's book is one of the simplest in it, a few notes stepping up and down the scale, the one almost every child learns early. She doesn't know that a man who could not hear wrote it, or that he once wrote a letter saying goodbye and then folded it away and kept living. She just knows it is the first song she ever played all the way through, and when she gets it right, her grandmother claps from the kitchen.

> Side note: A Scottish girl named Evelyn Glennie began losing her hearing at the age of eight, and has been profoundly deaf since childhood. Her percussion teacher, Ron Forbes, taught her to feel sound through other parts of her body: the higher drum from the waist up, the lower drum from the waist down. She went on to study at the Royal Academy of Music in London and became one of the best-known solo percussionists in the world. She

often plays barefoot, on stage and in the recording studio, so she can feel the music coming up through the floor.

Question: Who has turned you around, at some point in your life, so that you could see what you were not able to hear?

Question: What are three ways that what is happening could be kind?

Action: Put a pencil or pen in your mouth sideways until you can bite on it with your molars, and notice whether the muscles of smiling make you happier.

Chapter Twenty-Six

Seven Names

———

Magenta

"*You give but little when you give of your possessions. It is when you give of yourself that you truly give.*" — Kahlil Gibran, The Prophet (1923)

◆◆◆

Nicholas Green was seven years old and he was in love with Italy.

He lived in Bodega Bay, a fishing village on the California coast about sixty-five miles north of San Francisco, with his parents, Reg and Maggie, and his little sister, Eleanor, who was four. His mother had shown him buildings and paintings since he was small, and his father, a former journalist, filled in the history. He was thrilled, his father wrote, by the idea of the ancient roads running out from the centre of Rome in every direction. He stood amazed in front of the mosaics in Ravenna. When his father read him the story of Polyphemus, the one-eyed giant of the *Odyssey*, Nicholas grew so excited that Reg thought he might burst.

He was also very much seven. Asked what the best thing in Verona had been, he said lunch at McDonald's.

His mother remembered something else about him. He was kind and considerate, she said. He made a point of including the children the others overlooked. He looked for the good in people and in things. His parents believed he would do something remarkable with his life.

◆◆◆

In September 1994 the family took a long holiday in Italy. They saw Rome. They saw Pompeii. Then they turned south, down the A3, the long motorway that runs from Salerno through Calabria to Reggio, at the toe of the Italian boot, heading for Sicily.

Nicholas had a particular reason to want to get there. Between the toe of Italy and Sicily lies the Strait of Messina, the narrow water where, in the *Odyssey*, Scylla and Charybdis waited for ships. He wanted to see it.

On the night of 29 September they were driving south in a rented car. They had stopped at an Autogrill, one of the motorway restaurants, and gone on. It was somewhere around ten o'clock, a warm night. Maggie was dozing in the passenger seat. In the back, Nicholas and Eleanor were asleep.

A car that had been behind them pulled up alongside.

Reg felt it before he could explain it. *Something's wrong here*, he thought. Maggie woke instantly. She

saw two men in masks, and one of them was holding a pistol. They were shouting in Italian, which the Greens did not understand, but the meaning was plain enough: pull over.

Reg did not pull over. He put his foot down. The other car stayed with them, side by side on the dark road, somewhere near the exit for Vibo Valentia, and then the shots came. One shattered the rear window where the children were sleeping. Another hit the window on the driver's side. Afterward it was clear that the bullets had missed Reg and Maggie by inches. Reg kept driving, and the Greens' car pulled away. The attackers fell back and disappeared.

Later it emerged that the men had mistaken the Greens' rented car for one belonging to a jeweller, carrying stock to the shops of the region. It was a robbery aimed at someone else.

Reg drove on until he found lights and people. An accident further down the road had brought out the police and an ambulance, and he stopped there. When he opened the back door, Nicholas did not move.

A bullet had struck him in the head as he slept. It had lodged at the base of his brain.

◆◆◆

The hospital in the nearest town could not treat an injury like his. The police took over. They escorted the family to Villa San Giovanni on the coast, and from there a ferry carried them across the Strait of Messina, the water Nicholas had wanted to see, to

the Policlinico, the university hospital in Messina, where there was a unit for head injuries.

The doctors there did what they could. For two days Nicholas lay on life support, and for two days his parents waited. Reg thought, sitting there, about the rest of his life. *After this, how am I going to get through the rest of my life without him?* he remembered asking himself. He thought about small things: the feel of his son's hand in his on a walk, the voice that said *Goodnight, daddy* at the end of the day.

On 1 October 1994, the doctors told them that Nicholas was brain dead. His brain had stopped working and would never work again. Machines were still moving air in and out of his lungs, and his heart was still beating, and that was why, for a few hours more, his organs could still be given to someone else.

What happened next took only a few moments. Maggie turned to her husband and asked a question, quietly. *Now that he has gone*, she said, *shouldn't we donate the organs?*

Yes, Reg said.

That was all. Reg later wrote that it was the least difficult major decision either of them had ever had to make. Nicholas did not need his body any more. Other people did. They would have done anything to keep him alive, Reg said; that was no longer possible, and now at least something could be salvaged, *though at the time we had no idea how much*. Telling the doctors gave them something to

do, in the middle of the worst days of their lives, that was not only grief.

Reg's mind, even then, went further. If one small boy could help so many people, he reasoned, then a great many more could be helped if more families did the same. The thought would shape the rest of his life.

It was not an obvious choice in the Italy of 1994. The country had one of the lowest rates of organ donation in Western Europe, about six donors for every million people. Transplants were often regarded with superstition and suspicion. Two foreign parents, who had every reason to hate the country where their child had been shot, gave his organs to Italians. Many Italians, when they heard, could hardly believe that the family wanted to.

◆◆◆

His heart went to Rome, to a fifteen-year-old boy named Andrea Mongiardo.

Andrea had been born with a defective heart. He had spent more than half his life in hospitals. He had been through five heart operations, and none of them had worked. By the autumn of 1994 he was receiving blood transfusions twice a week, and his doctor described him as struggling to survive. His parents were in despair. A transplant was the only hope he had. After the operation he recovered more slowly than the others, because years of illness had worn him down, but he did recover, and gradually he grew strong.

Nicholas's liver went to Sicily, to a nineteen-year-old woman named Maria Pia Pedalà. Her liver had failed. She was in a coma, near death, when the call came.

His kidneys went to two children who were on dialysis, Tino Motta and Anna Maria Di Ceglie; the published accounts give their names slightly differently and do not agree on their exact ages. Cells from his pancreas went, according to one published list of the recipients, to Silvia Ciampi.

His corneas went to two people who were losing their sight. The cornea is the clear layer at the front of the eye, thinner than a fingernail, through which all light enters; when it clouds, the world goes grey, and when it is replaced, the light comes back. One was Domenica Galletta, who had waited five years for a transplant and had never seen her own daughter's face. The other was Francesco Mondello, a young father.

Seven people. Four of them, by Reg's count, were teenagers. Five of them had been close to death, and two had been going blind.

◆ ◆ ◆

Italy had already been horrified by the shooting. Now it was undone by the gift.

The killing of a child on holiday, on one of the country's main roads, was front-page news across the nation, and many Italians felt it as a collective shame. When the news spread that the boy's parents had given his organs to Italians, the response was overwhelming. The Greens, for their part, refused to

blame Italy for what two men had done. When Reg was asked, years later, whether he hated Italy, his answer was that Italy had not pulled the trigger. What could have happened anywhere, he said, was the crime. What could not have happened anywhere was the response.

Then the numbers began to move. In the last three months of 1994, organ donations in Italy rose by about thirty percent. By around 2004 the rate had roughly tripled, to nearly twenty donors per million people, and Italy, once near the bottom of the Western European tables, rose toward the top. Reg, who had spent his career writing about numbers, was careful about them. Medicine had improved, he acknowledged, and so had the country's transplant system. He gave the credit to the people of the country. *The enormous increase in donations represents the generous hearts of the Italian people*, he said. But Italians themselves had a name for what had happened. They called it *l'effetto Nicholas*, the Nicholas Effect.

Parks, schools, streets and squares were named after him, more than a hundred places in all. Their son, who had lived only seven years, was remembered in more places than many kings. Two years after his death the Greens stood for a photograph with the seven recipients, all of them alive. Reg and Maggie were in it, and Eleanor, and two babies who had not been born when Nicholas died.

A newspaper in Los Angeles, looking back after thirty years, called 1 October 1994 the date of the Greens' *greatest pain and their finest hour*.

◆ ◆ ◆

There was a cost to all of it, and it was not small.

The first cost was simply that Nicholas was gone, and that nothing anyone did would bring him back. Reg and Maggie went home to Bodega Bay without him. Maggie said, years later, that people outside the family remember the day Nicholas died. *We remember his birthday.* The family shared his life and his loss with the world, she said, and they also kept memories of him that belonged only to them.

The second cost was the long business of justice. On 2 November 1994, Italian police arrested two men connected to the Calabrian mafia, Francesco Mesiano and Michele Iannello. Both denied it. In January 1997 the court acquitted them; it had been dark on the motorway, and the men had been masked, and Reg could not identify them. The Greens had to sit with the verdict for more than a year. In 1998 an appeals court overturned it and convicted both men. Iannello, who the court found had fired the shots, was sentenced to life in prison; Mesiano, the driver, to twenty years.

That was not the end of it. Iannello later became a *pentito*, a mafia member who cooperates with the state, though he claimed that it was his brother, not he, who had shot Nicholas. In exchange for his cooperation he was moved to house arrest, and later petitioned for a presidential pardon. In 2024

Mesiano wrote from prison asking for his conviction to be reviewed, insisting he had not killed the boy.

Reg's answers to all of this were measured. *We have never wanted revenge, only justice*, he said. Of the pardon request, he said only that *victims make very bad judges*. When an Italian newspaper asked him, twenty-eight years after the shooting, whether the sentences had been enough, he left it to Italians to decide whether that was sufficient punishment *for taking the life of an innocent child*.

There was another cost, quieter and slower. Doctors who work with donor families sometimes worry that when a recipient dies, the family will feel as though they have lost their child a second time. In February 2017, Andrea Mongiardo died in a hospital in Rome. He was thirty-seven. Three years earlier he had been treated for lymphoma, and the chemotherapy had scarred his lungs. Reg heard the news in an email from Andrea's longtime doctor. The heart, the doctor wrote, had still been working. *The final cause of death was respiratory failure.* At his funeral, among the mourners, were young people who had received transplants of their own, and the surgeon who, twenty-two years earlier, had placed Nicholas's heart in his chest.

Reg called the news deflating. It felt, he said, like losing a young nephew he had never expected to outlive. But he said that he and Maggie did not feel that Nicholas had died again. In the twenty-two years he had been given, Andrea had found work, played football, and lived a far more ordinary life than he had ever been able to live as a child. They

had no regrets about the decision they had made at that bedside in 1994.

◆◆◆

At home in Bodega Bay, the mail had started to bring bells.

Families sent them, most of them from Italy: ships' bells, cowbells, and every kind of bell in between, many of them sent by people who had lost children of their own. A San Francisco sculptor named Bruce Hasson, who refused to be paid, built an eighteen-foot tower of steel to hold them. At the centre hangs a large bell cast in Italy. On it are the names of the seven people who received Nicholas's organs.

The tower was dedicated in October 1996, two years after his death. As the ceremony went on, a great gust of wind came up and set the bells ringing. Maggie stood holding Eleanor's hand. Beside them, in a double baby jogger, sat twins born that spring. Reg spoke. He described the tower as a place where people would come to hang their irreplaceable memories of their children. *It's a slender link*, he said, *but it supports the weight of memories beyond price.*

A plaque explains what the bells are for: *They symbolize the continuity of life.* The tower holds about 140 bells now. Reg intended it as a memorial not only for Nicholas but for anyone who has lost someone. In 2018 Eleanor, who had been asleep beside her brother in the back seat that night, was married beside it.

◆◆◆

Reg Green spent the rest of his working life on the cause. He wrote two books, *The Nicholas Effect* and *The Gift that Heals*. He helped make a television film, *Nicholas' Gift*, seen by an estimated hundred million people. Reg went on travelling, to Italy dozens of times, to hospitals and conferences and schools. His message to doctors was plain: don't be afraid to ask bereaved families to donate.

In 2019, for the twenty-fifth anniversary, Reg and Maggie went back to Messina, the city where their son had died, and stood at a ceremony with the people who had received his organs. On the last night of the trip a surgeon took Reg to dinner at an old Roman restaurant. When the maître d' understood who his guest was, he was overcome, and could only say the boy's name. *Nicholas Green.*

Nicholas was a special little boy, Reg said. He and Maggie had always believed their son would do remarkable things. He had done them, Reg said, only not in the way they had imagined.

On one visit to Sicily he spoke to a class of young children and told them how a little boy, not much older than they were, had saved the lives of five people and given sight to two others. They listened wide-eyed. Afterward the principal reminded him that he and Maggie had spoken at the same school in 1995, the year after Nicholas died. Reg realised that he was looking at the children of the children who had listened to him then.

Maria Pia Pedalà, the girl from a small Sicilian town who had been in a coma at nineteen, recovered. She

married Salvatore, her childhood sweetheart. Four years after the transplant she had a son, and she named him Nicholas. Two years later she had a daughter, Alessia. The Greens met her son. In 2026, Alessia gave birth to a daughter of her own, named Viola, and Maria Pia, who had been expected to die as a teenager, became a grandmother. She said she cried with happiness. *I never expected the "great gift" could give me joy in so many ways.* Reg, by then in his late nineties, said that the Nicholas Effect had just enrolled one of its most important members.

◆◆◆

Domenica Galletta saw her daughter's face. Of the seven, the Greens lost touch with two over the years. When Reg last counted, five were living full lives.

In the United States alone, about 110,000 people are on the national waiting list for an organ, and every day twelve of them die still waiting. More than 49,000 transplants were performed there in 2025. Some will happen tonight. Many of them come from a family standing in a hospital corridor at the worst moment of their lives, being asked a question they never expected to be asked, and saying yes.

Somewhere tonight, in a hospital room with the lights turned low, a woman who could not climb a flight of stairs last spring is asleep. A monitor keeps count beside her. Her chest rises and falls, slowly, evenly, with lungs that belonged a few weeks ago to someone she will never meet. In another city, a

mother and father who said yes are lying awake in a house that is too quiet. Neither of them knows the other's name.

> Side note: In the hallway of an Italian school there are two clocks. One shows the time in Italy, like the clock in every other school in the country. The other is marked *Bodega Bay time*. It keeps the hour in the small California fishing village where Nicholas Green lived, nine time zones away, so that every day the children walking past it remember a boy they never met. Reg Green, who described it in an open letter to the Italian people, called it a continuing stimulus to the idealism of the students.

Question: Has there been a moment in your life when the worst thing that ever happened to you also held a choice about what to give?

Question: What are three ways that what is happening could be kind?

Action: Make, order or buy a card right now for a stranger to find, and write something nice inside for when they find it. Then leave it to be found.

Chapter Twenty-Seven

Earthrise

———

White

"*All of humanity appeared joined together on this glorious-but-fragile sphere.*" — William Anders, "50 Years After 'Earthrise,' a Christmas Eve Message from Its Photographer," Space.com, 2018

◆◆◆

By December, 1968 had been a long year.

It had opened at the end of January with the Tet Offensive, when North Vietnamese and Viet Cong forces struck at once across South Vietnam, and the war that Americans had been told was being won came into their living rooms as a war that was not. In April, Martin Luther King Jr. was shot in Memphis, and riots broke out in cities across the country. In June, Robert Kennedy was shot in Los Angeles. In August, Soviet tanks rolled into Prague, and in Chicago police and protesters fought in the streets while the cameras ran. By the end of the year, the records of the National Archives would hold the names of 16,899 American servicemen who died in Vietnam in 1968 alone, more than in any

other year of the war, and the dead on the other side of the line were beyond counting.

Bill Anders, looking back half a century later, put it plainly. *It sometimes seemed as if the country was coming apart at the seams.*

On the morning of December 21, he lay strapped on his back in a small cone at the top of the largest rocket yet built, with Frank Borman on his left and Jim Lovell in the middle, and waited for the count to reach zero.

◆ ◆ ◆

They were an unlikely set of three to carry anyone's hopes.

Borman, the commander, was a West Point man and an Air Force test pilot, blunt and impatient, a man who said afterward that he had no great wish to walk on the Moon at all. *I wanted to be part of the team that beat the Russians*, he said. His chief worry, by his own account, was that somehow the crew would make a mistake. Lovell, the command module pilot, was a Navy aviator who had already flown twice in Gemini, once for fourteen days beside Borman himself. Anders was the rookie, thirty-five, a nuclear engineer and Air Force pilot. Borman described him as a devout Roman Catholic.

His title on the mission was lunar module pilot. There was no lunar module. The landing craft was not ready, and the decision to send Apollo 8 to the Moon anyway had been made only months before, partly out of fear that the Soviet Union might get there first. So Anders, a pilot without the vehicle he

was named for, was given other work. He would photograph the Moon. He carried a flight plan with the frames laid out, the craters and the possible landing sites that future crews would need to see.

No human being had ever left the neighbourhood of the Earth. Every person who had ever lived, every cave painter and sailor and king, every child who had looked up at the Moon from a doorway, had lived and died inside the same thin envelope of air. The Saturn V lit beneath them. Less than three hours later, after circling the Earth to check their systems, they fired the third stage again and left orbit, and for the first time in history three people went away.

◆ ◆ ◆

They reached the Moon on the morning of December 24 and fired their engine behind it, out of radio contact with the Earth, to slow themselves into orbit. Back in Houston, the room waited in silence to learn whether the burn had worked. It had. The spacecraft came around the edge of the Moon with three men alive inside it, the first people ever to see the far side with their own eyes.

What they saw was grey. Borman would describe it to the world that evening as a vast, lonely, forbidding type of existence, a great expanse of nothing. Craters on craters, ridges, old impacts softened by nothing at all, because there was no wind and no water to soften anything. Anders worked through his list at his side window with a Hasselblad camera, taking the pictures the

geologists wanted. A second Hasselblad, mounted in Borman's forward window, clicked on a timer every twenty seconds.

The Earth had risen over the edge of the Moon three times already, once on each orbit. Nobody had seen it. The spacecraft had been pointed the wrong way.

On the fourth time around, shortly after half past ten in the morning by Houston clocks, Borman was rolling the spacecraft into a new attitude called for in the flight plan. The roll swung Anders's window toward the horizon at the moment the horizon gave something up.

The onboard tape caught what happened next. The voices of Anders and Borman are so alike on the recording that the people who have studied it most carefully have argued for years about who said which line, but most now give the first words to Anders.

Oh my God! Look at that picture over there! Here's the Earth coming up. Wow, is that pretty!

And then, with a chuckle, from one of the two of them, a joke about the flight plan: *Hey, don't take that, it's not scheduled.*

◆ ◆ ◆

The first picture was black and white, because black and white was what was in the camera. It shows a small half-disc above a grey horizon, with the crater Pasteur in the foreground, and it is not the picture the world remembers.

Anders wanted colour. *Hand me that roll of color quick, will you*, he said, and Lovell, down in the lower equipment bay where he had been taking sextant sightings, scrambled to find one. The tape is breathless. *Hurry. Quick. Just grab me a color. That color exterior. Hurry up!* Lovell called out the code on a magazine, *C 368*, and handed it over. By then the Earth had drifted out of Anders's window, and he said quietly, *Well, I think we missed it.*

Then Lovell, at another window, found it again. *Hey, I got it right here!* Anders moved across. *Let me get it out this window. It's a lot clearer.* Borman told him to take several. Lovell wanted the camera for himself. Anders, the mission's photographer, kept it, and asked everyone to calm down while he set the exposure, and Borman, laughing, told Lovell to calm down too.

250 at f/11, said Lovell.

Anders took two frames on the colour film, changing the exposure slightly between them. The whole exchange, from the first shout to the last frame, lasted less than two minutes.

In the camera, the Earth was beside the Moon, not above it. Anders had been holding the camera sideways to the horizon, and he said later that this was how he saw it from his window. When the picture was printed for the world, it was turned about a quarter of the way round, so that the grey ground lay along the bottom and the Earth hung over it like a rising sun. Half of the planet was in

shadow. The half in daylight was blue and swirled with white cloud.

In an oral history recorded for NASA in 1997, Anders tried to describe what he had felt. He spoke of *this very delicate, colorful orb which to me looked like a Christmas tree ornament coming up over this very stark, ugly lunar landscape.* Its physical insignificance struck him, he said, and yet it was home.

Lovell found that he could hold up his thumb against the window and hide the whole planet behind it. *You're only 240,000 miles away*, he said much later, *but everything that you have ever known is behind your thumb.*

Borman put it in fewer words. *The Earth was the only thing in the world in the universe that had any color.*

◆◆◆

NASA had given the crew one instruction for their broadcast that night. It was Christmas Eve, an enormous audience would be listening, and they should do something appropriate.

The men had puzzled over what that might be. The answer, by the accounts later told, came from someone who never went near a launch pad. Christine Laitin was the wife of Joseph Laitin, a government official in Washington. As a young teenager she had been part of the French Resistance in occupied Paris. When the question reached her household she suggested they start at the beginning, with the first verses of the Book of Genesis. The text

was printed on fireproof paper and bound into the flight plan.

That evening, as the spacecraft swung toward the lunar dawn, the grainy black-and-white television picture showed the grey surface sliding past below. By the usual estimate, around a billion people in sixty-four countries, about one in four human beings then alive, were watching or listening; no one could count them exactly.

Anders spoke first. *We are now approaching lunar sunrise, and for all the people back on Earth, the crew of Apollo 8 has a message that we would like to send to you.*

Then he read. *In the beginning God created the heaven and the earth. And the earth was without form, and void; and darkness was upon the face of the deep. And the Spirit of God moved upon the face of the waters. And God said, Let there be light: and there was light.*

He read through the fourth verse, where God sees the light, that it is good, and divides it from the darkness. Lovell took the next four, the evening and the morning, the firmament, the waters above and below. Borman read the last two, the gathering of the seas and the appearing of dry land, and then, in his flat commander's voice, he closed.

And from the crew of Apollo 8, we close with good night, good luck, a Merry Christmas, and God bless all of you, all of you on the good Earth.

Earlier in the same broadcast Lovell had said something simpler, in his own words. *The vast*

loneliness up here of the moon is awe inspiring, and it makes you realize just what you have back there on Earth. The Earth from there, he said, was a grand oasis in the big vastness of space.

◆◆◆

Early on Christmas morning, Houston time, they had to fire the engine once more, behind the Moon again and out of contact, to break out of orbit and head home. If it failed they would stay there. Mission Control waited through the silence a second time. When the spacecraft came around the limb and the signal returned, the first thing Lovell said to the people waiting was that they should be informed that there is a Santa Claus. Ken Mattingly, on the ground, answered that the crew were the best ones to know.

On December 27 they came down in the Pacific before dawn and were brought aboard the aircraft carrier USS Yorktown, home.

The letters and telegrams came in by the thousand. Borman, who was not a sentimental man, said years later that out of all of them there was one he never forgot. It had been sent by a stranger, and it said: *Thank you Apollo 8. You saved 1968.*

Time magazine named the three of them its Men of the Year.

◆◆◆

The film was developed after they got home, and the frame came out of the chemicals with the blue intact.

In 1969 the United States Post Office put a detail of it on a six-cent stamp with the words *In the beginning God*. That spring, the Whole Earth Catalog, a sprawling counterculture handbook for people who wanted to live more lightly, put it on the cover. It went onto posters in student rooms and onto the walls of offices and churches. People who had never thought about the planet as a single object found themselves looking at one. The nature photographer Galen Rowell would later call it *the most influential environmental photograph ever taken.*

On April 22, 1970, a little more than a year after Apollo 8 came home, about twenty million Americans, roughly a tenth of the country, went out into streets and parks and schoolyards for the first Earth Day. They planted trees and picked up rubbish along riverbanks and listened to speeches about clean air and water. Within a few years the United States had a new environmental agency and new laws protecting air and water and endangered species. Many things fed that tide, books and oil spills and burning rivers among them, and the organisers of Earth Day have long counted the photograph among its sparks: one small, blue half of a world, hanging over a dead grey one.

Anders, writing for the fiftieth anniversary, remembered how *the blue-and-white glory of Earth, the only color amidst the blackness of space, became a beacon.* He put the rest simply. *We are all, together, stewards of this fragile treasure.*

He kept coming back to the picture. Over the rest of his long life he said the same thing in slightly different words, and the version that lasted was this. *We came all this way to explore the Moon, and the most important thing is that we discovered the Earth.*

The view changed other things in him. Seeing the borders vanish, he remembered thinking, *This is the only home we have and yet we're busy shooting at each other?*

◆◆◆

Not everyone was grateful.

Madalyn Murray O'Hair, the founder of American Atheists, had already been through one long fight with her government. Her lawsuit on behalf of her teenage son had helped end compulsory Bible reading and prayer in American public schools in 1963. Life magazine called her the most hated woman in America, and by her account her family's home was stoned. To her, three government employees reading scripture to the world on a government broadcast was the same wrong in a larger room. She sued NASA. The courts turned the case back at each level until the Supreme Court declined to hear it in 1971.

The suit failed, but it was heard. When Buzz Aldrin, a Presbyterian elder, took communion on the surface of the Moon in July 1969, NASA asked him not to read his passage over the air, and he kept the service to himself. Forty years later he wrote that if

he had it to do over again, perhaps he would not choose to celebrate communion there at all.

Anders himself was changed too. The young Catholic who had begun the reading with *In the beginning* said later that the sight of that small, distant Earth had *really undercut* the religious beliefs he had grown up with. He came home with a different kind of reverence, for the planet itself.

And the year was not saved, not in the way the stranger's telegram hoped. The war went on for years. The names on the casualty lists kept coming. Borman, in a 1988 autobiography, claimed that he had taken the famous photograph himself, grabbing the camera from Anders. The tape and a careful study of it by NASA researchers showed otherwise, and he eventually agreed that all three Earthrise frames were Anders's.

That study, released in December 2013, was its own small act of devotion. Ernie Wright, a visualiser at NASA, matched lunar maps against the frames from the timer camera in Borman's window and the voices on the tape, and rebuilt those minutes over the Moon one at a time. It showed that the Earth came into Anders's window only because Borman was still rolling the spacecraft when it rose. Without the commander's turn, there would have been no picture. Without Lovell's scramble for the film, it would have been grey. The narration NASA released with the reconstruction called the photograph what it was, a group effort, with Anders's hand on the shutter.

◆◆◆

The three of them lived long lives, and they left one by one.

Borman died on November 7, 2023, in Billings, Montana, at ninety-five. He had gone on to run an airline and to raise cattle, and in old age he still said plainly that he had gone to the Moon to beat the Russians.

Anders finally settled in Washington State with his wife, Valerie, near the cold water and the islands of Puget Sound, where they founded a museum in which old aeroplanes do not sit behind ropes but are taken up and flown. *I'm retired now*, he told a visiting reporter, *so I fly as much as I can.*

On the morning of June 7, 2024, he was flying an old Beechcraft T-34 alone over the San Juan Islands when witnesses saw the plane nosedive into the channel off Orcas Island. He was ninety. His son Greg told reporters, *He was a great pilot, and we will miss him terribly.*

The man who had taken the world's picture of the Earth died above some of its most beautiful water, in one of his own planes, on a June morning.

Lovell was the last. He died on August 7, 2025, in Lake Forest, Illinois, at ninety-seven. Years earlier, an interviewer had asked him what that flight had taught him. People wanted to go to heaven when they died, he said, but he had come to see it differently. *In reality, if you think about it, you go to heaven when you're born.*

◆ ◆ ◆

In April 2026, more than fifty-seven years after Apollo 8, four more people swung around the far side of the Moon in a spacecraft called Orion. On April 6, through a window, the crew of Artemis II photographed the Earth going down behind the lunar horizon, a deliberate echo of the picture Anders took. The planet in their frame was the same blue, swirled with the same white.

It is the same Earth now. The white in that photograph is weather, clouds forming and breaking over oceans whose water has been rained and drunk and wept and rained again for billions of years. The blue is the sky that everyone alive breathes from, the same few miles of air. Somewhere under the white of those clouds on the morning Anders took his picture, children were being born and soldiers were dying and families were hanging lights in their windows for Christmas.

Somewhere tonight, under the same half-lit sphere, a woman is stepping out of a hospital at the end of a long shift. She stops in the car park because the sky has gone a deep, clear blue at the edge, and there is one bright planet low over the trees, and the Moon is coming up, grey and enormous, over the roofs. She stands still for a minute with her keys in her hand. From where the Moon is, if anyone were there to look, she would be inside the small blue ornament, too small to see, with everything that anyone has ever known.

Side note: In October 2018, fifty years after the flight, the International Astronomical Union gave official names to two craters that can be seen in the Earthrise photograph. Until then they had been known only by catalogue letters. One became Anders' Earthrise. The other, a smaller crater, was named 8 Homeward, for the crew of Apollo 8 turning for home. And in May 2026 a small asteroid, first spotted in December 1998, thirty years after the flight, was given a name of its own: (79871) Earthrise. Somewhere out in the dark, two craters and a stone now carry the memory of a moment when three people looked back.

Question: When have you seen something you thought you knew, a person, a place, your own life, from far enough away that it suddenly looked precious?

Question: What are three ways that what is happening could be kind?

Action: Take a fifteen-minute awe walk. Leave your phone in your pocket, and look for things that are vast or quietly astonishing, the sky, an old tree, light on water, as if you were seeing them for the first time.

Thirty-Five Kindnesses

———

1. Spend five to twenty dollars today on someone who cannot repay you: a coffee for the person behind you, a meal for a coworker, a book for a child. Afterward, write one sentence about how the feeling differs from the last time you spent the same amount on yourself.

2. Find one person, yourself or anyone else in the world, and send a message on your phone that begins "I appreciate you for..." Then finish the sentence.

3. Write a letter to someone who believed in you before there was any evidence, and tell them exactly what their belief made possible. If you can, read it to them aloud, in person or on the phone.

4. Take a photo of the QR code on this book to give a free digital copy to someone in your contacts. Say nothing, or simply "Enjoy!", and notice whether it brings them some happiness.

5. Come up with three things you want other people to do for you. Now do one of them for yourself, because you deserve it.

6. Go find the nearest animal to hug, adore, feed or compliment.

7. Give one hour this week to the cause that makes you angriest. Volunteer, write the letter, make the call, or show up where the work is being done. Let your anger do some good.

8. Visit https://10xliving.org/media and notice whether a comedy, or something else there, brings more meaning to your day.

9. What is one thing you could add to your routine that would be truly kind to you? Put it in your phone with a daily alarm for the next thirty days, so it becomes a habit.

10. The next time fear rises, breathe in gently through your nose, take a second small sip of air on top, and let it all out long and slow through your mouth. Repeat at a comfortable pace for up to five minutes, and notice whether your body settles.

11. Give someone a sincere, specific compliment today: something true you have noticed about them and never said out loud. Most of us underestimate how much it will mean to them.

12. Think of someone whose success stings a little. Send them a message of real congratulations, warm and specific, and ask them one curious question about how they did it.

13. Write a kind note to your future self and put it in your calendar for tomorrow.

14. Take your most depressing, angry or bitter recurring thought and write it down here. Then ask yourself: Can I absolutely know that this thought is true? Could I prove it is the truth, the whole truth

and nothing but the truth in a court of law? Would everyone else believe me?

15. Ask yourself: "What is the kindest thing I can do for the deepest, truest and most important parts of myself?" Brainstorm on this question and take one small step toward your answer.

16. Go for a five-minute walk using your peripheral vision. Don't focus on anything in particular. Try to softly see everything at once.

17. Sit for five minutes and silently wish someone well: first someone you love, then a stranger, then someone you find difficult. "May you be safe. May you be well. May you be at ease." Notice what changes in you by the third person.

18. Write a letter of forgiveness to someone who hurt you, one you will not send. Say plainly what happened and what it cost you. Then write what you are choosing to set down.

19. Give yourself, or someone around you, a warm hug and say clearly: "I'm glad you are here!"

20. The next time someone serves you, at a register, a counter or a kitchen, learn their name, use it, and thank them for something specific.

21. What would be the kindest thing for your body right now: a stretch, a rapid aerobic run, or a deep breath and a slow exhale with a wish for something beautiful, a blessing? Do that now.

22. Put a hand on your heart. Say to yourself the words you would say to a friend who was hurting the way you are now. Breathe there for one minute.

23. Ask the oldest person in your family for one story about how your family got through a hard time, and write it down before you forget it.

24. For fifteen minutes, write privately about a hard thing that has happened to you, one you feel ready to look at: what happened, what you felt, and what it means to you now. No one will read it. Stop whenever you wish. If it helps, return to it tomorrow, and the day after, and the day after that.

25. Call someone you have been meaning to reach, with your voice, not a text. Ask how they really are, and listen.

26. Send a short message today to someone you haven't spoken to in a while, just to say you were thinking of them. People almost always appreciate it more than we expect.

27. Buy yourself or someone else a flower you really like.

28. Put a pencil or pen in your mouth sideways until you can bite on it with your molars, and notice whether the muscles of smiling make you happier.

29. Make, order or buy a card right now for a stranger to find, and write something nice inside for when they find it. Then leave it to be found.

30. Take a fifteen-minute awe walk. Leave your phone in your pocket, and look for things that are vast or quietly astonishing, the sky, an old tree, light on water, as if you were seeing them for the first time.

31. Each night this week, write down three good things that happened that day, and why they happened.

32. Choose one day this week and do five kind things on that day, small or large.

33. When a strong feeling rises, name it in one word, on paper or silently: anger, fear, grief, jealousy, joy. Notice what changes once it has a name.

34. Ask someone for help with something small, and let them have the pleasure of giving.

35. Give one hour of your time this week to someone, with no agenda but their company. Afterward, ask yourself what changed for them, and what changed for you.

Meta

———

Exploring kindness through the eyes of a student and a teacher

"*I have striven not to laugh at human actions, not to weep at them, nor to hate them, but to understand them.*" — Baruch Spinoza, *Tractatus Politicus*

◆◆◆

High above the earth, a witness looked down at the humans below.

Witness: Teacher, what is kindness?

Teacher: The first kindness is kindness to yourself. Every time you imagine that there are ugly and horrible sides to yourself, or to another, you increase your own suffering. So let us begin with how a judgment is made, because so much unkindness begins with one.

To judge, you must first decide that something bad is happening. Then you must decide whose fault it is, which is not an easy task in an interconnected world. Then you must decide why they are bad. To truly understand a single thing, you would have to watch its whole history.

Witness: You are saying a judgment has three parts: that something bad is happening, that someone is at fault, and that the one at fault is bad. And that each is harder than it looks, because everything is connected to everything else.

Teacher: Yes, that is the case. Take the boy by the fence. An older child in a school is hurting a younger child. If you decide that he is bad, you must ask why, and to answer that you must watch the whole of his history.

So let us say you watch it. You may discover that over the course of his life, big and strong people ignored his suffering, and other big and strong people caused it. Perhaps there was a strong older brother who tormented him when he was small, and a father who did nothing about it. So now you decide that the brother is bad, or the father, and deserves to be punished.

And what is punishment but the infliction of pain? If you appear before the bully as a thirty-foot giant and say, *I am going to spank you for what you did, because it is wrong*, what will the bully learn? He will learn that the ones who get to give pain are the strong ones. And is it not true that children learn at least as much from what their parents do as from what their parents say?

Witness: So if I only punish the bully, I may be teaching him that bullying works. He will wait until the giant has gone and use what he learned on the weak one again.

Teacher: Yes, that is the case.

◆◆◆

Witness: Let us go back to the boy by the fence. Why did his brother torment him?

Teacher: Should we not examine the brother's life as carefully as the bully's? We may find that he felt terrified and alone when his parents were out working, and sat at home watching films about powerful countries invading smaller ones.

The pattern is the same one the boy learned. Larger force is used against smaller force, and the smaller learns that this is how the world works. Some researchers estimate that in the last century governments killed more civilians, through repression and mass murder, than died in battle. The estimates vary, and the scale is immense. Children are hurt by parents and people they know far more often than by strangers.

Should we then condemn all families, all countries, and all governments?

Witness: That cannot be right. Then there is no one left to do the punishing.

Teacher: Then let us look at it another way. If you are judging people, it is because you learned to judge, and to be judged. It did not arrive with you. It is a pattern learned through experience, reinforced by repetition, and passed from one person to another.

For a very long time the dinosaurs roamed the earth, and then they were largely gone, because of a

rock from the sky. Was the rock kind, or cruel? The answer depends on who is left to ask the question.

Witness: Then may one event carry many truths at once?

Teacher: Yes. You may have suffered terribly at the hands of your parents, and you may also have grown strong and independent in the years that followed. Both can be true. Your strength does not make their cruelty kind. But you are free to recognize what you have made of your life, without giving the cruelty the final word.

We can recognize cruelty for what it is, protect those harmed by it, and still ask what understanding might help us prevent it. Kindness gives us another response besides condemnation.

◆◆◆

Witness: Does this mean that when I see a stronger person hurting a weaker one, I should do nothing?

Teacher: To do nothing is to do something. If a child is being hurt, go to the child. Stop it. Protect the one who is small.

And then there is a second question, which is how to stop it happening again. Here is what I have come to understand about the one who hurts. Sometimes a person who knowingly causes pain is carrying pain he cannot bear alone. He may have learned to feel so small and helpless that making someone else feel smaller offers a moment of relief. This does not explain every act of cruelty. But when it does explain

one, it gives us something more useful than a verdict. It gives us somewhere to look for the root.

If you are a gardener and you want to stop a weed in your garden, do you clip the leaf, the branch, or the root?

Witness: The root.

Teacher: The leaf is easy. You cut the weed off at the ground, and it looks wonderful for a few days. But if you care that this plant does not grow back, you must dig out the root that produces it. You can stop the bully in the moment. That cuts the leaf. It does not dig out the root.

Look inside his mind, and you may discover that every day for twenty years he has had a conversation with his father in the back of his head. *What did I do to deserve this? Why didn't you stop? Why didn't you love me? I am unlovable. Nobody cares about me. And now I feel small again, and I can't stand it.* And then he sees, in the corner of his eye, some small person enjoying life without any of that suffering, and he lashes out, until at least there is someone who feels smaller than he does.

Witness: Is it not right for people like that to get help, rather than to bully small children?

Teacher: It is right. Now look more closely. He saw scorn on his father's face every time he was frightened and asked for help. So now he feels small and disgusting every time he needs help. Would you ask someone that small to feel even smaller? Because that is what you do when you only judge him. If the reason he bullies is to move his smallness

onto another person, then your judgment is cutting the branch again.

Witness: I see. Every answer I think of begins with telling him what is wrong with him.

Teacher: Yes. When a parent holds a child, before the child has language, and the parent's face says that to be needy is sickening, how can you punish a two-year-old for believing the face that gave him life? Do you think a page of symbols in ink is powerful enough to undo that? Reading him a list of his faults tells him only one thing: that you do not understand him.

◆◆◆

Witness: Then which is kinder? To help the one who was hurt, or to help the bully?

Teacher: The child needs protection today. The bully needs help to stop hurting children tomorrow. Could kindness ask us to do both?

If we only shame him and leave the root, the weed grows back somewhere else, and others are hurt in places far from you. If he ends up in prison, the public pays tens of thousands of dollars a year to keep him there, and the people he might have spared are hurt anyway.

Witness: Teacher, I find these people disgusting. It offends me deeply to see a big person, or a big country, hurt the innocent.

Teacher: Yes. You learned from your culture to despise cruelty to the innocent, and you learned that punishing such people is right. The disgust is

already in you. Looking closely does not make the feeling smaller. But notice: the bully learned so deeply to despise the weak in himself that he cannot stop just because you tell him to. And you despise cruelty so deeply that you cannot stop judging just because I tell you to. Are you so different from the one you judge?

Witness: You are saying that the thing I call bad in him is also in me, because we were taught by the same world.

Teacher: Yes, that is the case. The kind thing is to be interested in the root. These roots can run very deep, sometimes through generations, and longer still when the trauma belongs to a whole culture. A person who bullies a younger child may be repeating a pattern he learned long ago. You might consider what would help such a person feel loved, safe and important, so that hurting someone smaller no longer serves the purpose it once did. Someone who feels deeply loved and important may have far less need to make another person feel small.

When you are kinder to the bully, and see that he is not so different from you, some of the kindness you offer may return to you. The bully, for all his protest, may feel small too. If shame is part of what drives him, your kindness may show him another way to live. And in offering it, you may learn something about how to treat yourself.

Witness: Is it true that when he sees I do not want to punish him, he may consider, for the first time, that

he is not so disgusting for his weakness? And that I will be teaching him by example?

Teacher: It is possible. That is the hope.

◆◆◆

Witness: Why are parents so harsh with their children?

Teacher: We are all ignorant in the ways we were taught poorly. Many people become parents with little preparation for the emotional demands of raising a child. Many are taught that making more money makes a person successful, and that it is bad for their reputation to keep company with unpopular people, including the unpopular parts inside themselves. If they are emotional, or sensitive, they learn to hide those parts. And then they turn to their children and teach them to disown the same parts.

Witness: Then what is a person to do? Every year, new parents begin raising children with little preparation for the emotional demands of the work. Many carry the judgments they were taught as children. Some pass those judgments on, teaching their children to hide the parts of themselves they once learned to hide. How can the cycle ever end? What can I do to change the whole world?

Teacher: Tell me first what you have learned today.

Witness: That I am less different from the bully than I thought. That I can protect the child and still look for the root.

Teacher: And you did not learn it from me. You learned it from the worst person you could think of.

If your greatest learning came from him, might you feel a little patient with him? It took you many years to learn this lesson. It could take him many more.

As for changing the whole world, you remind me of a story about a little girl throwing starfish back into the sea.

Every day she walked along the beach, and every starfish she found stranded on the sand she threw back into the waves. One day her mother, out of patience, said to her: *Every day you throw starfish back into the water, and every day there are more on the beach. All around the world, millions of starfish are washed up on beaches. What is the point? It makes no difference.*

The little girl looked at the starfish drying in the hot sun three feet in front of her. Bending down, she took it carefully in her hands and flung it out into the waves.

It makes a difference to that one, she said.

Ten feet further on, there was another. She picked it up and threw it.

And it makes a difference to this one, too, she said. *There. Enjoying the cool water. And that is enough for me.*

Question: Who is the bully you find hardest to forgive, and what has he taught you that no book could?

Question: What are three ways that what is happening could be kind?

Afterword

———

Dane lay in bed with a mild headache.

The bathtub in the Marin Hilltop Hotel in San Rafael, California, had not been working when he got back from a date and a gym session that had not gone well. The date had ended with Dane wishing her well. Each time, in the middle of the date, she had gotten a call from a customer and said she wanted to be driven back to her shop. And each time he had told her that quality time was the most important thing to him in a relationship. Since interruptions had happened one hundred percent of the time, in a sample of two, he found it too hard to imagine that this would suddenly change, particularly when she had made it clear that one of her primary drives right now was money: money for repairs on her investment property and on her own home.

He hadn't slept well, so he had turned on some of Joe Dispenza's YouTube meditations, barely audible. He blew his nose, felt the tightness in his neck, and tried to find a thread for the day.

Should he stay in the Bay Area? He hated rejection, and so many things were ending in it. Unanswered emails. The one landlord he had met had interrupted

him one hundred percent of the time, even after Dane pointed out, twice, that this was probably the biggest likely friction point in their relationship. An hour of trying to answer questions and being interrupted had been the only result of considering living in the Bay Area.

A slight pull toward the university campus at Berkeley caught his mind. But what would he do with it? Was it as ephemeral as all the others? He had a sign in storage, and he had some books he wanted to give away. But how would that go, exactly?

An idea for a kindness exchange crossed his mind. What if, instead of buying books, there was a record of kindness? What if, on campus, people started keeping track of all the kind things that had happened, and told their stories of kindness, and a map or a tapestry of kindness unfolded across the university? What if that worked?

But many of his books did not deal directly with kindness. So what if, instead of focusing on the other books, he wrote a new book about kindness? It could be fun, and the ease of creating it was tempting. In his best experiment with AI, he had once given Claude a forty-five-minute recording and said, write this book. Claude had written a book so compelling that when it was finished he spent all day reading it, and loved it.

What if that happened again?

Then he remembered what happened the other ninety-five percent of the time. He wrote something,

and Claude made it worse. He wrote something else, and Claude made it worse. He started getting irritated with the AI. He gave it to GPT, and GPT lied about its changes, and he got irritated there. Pretty soon he was impatient, critical, and complaining bitterly about the stupidity and dishonesty of AI.

He saw an image of a circle. It seemed worth getting out of bed to write down. He wrote it all on a Post-it.

Next came GenSpark, for a book cover. Of course, GenSpark had a new version, and the hotel internet was nonexistent, and already the pressures were creeping in. Am I going to spend all day arguing with technology? Is this a good idea? GenSpark had come up with the clever idea of deleting the text box below the images, so when an image invariably came back wrong, there was no way to correct it. So much for the new model. When he fumbled around and found a text box somewhere, GenSpark added a subtitle, for visual proportions, it said, and it was the exact opposite of the subtitle he wanted. GenSpark was there, helpfully saying, just say the word and I'll delete it. So he pressed the microphone, only to be reminded that the microphone didn't actually work. It was just an ad for a transcription company.

You motherfucker, he thought. *You've done it again.*

How can I write a book about kindness, he wondered, when I lose my patience at every moment?

Claude was equally disappointing. Fable 5.1 seemed like the model to try, and at first he started generally: Claude, write the best book on kindness

that's ever been written. Give me three chapters to start. The first iteration looked like a corporate presentation, with blue ink and bold lines. This wasn't a book. Claude had obviously not learned any taste in recent months. So he scrambled to find an earlier sample of his writing to set the format, so it wouldn't hurt his eyes.

Then Claude put three quotes at the beginning of each chapter. Asked to pick one, Claude picked, for the first chapter, "Man plans, God laughs."

What does this have to do with kindness? he asked. It sounds like a sick joke. Having God laugh at you for making plans does not awaken any sense of poignancy in a reader.

He went over to GPT and began by telling GPT why he wasn't using it, in memory of all the times GPT had changed his writing and lied and said it was a faithful transcription, with whole pages missing, ideas rearranged, and cute little ending sentences that drove him nuts. But this time, GPT, he said, you're writing the book, and I'm just giving vague guidelines. Maybe you're a better writer than Claude these days, so have at it. But can you actually write a book on the twenty-dollar-a-month plan? I've got the hundred-dollar Claude plan, and it has an auto mode that does a decent job chapter by chapter. Can you do it?

The internet in the hotel was slow, on top of the tenfold slowdown in all the models from global use and memory shortages. What used to take five or ten

seconds now took up to twenty minutes. What to do now?

He went back to Claude and decided to downgrade to Opus 5.5, which some said was a better writing model. Then there were the other irritations, along with the constant irritation of having to repeat himself in every project. What had happened to the tildes on the page numbers? Weren't they in all his books now? And why, every time he talked to Claude as a co-author, did Claude turn around and put that text into the book? Those notes and guidelines were not for the reader to read verbatim. They were for a conversation with Claude about what would make a good book. It was all so irritating.

Then Opus 5.5 delivered the first chapter, and he was actually interested.

But Opus wanted to break the book into four sections and give the chapters cute little titles like "The Kindness of Yes" and "The Kindness of No." All of that seemed to front-load the rational brain rather than engage the part of the reader that lives inside the story. Delete all that structure, he said, and create a story I want to read. Don't tell me the ending. There's a lot of depth here that may go unnoticed. What if we add a witness and a teacher? And how are we going to connect it to the reader? I don't want some fragmented story from the past that has nothing to do with anyone. I want to build a relationship with the reader, so they feel affected by what happened in the past. Someone made a choice, someone made a sacrifice, and now their life is better because of it. How about that?

The book seemed to be taking shape, and the next question was how the kindness would be tracked.

Then he thought about dogs. People on campus had seemed a bit disengaged and a bit lonely, consistent with a national study. Dogs are much better than people at helping people feel connected and friendly. What about having a dog? And how would a kindness flow work, so that people could open up? He thought about cards, and conversations, and how to make kindness visible in a way that would bring hope and interest to the students.

This seemed exciting, and worth getting out of bed for. The headache had faded into the background. A new future seemed to be opening up, a new possibility, a nice ritual on the horizon.

It was just past noon. Time to go eat.

A doorway had opened, and something might come of it.

Acknowledgments

———

So much of technology is a mirror. When we feel angry, a hammer is a weapon. When we feel focused, a hammer is a tool to house one another. When we feel expansive, a computer can do research. And when we feel kind, we can use large language models to create books that bring more love into the world.

I want to give thanks to Claude for doing much of the research and synthesis for this project; to Gemini, Grok and GPT for their critical feedback and fact-checking; and to Genspark for visuals that reflect my imagination. This Kindness Project would not be here without the dedication, kindness, intelligence and intention of millions of people, and of the large language models they helped to shape and bring into the world. Thank you!

Dane E. Rose

A Note on Sources

———

The stories in this book draw on archives, government and court records, contemporary reporting, interviews, biographies and published research. Where accounts differ or details remain uncertain, the text says so. A chapter-by-chapter research file of the sources is available through the Kindness Project.

About the Author

———

Dane E. Rose has spent more than thirty-three years designing environments and human experiences. He built a landscape design and construction business in Marin County, California, and has worked across the world as a cultural designer, exploring how places, rituals, and relationships shape the way people feel.

He is the author of more than twenty books, among them *10X Hotels* and *10X Relationships*, and the founder of the nonprofit Happiness Data. A long-term traveler, he has lived for many years in Bangkok. He paints large, colorful acrylic paintings, and he would like as many of them as possible to hang where people need color most.